GNAMMA RESEARCH · READING EDITION

Qawāʿid al-Tawḥīd and Tamhīd al-Qawāʿid

قواعد التوحيد · التمهيد في شرح قواعد التوحيد

English Reading

Abū Ḥāmid Muḥammad Turka al-Iṣfahānī · original matn
Ṣāʾin al-Dīn ʿAlī Ibn Turka · commentary (early fifteenth century)

A bilingual research reader of divine unity, existence, knowledge and manifestation.

Contents

Commentator’s introduction

Original text and commentary

Source-based working translation. Electronic Arabic–English comparison completed 11 November 2026; not an independently human-certified or manuscript-collated edition. The reported ancestral loss at QT-059 remains unreconstructed. Unresolved readings are recorded in the Study and Reference editions and the online comparison ledger.

Introduction to the commentary

Ṣāʾin al-Dīn Ibn Turka

Praise: manifestation and concealment

Praise belongs to God, who made the hidden recesses of the shadows of His majesty places where the lights of His beauty appear, unfolding in detail the governing properties previously gathered together; who made the forms of His self-disclosures rising-places for the suns of meanings, bringing to completion His universally bestowed favours. For His servants who enjoy His love, and for His adversaries who remain far from Him, these became respectively the horizons where the stars of knowledge rise and where the first gleams of gracious gifts set, answering the desire expressed by the tongue of preparedness. Glorified is He: hidden for no reason other than the utmost manifestation through the luminaries of His places of disclosure and the flashes of radiance called forth when lights emerge within their enveloping sheaths. Exalted is His affair: manifest for no reason other than the deep penetration of His being into the interiors of His veils and the depths of darkness that this entails. Hidden, yet scarcely concealed; manifest, yet scarcely appearing.

Blessings upon the Prophet and his family

Then blessings and peace upon Muḥammad: the horizon from which every good and perfection spreads, the one who inaugurates the beginnings of every opening and brings every completion to its close. That is the radiant light unmixed with the blemishes of shade or the obscuring deceptions of cloud. ‘Seek no shadow of otherness within his sun: it is sun, it is shadow, it is shade.’ And blessings upon his family, the niche that gathers all that is dispersed and the lamp that draws every ordered whole together.

Rational inference and experiential witnessing

To proceed: the question of divine unity, as established by those who witness and as witnessed by those who have attained realization through unveiling and direct vision, is one to which the reasoning of intellectual investigators occupied with arguments and demonstrations has not yet found its way—except for those whom God supports with a light from Himself and successfully guides to it. These combine the two ranks of rational inference and experiential witnessing, and possess the twin excellences of inferential knowledge from effects and unveiling of causes. Through their faithful following of the prophets, God has delivered them from the narrow confines of rhetorical and demonstrative premises into the open expanses of disclosures received through unveiling and addresses encountered in direct vision. Blessings upon all those prophets, who connect the subtle

links of realities from the very source of gathered unity to the domain of differentiation, and mediate the descent of meanings from the heaven of holiness to the level of their unfolding. This applies especially to those who take as their excellent example the first of the prophets in existence and rank and the last in time and mission: Muḥammad, blessings upon him and his family. He is the end of all ends, and his exalted legacy is the fountain of perfections and the source of felicities. Upon him and his family be the best blessings and most complete greetings.

Agreement between demonstration and revelation

Thus, when his noble friends undertake to establish the meanings of divine unity, you find them bringing rational demonstrations and transmitted divine laws into the fullest conceivable agreement. They dispel the difficulties raised by certain philosophers who fall short of reconciling what sound reasoning has yielded with the explicit revealed text. In the other sciences of reality and fields of certain knowledge, too, they expose the points at which those philosophers' reasoning breaks down and the places where their feet slip. Confusion is thereby disclosed for what it is, and the faint star is distinguished from the sun. All this is but a ray of sunlight dispersing a pitch-black night—or, to use the proverb, a familiar trait recognized in Akhzam.

The wider disclosure of once-concealed knowledge

Our age has now reached the fullness of its development. The great tree of its flourishing stands mature; the season has come to gather its fruit and to lift the veil from its hitherto secluded, untouched discoveries, through the traces shining upon the pages of its days in the heavenly revealed books and the lofty writings of unveiling. By my life, you will find that what the great masters attained only after exhausting and strenuous discipline over many days and nights has become a morsel on the tongues of the learned and the common alike. Matters whose disclosure once occasioned verdicts calling for the blood of great men are now as publicly known as the sun in broad daylight. In brief, the secrets of a sacred valley whose stages the perfected could tread only after removing both sandals, and whose protected precinct none could approach without folding both feet away—indeed, stripping away both faculties—can now be heard, as it were, from the sandals' own straps. Their elusive subtleties can be caught in the fine interweaving of the faculties themselves, as their fugitive realities are caught in the nets of apprehension. Through the faculties of estimation and intellect and the ordering of what they apprehend, under the favourable conditions of these times, the discerning person reaches them as readily as the clearest certainties and encounters them as the first self-evident truths. ‘How long will you gesture toward the two branches and the landmark, when the matter is clearer than a fire upon a hill?’

Ancient sages and the limitations of later disputation

Moreover, this alone was the position preferred by the earliest sages—those counted, according to the historians, among the chosen prophets and friends of God, peace be upon them: Agathodaimon, called Luqmān in the language of revelation; Hermes of the Hermeses, called Idrīs; Pythagoras, called Seth; and the divine Plato. But the later followers of the First Teacher, by whom I mean the Peripatetics, confined the reception and acquisition of true wisdom to argument alone and purely discursive inquiry. The dark veils of difficulties arising from the dialectical rules on which their procedures were founded then prevented them from discerning the truth of this clear question. What is astonishing is that anyone among them who proposes a fresh verification or a more exact investigation merely adds another denial or counterargument. Through the accumulation of contradictions their writings become a collection of darknesses piled upon one another, from whose gloom very few escape. ‘God did not wrong them; they were wronging themselves.’

Why the ancestor's treatise needs a commentary

As for the treatise composed by my master and ancestor Abū Ḥāmid Muḥammad al-Iṣfahānī, known as Turka—may his secret be sanctified—it contains decisive demonstrations and luminous arguments for the fundamental question, in accordance with the position of those who have attained realization. Through the subtlety of his exposition he went to great lengths to remove those doubts, and exerted himself to sweep away their impediments with the force of his explanations, leaving no trace of misgiving about these truths for anyone with even modest training in intellectual inquiry. Yet the depth of his penetration into philosophical wisdom and the elevated level of his demonstrations put his difficult objectives beyond the understanding of most students, and the foundations of his lofty insights beyond the grasp of many seekers of guidance. During discussions with some of my sincere companions in study, therefore, I sought to remove the veil of concision from the secluded meanings of his expressions through the clearest explanation. My purpose was to make their benefits more widely available and complete their valuable results: indicating the principal doctrines and fundamental rules of the people of unveiling, pointing to the crucial connections of their investigations and the general scope of their aims, preserving their customary terms and expressions, and respecting the relationships between their technical vocabulary and their metaphors. I wished to guard against an unintended meaning being understood and thereby producing confusion and corruption in the inquiry. Once completed, the work was entitled The Book of Preparation: Commentary on the Treatise Principles of Divine Unity.

The commentator's apology and programme

I am, however, living through an interval that keeps me away from sustained discussion, and occupations divert me from reading and learned debate. I therefore hope that anyone who encounters an oversight will cover it with the mantle of pardon. May God protect us and you from the paths of delusion and falsehood, guide us and you along the right way, and give us a draught sufficient to quench our thirst from the specifically Muḥammadan spring—upon him and his family be the finest and fullest blessings and the most comprehensive greetings. Since the argument of this treatise follows the method of those who reason by inference, it is appropriate to begin with a prolegomenon that presents its contents in outline and distinguishes the subject, principles, and questions proper to this science. In doing so we follow their example and their custom of placing such an account first. Thereafter we shall set out the treatise's purposes precisely and explain its benefits, God alone, the Mighty, willing.

The highest science and the example of music

As for the prolegomenon: know that the science considered here is unrestricted divine science, which is the highest science without qualification. Its subject must therefore be the most general of subjects in conception—indeed, the most comprehensively inclusive of concepts, the clearest in meaning, and the first in conception and intellection. For the theory of demonstration establishes that the superiority of sciences corresponds to the generality and comprehensiveness of their subjects. A science is highest without qualification only when its subject is more general than every other subject, so that the subjects of all the sciences are particular cases falling under it. An objection may be raised: that conclusion follows only if the subject of a subordinate science must always be narrower than the subject of a superior science. Yet the subjects may differ essentially, as music and arithmetic do: music is expressly subordinated to arithmetic despite the essential distinction between their subjects. We reply that the subordinate subject must fall under the superior and be narrower either in itself or under the aspect investigated; otherwise the science would not be subordinate. Music falls under arithmetic by reason of the aspect it studies. Although musical tones are qualities and thus differ from quantity as such, they become the subject of musical science only insofar as properties belonging to discrete quantity attach to them. Under that aspect, music necessarily falls under arithmetic. Nor should one object that this would permit the superior subject's generality to derive merely from an additional aspect rather than from itself, so that the demonstration would fail. Granting the proposed implication, the relevant aspect in our present case is not external to the subject: it is its very concept. Intrinsic generality therefore follows on either account.

Existence without restriction is not existence restricted to absoluteness

You may object: if the aspect under which the subject is considered is simply its concept and nature, the investigation must concern what belongs to existence insofar as it is existence. Its scope would then be confined to what depends on no matter either in its existence or in its definition. Anything dependent on matter in either respect has to be investigated under its particular aspect; otherwise it is not that thing which is being investigated. This would therefore be none other than the science called metaphysics. We reply: this would follow only if the subject adopted here were abstract, absolute existence. But if the subject is existence without restriction, with absoluteness itself not included as an additional qualification, all particularities and aspects—whether material or immaterial—fall within it. This will be explained in detail below.

Avicenna's subject of metaphysics and Ibn Turka's proposed distinction

You may say that this does not agree with what a survey of their writings reveals. The master of the Peripatetics, Ibn Sīnā—may his secret be sanctified—expressly states in the second chapter of the first book of the Metaphysics of the Healing that existent as existent is common to the categories and must be made the subject of that discipline. We reply that existentness, in the common sense in which they make it the subject of the discipline, encompasses all the categories insofar as it is predicated of them. But, on their account, the distinctive characteristics and aspects of each category are neither included within that common meaning nor predicated of it as identical with it. It is therefore an abstract meaning, not the meaning adopted as the subject of this science. In the latter sense, existentness is the very reality of those particularities and those very aspects: they are but the determination-forms distinguished through relations, correlations, and different considerations, as you will come to understand, God willing. Once this is grasped, the difference between the divine science discussed here and the divine science called metaphysics is precisely the difference between the unrestricted and the restricted.

Comprehensiveness, first intelligibility, and the difficulty of naming the subject

Rational division establishes that every concept falls under the subject of one of the three sciences: the science concerned with nature, the science beyond nature, or the science intermediate between them. Since the subject of the highest of those sciences itself falls under the subject of this science, the latter must be universally comprehensive in relation to all other concepts. It must also be the clearest in meaning and the first to be conceived. Were another concept clearer, it could not be the most general without qualification; otherwise what is particular would be clearer than what is general, which is impossible. Once it becomes clear that the other subjects fall under the subject of this science, the position of their questions and principles also becomes clear, since these are judgments concerning the subject and what makes those judgments evident. Yet expressing this all-

embracing meaning—the comprehensive concept from which nothing escapes and to which nothing stands opposed—is exceedingly difficult. Calling it absolute existence or the Real is to designate it through its most proper attribute, which here is the most general of concepts. Were a term available with a more comprehensive and clearer determinate meaning, it would be closer and more proper to the subject, and that alone would be the appropriate expression for the subject of unrestricted divine science.

Why the term existence is most comprehensive

Among the terms used here, none has a better claim to that role than existence. Its meaning is the most comprehensive of concepts, the clearest to conceive, and the first in intellection and occurrence. This can be shown in two respects. First, the meaning of the relation between generality and particularity is that an instance of the narrower concept possessing either mode of occurrence is included among the instances of the wider concept possessing that same mode, but not conversely. Any concept such that the generality of other concepts becomes actual only when they are qualified by one of its two divisions must therefore itself be the most general of concepts without qualification.

Why existence is most evident

Second, being evident or not evident likewise turns on whether something needs an intermediary in order to possess one of the two modes of occurrence or existence. What is preceded by something else in acquiring that qualification, and needs an intermediary for the qualifying relation, is remote from the occurrence in question and is called non-evident. The remoteness varies with the number of intermediaries. What is not preceded by another and requires no intermediary, but has that occurrence primarily and through itself, is close to it and is called evident. Now, that to which proximity makes what is related to it evident, while distance makes it non-evident, must be the clearest of concepts. Otherwise proximity would not explain evidence, nor its absence the lack of evidence. Existence is also the meaning closest to the Principle. Nothing is realized through itself or through another unless it is first conjoined with existence; nor does anything occur in itself or for another without that meaning first obtaining for it and its being realized through it. Hence, when those who have attained realization intend this subject, the word existence is clearer in indication and more frequent in their expressions than any other name or term.

Objection: how can an all-inclusive subject have proper predicates?

An objection may be raised. According to the customary account, the subject of a science is that whose proper essential accidents the science investigates: predicates outside the subject's essence which belong to it either through itself or through something coextensive with it, whether an intrinsic part or an extrinsic factor. But the names and realities

predicated of the subject here cannot belong to it by such an attachment. On your account the subject is itself those names and realities, and nothing at all lies outside it. Even if attachment is conceded, why should it arise through the subject itself or through something coextensive with it? If it did, no attached predicate could be separated from the general subject. The subject would then not be more general than the predicates of its propositions, and there would be no greater reason to choose it as subject than any other coextensive concept. Moreover, according to the principles of the people of realization, all the names and realities are required by the essence itself, in itself and for itself. They cannot be separated from it, since what the essence requires cannot fail to accompany it. How, then, can the concept indicating that essence be more general and comprehensive than those names and realities?

Reply: common identity and distinguishing determinations

We reply that a preliminary point must first be understood. The generality of a concept is conceived only in relation to the particulars falling under it. But those particulars admit two considerations. First, the universal concept is truly predicated of them as what they are and encompasses them all. Under this consideration they add nothing to that concept itself. Second, they have distinctive realities and relational, conceptually considered particularities by which each differs from everything else. Under this consideration they are neither that concept itself nor included in it, but are matters outside its conceptual content that belong to it through itself. For the distinguishing character of the all-encompassing meaning is precisely its inclusiveness and comprehensiveness. That character requires it to admit the attachment of all other concepts without excluding any particularities, even when those particularities oppose, succeed, or exclude one another. Such is what comprehensive inclusion requires, as you will see. This accords with the masters' description of absolute identity as the gathering-place of opposites. The same subtle point will recur in the treatise, so the discerning reader should keep it in mind. It now becomes clear that, under this consideration, the names and realities are attached predicates suitable for investigation, while that to which they belong is suitable as the subject. Even if their coextension with the subject is conceded, this does not disqualify it from being their subject, just as coextensive properties and necessary concomitants can be investigated in relation to specific natures.

A divine name can be present without its operation predominating

They do indeed maintain that the essence of itself requires all the names and that each name encompasses the essence under all its considerations. Yet the names differ in the manifestation of their governing effects within receptive loci. In some manifestations the predominant name, judged by the appearance of its effects, may be universal; in others it may be particular. The predominant name is the one that appears and qualifies that manifestation, while the effects of the other names are absorbed beneath the ruling effect

of its governing name. The comparison is with composite natures which we call hot or cold. Thus a reality's intrinsically requiring a name, and that name's inseparability from it in existence, do not entail that the name's effect is manifest in every form of the reality's determination or that it qualifies all those forms alike.

Conceptual and assertoric first principles

As for the principles proper to this science: its conceptual principles consist in conceiving the fundamental realities necessarily accompanying the existence of the Real, glorified is He. Among the people of this discipline these are called the names of the essence; next come the names of attributes, then the names of acts and the names of the relations and correlations obtaining among them. Its assertoric principles consist in judging that these realities are established in themselves, or that certain necessary concomitants are established of them.

How the principles of the highest science become known

One may object that principles must either be evident through themselves or have been established in a higher science and accepted in the science that uses them. Since these realities are not self-evident, they must be established in a higher science; but you have said that there is no science higher than this one. We reply that the principles—the realities discussed here—likewise become known in either of two ways. They may become known through their effects appearing in the world and the knower witnessing those effects and governing properties by sense and intellect, or by intellectual intuition and unveiling, and learning from them. This corresponds to what is self-evident in the formally organized sciences. Alternatively, they are received from someone whose unveiling is higher and more complete, such as the perfected among the prophets and friends of God. This corresponds to what has been established in a higher science.

A criterion for distinguishing disclosure from deception

It should not be objected that this is sound only if they possess a criterion by which what is correct in this science can be distinguished from what is not, as in the other theoretical sciences, so that what is received can be tested by its proper measure; otherwise, mere imitation affords no reliable foundation in the sciences of reality. We deny that they lack such an instrument. The people of realization who possess unveiling maintain that there is a suitable measure and degree corresponding to each person and time. Thus they disclose certain realities to one person while withholding them from another, and withhold them at one time from someone to whom they reveal them at another. Without this, a person could not distinguish a genuine divine communication from corrupt satanic suggestion.

The questions of this science and their demonstrations

The questions investigated here concern the levels and domains to which these realities and names relate, the assignment of each to its proper domain and source, and the detailed articulation of its particular governing properties and relations. Each name has a domain proper to it; in their technical framework this is what is meant by the divine names' tawqīfī character—their being authoritatively fixed. You may ask: in every science, a question is something demonstrated within that science. Where there is no demonstration, how can there be a question in this technical sense? I reply that a demonstration is an arrangement of certain principles, whether self-evident or accepted, which leads to the judgment sought—the judgment called the question. You have now learned what corresponds in this science to those two sorts of principles. Whatever is established by combining them in the pursuit of scientific inquiries and knowledge of reality constitutes one of its questions.

Why the analogy with formal sciences is useful but limited

Besides, all these are conventional rules of the formally constituted sciences, which are particular and restricted. Their application to unrestricted universal science does not follow of necessity. The characteristic proper to what is unrestricted differs from the characteristics of its particular instances, and the judgments belonging to the particulars need not apply to the universal that applies to them. What must hold is the application of the judgments of the unrestricted universal to its particulars, not the reverse. Nevertheless, since the argument in this treatise is built upon the method of reflective investigation and inference, undertaking these correspondences is not altogether outside the bounds of a reasonable exposition.

Do not confuse the vocabularies of philosophers and people of realization

Know that certain terms used here have different meanings in the conventions of reflective investigators and of those who have attained realization. A newcomer becomes confused by mixing these two terminologies and substituting one for the other. To make the inquiry precise, we must therefore first draw attention to the two meanings under the two conventions. One such term is existence. For reflective investigators it denotes being in external things, or being without further qualification. Although being is synonymous with existence in their terminology, they consider it appropriate to explain simple natures of this kind by a clearer term: a verbal explanation intended to direct attention, rather than a definition through constituent parts.

Quiddities and the distinction between hypothetical and real existence

Since, on their account, existence is additional to the quiddities of existing things, and no quiddity is realized without being conjoined with existence and entering one of the forms of occurrence, whether real or conceptually posited, they pictured the relation of quiddities to existence as like the relation of bodies to spatial location. Just as each body has a natural affinity with a particular place and does not depart from that kind of place, so, they thought, quiddities stand in relation to existence. Some are realized only through intellectual supposition: they exist solely in the cognitive faculties, as do conceptually posited relations and correlations. This kind is called hypothetical existence, and conceptually posited matters are its subjects. Others are realized independently of supposition and conceptual consideration, whether or not an intellectual supposition is made. This is called real existence, or existence in the order of things as they are—nafs al-amr.

Real existence can include mental existence

Within this latter division, some things also exist externally; their existence is called external existence, that is, existence outside the faculties of awareness. Others are realized within those faculties, such as real relations and correlations and the other matters occurring at the second level of intellection. It should not be objected that these must therefore belong to hypothetical existence because they occur only in the cognitive faculties. We reply that, although they occur in those faculties, they are not confined to them: they also have existence outside them and so belong to real existents. The point of the division is this: whatever intellect conceives either admits existence in itself or does not. What does not belongs to hypothetical existents; what does is a real existent. The latter either possesses that existence specifically outside the faculties of awareness or does not. The first is the external existent; the second is the mental existent.

True judgments about a nonexistent Zayd and two meanings of external

It follows that the mental existents just mentioned are kinds of real existent and of existent in nafs al-amr. Nafs al-amr is therefore broader than the external: whatever is realized externally is realized in nafs al-amr, but not everything realized in nafs al-amr is realized externally. The humanity of a Zayd who does not exist outside the mind, for example, is established in nafs al-amr without being realized externally. An objection may be raised: how can the humanity of this nonexistent Zayd be judged true, and his being a donkey false, when there is no external counterpart at all? A true statement, unlike a false one, is precisely one that has an external counterpart. We reply that external is equivocal. Sometimes it means what obtains independently of the intellect's act of consideration, as when we say that a report has a counterpart in reality or lacks one. In that use it is synonymous with nafs al-amr. At other times it means what stands in contrast to mental

existence, as in our present division. This second meaning is narrower than the first. Consequently, a statement's lacking a counterpart in the external in the narrower sense does not entail that it lacks a counterpart in the broader sense.

Can nafs al-amr be explained by a universal intellect?

One should not object that necessity dictates that anything existent which does not exist in the cognitive faculties must exist outside them, or else not exist at all; hence a third order beyond these two, called nafs al-amr, requires its existence to be demonstrated. We reply that one attempted demonstration proceeds as follows. Rational principles establish an externally existing, self-subsistent being without spatial position, actually containing all intelligibles capable of becoming actual. Neither it nor those intelligibles can change, undergo alteration, newly arise, or cease; it and they possess these characteristics eternally. This is called the universal intellect, and the Preserved Tablet is taken to refer to it. A later thinker objected by citing the Necessary and the intellects: on this account, they would have no existence in nafs al-amr. He then proposed an account whose gist was that nafs al-amr means the realities of things according to their own essences, abstracting from matters external to them. But this explanation only adds obscurity—unless his words are understood in the ancient sense that all intelligible forms and meanings are represented and established in that intellect itself, as the people of realization maintain. Since the objector denies that position, however, his statement cannot be interpreted in this way.

The higher world and the passage attributed to the Theology

The appropriate explanation on their method is that nafs al-amr denotes that in which true forms and meanings are established: the higher world, the world of immaterial beings. Calling it the world of the Command supports this understanding. Every true meaning or form must have a corresponding reality there. An exposition of this may be discerned in what the teacher of the Peripatetics, Aristotle, says in the eighth discourse of the work on divine science called the Theology. Having explained that the higher world is the complete living being containing all things, and that the sensible world is like its image and model, he says that the Real's first act is the First Intellect. For that reason it possesses a power possessed by nothing else, and every substance after it is an effect of it. On this account, all things are intellect and intellect is all things, because intellect contains all their universals, attributes, and forms. Everything that has been or will be corresponds to what is in the First Intellect, just as the cognitions within our souls correspond to the entities that exist; it cannot be otherwise. Were we to allow a difference or disparity between the forms in our souls and the forms in existence, we would neither know those forms nor apprehend their realities. For a thing's reality is that through which it is what it is; without this, what is apprehended would be something else, and what is other than the thing is its negation. Thus everything the soul apprehends and conceives of existing entities is those entities themselves, though in one mode here and another there. I have reproduced this entire

discussion because, besides bearing on our present question, it clarifies reality, truth and the real, the reason for calling this mode of existence real existence, and other subtle matters. Reflect upon it.

Why appeal to earlier masters in a rational investigation?

Know that most of this book's discussions, being remote from ordinary dispositions and unfamiliar to minds, incorporate passages from the masters. They will be exposed to the scrutiny of those who reason by inference, among whom a perceptive critic is seldom found. It is therefore necessary to mention authorities on whom such readers can rely, in keeping with their customary ways of learning and teaching, so that their hearts may acquire some confidence. Perhaps God will use the keys of that assent and faith to open for them the doors of truth and certainty, for He is the clear Opener. Otherwise, discussions of this kind do not properly rest on citations of transmitted statements, just as the construction of rational demonstrations does not require them. All the foregoing has been according to the view of reflective investigators and reasoners. The remaining terms, whose conventional meanings are familiar among them and not liable to confusion, need not be discussed here.

Existence in the vocabulary of realization: Ibn Arabi's circle treatise

For those who have attained realization, however, existence is not something additional to existing things. Rather, existing things are its specific particularizations, of which it is predicated as what they are: its determinate varieties, distinguished merely through relations and the states that accrue to them in accordance with the faculties of apprehension and awareness. The very entities of these realities are their own identity and existence, and nothing else. The detailed sense emerges from the discussion of the Shaykh, may God have mercy on him, in his work called The Construction of Circles: ‘Know that existence and nonexistence are not something additional to the existent and the nonexistent. Yet estimation imagines them as attributes referring to the existent and nonexistent, and imagines them as a house into which things have entered. Hence one says that something entered existence after not having been. What the people of realization mean is that the thing came to exist in its own entity: existence and nonexistence express the affirmation and negation of the entity itself. Once the entity is affirmed or denied, it may be qualified by existence and nonexistence together, through relation and correlation. Thus Zayd, who exists in himself, is present in the market and absent from the house. Were existence and nonexistence intrinsic attributes like blackness and whiteness, it would be impossible to qualify him by both: if nonexistent, he would not be existent, just as if black he would not be white. Yet he can correctly be described as existent and nonexistent at the same time. This is relative existence and relative nonexistence, while the entity itself is established. Once it is clear that this is neither an attribute subsisting in a subject nor a subject intelligible on its own without relation, it is established that it belongs wholly to

relations and correlations, like east and west, right and left, front and back…’ Here ends his own noble wording.

Why merely relational existentness does not exhaust real existence

Give thought free rein over the implications of these words and examine their inner content carefully. It will become clear that what later thinkers understood by the term existence, and made their convention when they treated it as an intellectual consideration attaching mentally to existents, is not the real existence on which the doctrines and fundamental commitments of the people of realization are based, nor one of its proper real attributes. It is merely a relation that does not enter into the reality of existence at all. The source of their error and the point at which they slipped thus become apparent. What is especially astonishing is that the author of the Philosophy of Illumination argues for existence's conceptual status by using precisely the relational meaning described by the Shaykh, may God have mercy on him. He treats ‘Zayd exists in the market’, ‘Zayd exists in the house’, ‘Zayd exists in the mind’, and ‘Zayd exists in external reality’ as having one and the same meaning: the relation just mentioned. By arguments of this kind he confines the meaning of existence to the relational sense. This question will receive further examination below, God willing.

Kawn and the two considerations of unity

As for the term kawn, the Shaykh says in his explanation of the vocabulary of the people of God that it means every existential affair. To establish the sense of this statement requires a preliminary point of great importance: unity admits two considerations. One belongs to it intrinsically; under this consideration it is called absolute and real unity. It is a thing's being such that its concept includes nothing suggesting a plurality of aspects or any duality at all. Even the non-consideration of multiplicity is not included in the concept, since that would suggest an opposition to multiplicity and thus entail duality. The one under this consideration stands opposed to nothing, and nothing stands opposed to it. It is therefore not opposed to the many and is not the one considered in numbers. The saying ‘God is one, not numerically’ points to this meaning. The second consideration attaches to unity incidentally; under it unity is called relational or relative unity. It is a thing's not being divided in itself into multiple items insofar as it is so considered. This is the one said to stand in an accidental opposition to the many.

Genuine multiplicity and the objection from a common negation

Multiplicity likewise admits two considerations. One belongs to it intrinsically; under this consideration it is called genuine multiplicity. It consists in the multiple things being considered without anything suggesting a unifying aspect or a common element. Even the

non-consideration of unity is not itself included, since that would suggest a unifying aspect. An objection may be raised: the non-consideration of a unifying aspect is itself a unifying aspect in which the members of the multiplicity can share. Similarly, excluding whatever suggests a plurality of aspects introduces a plurality of aspects into the concept of absolute unity. For that exclusion is a negative concept attached to unity in relation to something else, and must therefore differ from its reality; a plurality of aspects follows after all.

How an unknown reality can be conceived through an indicative aspect

We reply that intellect can posit aspects through which to conceive the realities of things whose realities are unknown in themselves, and can refer to them through those aspects. This remains possible even when, under an external consideration, those aspects conflict with the realities concerned. Consider the statement, ‘No judgment can be made about what is wholly unknown.’ Here a known description is posited for the wholly unknown reality, through which it is conceived and judged, even though being known in this manner conflicts with that reality considered as wholly unknown. You may ask how one of two incompatible things can be conceived through the other and judged under its aspect. The aspect by which a thing is known and judged must be a description truly predicable of it as what it is. I reply that descriptions admit two considerations. First, they may be considered according to their natures in themselves; under this consideration there is no incompatibility between them and their subjects, and they must be truly predicable of those subjects. Second, they may be considered together with the features that accrue to them through occurring in intellect. Incompatibility arises only under this second consideration. This is plain in the example: the nature of unknownness, considered just in itself, is not incompatible with its subject. Otherwise it would not be that subject's description or be truly predicated of it.

Universality and the intellect's power to abstract from its own conditions

If, however, the description is considered together with the identity it acquires by occurring in intellect, an incompatibility between it and its subject arises through that incidental identity, which belongs to it only by an extrinsic consideration. Features that accrue to things through circumstances outside their own natures do not enter into their intrinsic judgments or the properties they possess through themselves. Otherwise no concept could remain universal when conceived, since whatever occurs in intellect is, considered in that occurrence, a particular. It belongs to God's consummate wisdom that He has given intellect a special power and innate capacity to conceive the concepts present in it just as they are, stripped of the features arising from their incidental occurrence and the restrictions dependent on particular receptacles. Intellect can thereby distinguish the true judgments that belong to them as they are—the judgments making their constitution intelligible and distinguishing them in themselves—from the other features that accrue to them through their loci of appearance and degrees. Thus it can conceive things as they are

in existence and become illumined by realities as they are. This power is among the effects of the First Intellect, of which we said earlier that it is the Real's first act, and among the forms of its determinations in this realm. Take heed.

Relative multiplicity and four ways of considering manifestation

The second consideration of multiplicity is what is called relative or relational multiplicity: a thing's being such that it is divided into multiple items insofar as it is so considered. The difference between this consideration and the incidental consideration of unity is evident. With this established, we say that true, one existence appears through its own essential light, which discloses it in respect of the hiddenness of its absolute identity. When the pluralities appearing in its locus of disclosure are considered—pluralities consisting in the multiple affairs of the self-disclosing reality, as will be established in its proper place, God willing—four considerations arise across the two presences: genuine unity and genuine multiplicity, and conceptually considered relational unity and relational multiplicity.

The Real, creation, divine names, and fixed entities

When genuine unity is considered in the two presences distinguished by hiddenness and manifestation, the designation is the Real. When genuine multiplicity is considered in them, the designations are creation, otherness, loci of manifestation, forms, affairs, and the like. When relational unity is considered—taking them all as relations returning to one entity—they are called the names and states of the Real. When relational multiplicity is considered—taking that plurality insofar as it stands in some relation to the comprehensive principle, and conceiving it as unified but stripped of existential coloration—it is the affair referred to earlier as related to existence. It is called kawn, the reality signified by the cosmos, its fixed entity, and similar names.

How the two vocabularies overlap without coinciding

It follows that kawn, in the meaning adopted by the people of realization, differs from existence in their terminology. For the reflective investigators, by contrast, the two are coextensive—indeed synonymous, as explained above. The two meanings of existence therefore overlap without either simply containing the other: they coincide in real quiddities, while diverging in divine realities and cosmic forms. It should not be objected that, for the reflective investigators, a quiddity does not exist in itself and therefore cannot provide a case in which the two meanings coincide. The discussion concerns real, existing quiddities, which under that consideration can indeed provide such a case. Between the two meanings of kawn, on the other hand, there is unrestricted inclusion of the narrower in the wider. The preceding account has also shown that unity admits two considerations.

Unrestrictedness, manifest existence, and necessity

Know, then, that the genuine consideration of unity is the meaning of unrestrictedness which belongs to existence through itself and which existence primarily requires. It is one of existence's evident and necessary properties. Wherever the reality of existence appears, it appears only through this unrestrictedness, and its governing properties are realized only under that consideration. This is what the people of realization mean by the manifest aspect of existence, for what is manifest in a thing is that through which the thing is first apprehended. Necessity points to this aspect.

Relational unity, knowledge, and possibility: end of the prolegomenon

The second consideration, the relational one, is that in which the subtle connections returning to the single entity are taken into account. It belongs to existence only after knowledge's belonging to existence has been considered. It is therefore what the nature of knowledge primarily requires and through which its governing properties become manifest. Possibility points to this aspect. There is a noble and subtle point here that becomes apparent through reflection. This discussion and the other terms used by the people of this discipline will receive further explanation and investigation in the course of the commentary, God alone, the Mighty, willing. We shall therefore not prolong the prolegomenon with them.

Matn and commentary

QT-001 — Opening: the difficulty of tawḥīd

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds, and blessings upon His Prophet Muḥammad and his family. To proceed: setting forth the question of divine unity (tawḥīd) in the manner adopted by those who possess gnosis (ʿārifūn) and indicated by those who have attained realization (muḥaqqiqūn) is among the difficult questions that the thoughts of disputatious speculative scholars cannot reach, nor the minds of learned philosophical investigators grasp.

SH-001 — The two objectives announced in the opening

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: know that this opening formula, besides containing what ought to be placed first when composing and arranging a book, also indicates the treatise's purposes in outline, as the art of instruction and explanation requires. Its discussion returns to two objectives.

The first is to establish the unity and necessity of existence without restriction, and to confine to it the attributes of perfection that deserve praise. The author's words, ‘Praise belongs to the one entitled to it’, point to this objective.

The second is to establish that, although all existents are manifestations of the unrestricted reality just mentioned, that reality appears in the totality of its levels and the unity of its comprehensiveness only in individuals of the human specific reality who realize those levels through spiritual taste and witnessing. Among them is the one distinguished within this manifestation and mirroring by the excellence of sealing and completion—blessings and peace upon him and his family. The words ‘and blessings upon His Prophet’ point to this.

The expression ‘the position adopted by the knowers’ refers to the later Muḥammadan friends of God—God's blessings and peace upon them, and His good pleasure—who explicitly disclosed this teaching, openly composed and recited it in poetry and prose, and established it for discerning readers through transmitted evidence and rational argument. The expression ‘to which those who have attained realization alluded’ refers to their predecessors, such as the prophets, peace upon them, and their disciples among the friends of God: the Hermetic sages and the ancient philosophers. In most of their expressions they intended it only by symbol and intimation, responding in each age to its people's capacities of apprehension and descending to the successive levels of their understanding. They indicated it only through an allusion containing a measure of concealment, so that the comprehensive character of their speech could benefit both the learned and ordinary people.

By ‘reflective investigators among the disputants’, he may mean the theologians, just as ‘accomplished researchers’ is intended to refer to a group among the Peripatetic philosophers.

QT-002 — The opponents’ psychological objection

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> For most of them suppose that certainty about it points to a firmly established disturbance of temperament in the bodily substrates of the faculties of the soul, the burning up of sound bodily materials, and the domination of black bile over the noble primary organs. For, they maintain, no one could become convinced that every rational, sensory, innate, and instinctive judgement is invalid—after undertaking arbitrary exertions and spiritual disciplines arising from imaginary obsessions—unless that newly arising cause had supervened and he had been afflicted by the malignant illness just described.

SH-002 — The opponent's physiological objection and its proposed inference

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: know that it is the author's custom, as a survey of his other books shows, first to present an opponent's position and its supporting argument in the strongest formulation when establishing a theoretical conclusion. He strives as far as possible to secure its foundations and reinforce its connections. Only then does he explain the sources of its doubts and confusions and cut off the grounds of its specious arguments. He intended to follow that customary procedure in this treatise. He therefore began with what an opponent might use to demonstrate the unsoundness of the practitioners' path to their sought-for unveilings and experiential knowledge: the path called purification and emptying oneself. Its status here corresponds to the question of whether reasoning yields knowledge on the inferential path, and so it must precede the remaining investigations and discussions.

The objection can be stated as follows. Certainty that this doctrine is true indicates that the temperaments of the bodily substrates of the soul's faculties—the bases of cognition—have deviated from their original condition. Indeed, a disordered temperament has become firmly established in them, and a condition requiring treatment has persisted. Otherwise the person would not have become utterly certain of it. The preparatory cause and the path leading to that certainty would consequently be a malfunction of the cognitive faculties. Any path consisting in their malfunction is plainly a path to ignorance and deficiency, far from leading to certain sciences and genuine perfections.

You may ask how one can infer a deviation in the temperaments of the faculties' substrates, which belongs to bodily qualities, from certainty in knowledge, which belongs to psychic

qualities. We reply that this is an inference from the presence of an effect to the realization of its cause, called a demonstration from the effect—burhān al-inn—among reflective investigators.

The causal connection is readily explained. A malfunction in the substrates of the soul's faculties—that is, the bodily organs serving as cerebral instruments of thought—causes a malfunction in what is apprehended through them. These organs stand to the discriminating insight that judges things as they are as the parts and layers of the eye stand to the power of sight. A defect in an eye's part similarly produces a defect in what it perceives. Every act of cognition mediated by a bodily instrument must involve the operation of a subtle connection and an encompassing correspondence between the nature of that instrument and the kind of cognition concerned. Otherwise that cognition would not be assigned to that instrument rather than to another. Deviation of the instrument's temperament from its balanced condition must therefore annul the operation of this connection: the operation of a thing necessarily ceases when the thing is absent. Cognition becomes disordered and corrupted in proportion to the loss of correspondence. Whenever the temperament deviates, its apprehensions consequently deviate from their sound origin and straight course, especially when the deviation becomes entrenched and persistent.

It should not be objected that this argument works only for particular forms and meanings apprehended by the soul through bodily faculties and material instruments. When the issue concerns universals intelligized without any such instrument, how can the inference hold? We reply that, even granting that this question belongs to universals, we do not grant that the soul intelligizes every universal without an instrument. Some universals are intelligized through instruments after being abstracted from particulars by removing individuating features. Such a universal is called the universal after multiplicity. Even granting the broader claim, we still do not grant that the inference rests merely on apprehending this doctrine itself. It rests instead on what the doctrine is supposed to entail: the cancellation of observations and first principles. Hence the author argues with the words ‘since certainty in the invalidity of all rational judgments…’.

The explanation given is that certainty that the doctrine of unity is invalid amounts to certainty in the invalidity of all classes of certain cognition: rational judgments established by demonstration and those carrying their syllogisms with them; sensory judgments belonging to observation; primordial judgments belonging to first principles; and instinctive judgments belonging to immediate awareness. For, on the opponents' assumption, judging quiddities to be distinct and determinate things to differ—as those premises require—is incompatible with accepting a doctrine that removes the judgments of differentiation and distinction.

Furthermore, when the signs of an illness appear after its causes have been undertaken, sound intellectual intuition and a well-directed mind conclude that the illness has arisen. The author therefore follows the argument with ‘after engaging in spiritual exertions and indiscriminate disciplines’. These mean excessive sleeplessness and hunger, which are said

to give black bile ascendancy over the principal cerebral organs. Those organs sustain the other intellectual cognitions, the primary source of the form constitutive of the human specific reality.

QT-003 — Reversing the objection

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> But since the matter was contrary to what they supposed—indeed, the reverse of what they imagined—…

SH-003 — Reversing the objection—and acknowledging the disputed premise

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this is because what the opponents took as evidence of a disordered temperament in the substrates of the soul's faculties is instead evidence of those temperaments' health and soundness. When the apprehensions of the cognitive faculties and organs of awareness agree with things as they are, and their judgments concern things as they really are, this indicates the soundness of their substrates' temperaments. For the unimpaired issuing of operations from their substrates indicates their health. The situation in the proposed inference is therefore contrary to what the critics supposed—indeed, the reverse of what they imagined. What they offered as evidence of a disordered temperament in those who possess certain conviction of the true doctrine actually indicates an entrenched disorder in the cognitive substrates of those who fall short of that degree.

Every faculty and principle, whether natural, animal, or psychic, is assigned an end proper to it. When that end fails to follow from it, the failure is due to a supervening disorder that has diverted its temperament from its original condition. Were the temperament left to its own nature, free from impediments, it would proceed to its completion and its end would follow. The end of the soul's cognitive faculties is unquestionably to apprehend things as they are. When that end fails, a disordered temperament has therefore intervened. Thus the alleged incidence of disorder is the reverse of what the opponents imagined.

You may object that treating the doctrine of unity in the stated sense as an apprehension of things as they are, and as the end sought by the soul's faculties, is precisely the point at issue and the disputed claim. How can it therefore serve as an acceptable argument on the opponents' own method? We reply: let these propositions be provisionally accepted and laid down here, until they are demonstrated in their appropriate places in the course of the treatise. This follows the customary procedure for establishing theoretical conclusions.

QT-004 — The purpose of the treatise and exhortation

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> I wished to write a treatise in which I would make clear the truth of the doctrine of those who possess gnosis and the falsity of the claim made by its detractors and deniers. It would contain the choicest of what became evident to me through intuitive insight (ḥads) concerning this question, and the distilled outcome of what my reflection reached in that controversy. We resolved to set forth the question according to the method of disputation, to engage the detractors in debate, and to establish it by powerful proofs with which to repel the deniers' objections and strengthen the seekers' desire. O God, place us among those who are saved and victorious, not among the misguided and rejected. Brothers who seek attainment: hasten to acquire true perfection and everlasting abiding before inevitable dissolution and bodily passing overtake you. Make haste during your life, before natural death comes upon you. Seek His help in every affair and place your trust in Him, if you are believers.

SH-004 — Intellectual intuition, acquired learning, and enduring perfection

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: know that the author habitually ascribes all experiential or unveiled meanings, despite the different expressions used for them, to intellectual intuition, following the convention of reflective investigators. In their classification there is nothing opposed to discursive thought except intellectual intuition, as will be established later. The remaining expressions in this passage are clear.

He addresses the exhortation specifically to 'companions in acquired learning', meaning those who have become discerning through the method of reflective investigation. Their preparedness is close to the acquisition of experiential knowledge, and they are fit to receive the effusion of genuine perfections. For they have ascended from imaginal forms and sensory particulars to intellectual meanings and universal cognitions, and have escaped entrenched habits of uncritical acceptance. Such habits make the intellect confuse the judgments of estimative particulars with universal realities and admit conjectural and estimative judgments alongside certain and intellectual ones.

Yet these investigators fall short of genuine perfection when they restrict perfection itself to recalling particular technical conventions impressed in bodily instruments and corporeal faculties. Those conventions pass away with their bodily substrates when the elemental constitution comes to an end. Their intellectual ascent has consequently not benefited them to the fullest extent. The matn's placing everlasting subsistence immediately after genuine perfection points to this meaning.

QT-005 — Existence is common in meaning, not merely in word

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Know that existence (wujūd) is common to all particular existences—not in respect of the word alone, but in respect of the meaning—as we have explained in our other writings.

SH-005 — The shared meaning and reality of existence: quotations from the ancestor's philosophical works

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: since the reality of existence is evident both as to whether it is and as to what it truly is, as was indicated previously, the author begins with its properties. He gives priority to its being common in meaning, because this is the property nearest to the reality itself and the basis of the other properties and investigations intended here, such as necessity and unity.

Although the self-evidence of the reality entails the self-evidence of its common meaning, the author offers several reminders to deepen insight. Among them is this: if the self-evidently known concept of existence were not common to all existents, supposing its absence from them all would not entail the complete absence of them all. But that consequence is false. We necessarily know that whatever wholly lacks the self-evidently known meaning of being is altogether absent.

It should not be objected that what the author established in his other books was merely the common meaning of existence according to Peripatetic terminology, since his discussion there engages the Peripatetics on their own method. That, one might say, cannot establish the common meaning of existence in the sense at issue here, given the distinction between the two terminologies. We reply that the author's intended meaning of existence is the real one accepted by the people of realization, not the merely conceptual one adopted by some later thinkers. After exposing the weakness and disorder in the foundations of the latter view, and the breakdown of principles and loss of consistency following from it, he establishes in several places that what we mean by existence is a real meaning. Anyone who reflects on his explanation, with certain and well-grounded knowledge of the principles of the discipline, will not hesitate to recognize the truth of this difficult inquiry.

In al-Iʿtimād, after answering the arguments of the Master of Illumination and others for existence's merely conceptual status, the ancestor writes: ‘Once this is understood, we say: if this eminent thinker means that realization in external things does not possess a further external realization additional to itself, that is true. But it does not follow that this realization is itself merely conceptual. If he means that some conceptual meaning necessarily accompanies its reality, and that joining the two produces a conceptual aggregate, we do not dispute this either; it still does not follow that existence itself is conceptual. If, however, he means that external realization itself is an intellectual consideration, this is plainly not so. Each externally existing quiddity has realization and external identity. If that realization and identity are additional to it, external realization must itself be real, since that through which a real thing is constituted and realized must be

real. If they are the quiddity itself, then this realization, being common to all, must be either those quiddities themselves or a part of them. It cannot be merely conceptual.

‘Furthermore, if external existence had no external realization, the quiddities occurring externally would be just the same as those occurring mentally, since mental occurrence is even more appropriately classed as conceptual. There would then be no difference between mental and external quiddities except by consideration. If existence were a purely intellectual meaning, either production would have to be denied or quiddities themselves would have to be what is produced.

‘Again, we apprehend realization in external things. It is impossible for that realization not to be externally realized; it therefore is externally realized. One may object that the same reasoning would establish that the existence of a newly occurring thing which does not exist at present cannot fail to be existence; it would consequently exist and would not now be nonexistent. We reply that we do not concede the falsity of the proposed conclusion. Existence does not admit nonexistence, just as it does not receive existence. Rather, it is a quiddity that admits nonexistence, and it becomes nonexistent through the cessation of its conjunction with existence. The truth is that external existence is self-evidently conceived, and its realization in external things is likewise self-evidently known. Doubt here may arise not from subtlety and concealment but from extreme clarity and disclosure.

‘Know that a discerning reader familiar with the principles of the discipline, who comprehends all the discussions offered here, may thereby discern the truth of this issue. An explicit account of what powerful intellectual intuition and clear demonstration attest is found in our book entitled al-Ḥikma al-Manīʿa.’

Likewise, in one passage of al-Ḥikma al-Rashīdiyya, he says: ‘If you make external existence like the other negations and relations, let us treat all the remaining concepts in the same way—indeed, they have a stronger claim to be classified as conceptual considerations. We shall then make existence itself the real basis of everything other than it in external things.’

In another passage there he says: ‘There is no doubt that quiddities' being qualified by external existence in external things requires that existence to occur externally. The case is different for that whose reality is this very existence or a ground entailing it. Discerning minds may be confused here, not because the issue is hidden and obscure, but because it is so manifest…’ Here ends his wording.

Anyone who removes the veil from these passages, from which the lights of verification shine, will not doubt that the meaning of existence indicated by the author differs from the opinions of later philosophers, particularly the Peripatetics. It should not be objected: how can that be, when he plainly follows their steps in clarifying their aims and arranging their demonstrations, before refuting some and critically examining others? Such a procedure, one might say, requires agreement between the two terminologies and conventions.

We reply that his indication of his own position comes after he has first accommodated their customary discourse, proceeded on the principles of their discipline, and refined and established their case as fully as possible. He then exposes the resulting defects and breakdowns, supported by demonstrations untouched by the blemishes of imagination. This does not deprive the inquiry of coherence. Moreover, the dispute in this case is not merely verbal. The meaning they regard as conceptual is the very one the author establishes as real by the foregoing arguments; conversely, the quiddities they regard as real are, for him, relations and conceptual considerations.

They restrict the term existence, throughout its degrees and divisions, to what has one of the two modes of being, while extending it to things possessing external being. Their usage thus differs from that of the people of realization through a relation of generality and particularity, as indicated in the introduction. As for the author's position as discerned from his other writings, the distinction is by particularity alone, not by generality. Once this is understood, his engagement with them and his argument against them are sound: what is established of the more general must also be established of the more particular.

QT-006 — The necessity of the reality of existence

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> It is evident that the reality of existence, considered just as it is in itself, does not intrinsically admit nonexistence: for one of two contradictories cannot be qualified by the other, nor can one nature turn into the nature of its contradictory. And whenever nonexistence is intrinsically impossible for a reality, that reality is necessary through itself.

SH-006 — The argument from non-admission of nonexistence and five further proofs

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: after establishing the common meaning of existence, the author begins to explain its necessity, one of the treatise's objectives. The argument is this. The reality of existence, considered just as itself, does not of itself admit nonexistence. Whatever does not of itself admit nonexistence is necessary through itself. Therefore the reality of existence is necessary through itself. The major premise is evident. As for the minor: if the reality of existence admitted nonexistence through itself, its qualification by nonexistence would be possible. Supposing that qualification to occur would then entail no impossibility. But it does entail an impossibility. The subject either remains what it is while qualified by nonexistence or does not. If it remains, one contradictory is qualified by the other; if it does not, the nature of existence is transformed into the nature of nonexistence. Both are manifestly impossible.

The author finds this sufficient to establish the necessity of existence: a little suffices the discerning, whereas much does not suffice the dull. Nevertheless, the conclusion can be established in numerous ways. We shall mention some to increase investigators' insight and encourage the discerning among them.

First: unrestricted existence is existent, simple, and uncaused; whatever is such is necessary through itself. It is existent because, if nonexistent, a thing would be qualified by its contradictory. A subject remains with its attribute, whereas a thing cannot remain with its own negation. It is simple because, if its parts existed, existence would precede itself; if they did not exist, existence itself would be absent. It is uncaused because otherwise a thing would again precede itself, since the existence of a cause necessarily precedes its effect. That anything possessing these properties is necessary through itself is evident.

Second: if existence were not necessary, it would be either possible or impossible, since every concept falls under one of the three modalities. Possibility is impossible here: the possible is what of itself admits existence and nonexistence, whereas a thing does not receive either itself or its contradictory. Impossibility is likewise excluded: the impossible is nonexistent, whereas existence is existent, as already established. Its impossibility would also entail the absence of particular existences, since a more particular instance must possess what belongs to its unrestricted general nature.

Some later thinkers have attempted to answer this. Some choose the second alternative. They understand a thing's qualification by existence to mean that it is such that, when present in the mind, it is qualified by existence. External things are similarly qualified by necessity and possibility even though these have no external identity of their own. Existence, on this account, likewise lacks an external identity. Their support is merely the eminent al-Ṭūsī's statement—God have mercy upon him—that existence is a second intelligible. You already know the defect in this argument.

I wonder how this eminent thinker, who refuses to accept even particular conclusions solely on the testimony of great masters of unveiling and leading guides, dismissing such testimony as persuasive rather than demonstrative, can satisfy himself on this momentous issue by citing one of the accomplished reflective investigators. He remains devoted to what he has acquired by reasoning alone and rests content with it.

Others choose the first alternative, arguing at length to the following effect: existence without restriction, taken without the condition of anything—that is, the natural universal—is not one thing but many. It is predicated of the existence of the Necessary and of possible things. Some of unrestricted existence would therefore be necessary and some possible in the strict sense. But anyone with even slight familiarity with their methods sees that this multiplicity concerns the individuals of which the nature is predicated. The reality of the concept itself, the natural universal, contains no multiplicity or plurality.

Third: existence is existent, as previously explained. If it were not necessary, it would be possible, and its cause would necessarily exist. That cause would be either existence itself or one of its particular instances. Either alternative entails a thing's preceding itself.

They sometimes answer that its cause is one of its particular instances, and that self-precedence would follow only if existence were not an attribute of that instance. They overlook that the cause must precede through existence, so the impossible precedence follows either way. At other times they say that unrestricted existence is not one thing requiring one cause: the Necessary is an existent without restriction, and each possible thing is likewise an existent without restriction. Each such existent has another such existent as its cause, until the series reaches one without an efficient cause.

The defect in this has already been explained. I have related their arguments only to alert the discerning reader that, unless intellect in its sound original disposition is free from imposed judgments and familiar conceptual habits, clear demonstrations do not benefit it and theoretical proof does not bring it to certainty. Otherwise, why do these accomplished thinkers—despite their deep involvement in disputation and their high level in investigation and debate—not rest upon manifest truth when their own demonstrations follow this course? Instead they mount the vehicles of conjecture and mere possibility.

Fourth: existence is existent, and its existence is itself. Whatever is such is necessary through itself. Its being existent has already been explained. Its existence is itself because otherwise it would be either a part of existence or external to it. The first alternative entails composition in existence, already shown to be false; the second entails an impossible regress.

Fifth: an existent is something possessing existence. Possessing existence is broad enough to include the case in which existence is the thing itself and the case in which it is other than the thing. The nature of existence is different: a thing is established for itself, and what belongs through itself cannot be removed or affected by an external factor. Whatever has existence established for it without an intermediary is the Necessary.

QT-007 — The necessary reality cannot be qualified

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> That reality which is necessary through itself is not taken under the qualification of generality, since the general as general has no extramental realization. Nor is it taken under a specifying qualification belonging to privative conceptual considerations, for the reason already given; nor under a specifying qualification belonging to positive, existential determinations. For if that specifying qualification stood to it as form does, what is necessary through itself would be composed of two parts, or of diverse parts, and that is impossible. If instead it stood to that reality as an accident, it would not follow from the reality’s very nature; otherwise it could not be a specifying qualification.

> The intrinsically necessary reality would then depend for its intrinsic necessity on something distinct from itself, since an infinite regress among ordered terms situated between two present endpoints is impossible.

SH-007 — Why genuine unrestrictedness is not a condition added to existence

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: existence considered just as itself is sometimes applied to what is qualified by generality and absoluteness—that is, the nature conditioned by the exclusion of anything else. It is also applied to what is free even of this condition: the nature taken without the condition of anything. Since the preceding demonstration established the necessity of the nature considered just as itself, the author now explains that what has been shown necessary is not what is qualified by generality. It is the reality unrestricted in the genuine sense, not absoluteness opposed to restriction, since that opposition itself constitutes a restriction. The Necessary cannot be restricted in any way.

A condition allegedly restricting the nature of the Necessary must either be the condition of generality—abstraction from all other conditions—or a particularizing condition that removes the conditioned nature from its generality, confines it to some particulars, and distinguishes it from opposed individuals. In the latter case, the condition must either be conceptually posited and negative or real and existential. There are therefore three alternatives, all false.

The first is false because, if the necessary reality were the nature taken with the condition of generality, it would be the general precisely as general. The general as general has no external existence. The necessary reality would consequently not exist externally.

The second is false because qualifying the necessary reality—the nature of existence considered just as itself—by negative conceptual conditions would entail the previously mentioned qualification of one contradictory by the other. You may object that this follows only if conceptual conditions are sheer nonexistence, which they are not. We reply that conceptual considerations must contain a negative condition. Their existential component, insofar as existential, returns to the unrestricted nature, leaving sheer negation as the distinctive condition. The impossible qualification therefore follows.

As for the third alternative, a real, existential, particularizing condition must stand to the reality either as a form to a composite—being a differentia constitutive of it—or as an accident outside the necessary reality but constituted through it stands to its subject. The first is impossible because the necessary reality would then be composed of two parts when the differentia belongs to a highest or single genus, or of several different parts in other cases. The second is likewise impossible. Whatever attaches to something must have as the principle of its attachment either that thing itself, a part of it, or something external.

It cannot arise through the thing itself: a particularizing condition must exclude some instances and retain others, and what is coextensive with the nature cannot do that. The second case, dependence on a part, is plainly false. The third makes the necessary reality depend for its intrinsic necessity upon something distinct from it. For, if the intermediary were not distinct but instead another property attaching to the nature, that attachment could arise neither through the nature itself nor through a part of it, and so would again require something external. If this too were an attached property, a regress would follow among ordered items, each earlier item causing the next, between two enclosing endpoints: the nature and its particularizer.

Let the discerning reader understand that this is, for the perceptive critic, an adequate explanation and sufficient demonstration that the true reality and necessary nature, precisely as necessary, cannot be tinged by any condition whatsoever or admit determinations external to it in any respect. Its determination is instead genuine unrestrictedness and the intrinsic unity of all-comprehensiveness, as I indicated in the introduction. Reflect on this: it is among the most important subtle points.

QT-008 — Objection: the necessary nature as a correlate of common existence

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> If it is objected: 'The necessary reality is the nature that is among the necessary correlates of that existence, already mentioned, which is common to all particular existences.'

SH-008 — Presenting the later Peripatetic alternative in its strongest form

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: after establishing what is true, the author intends to expose the falsity of a position adopted by later Peripatetics and attributed by them to accomplished philosophers. This will confirm what he has prepared by demonstration and reinforce the structure he has established. They maintain that the necessary reality is a particular nature: one individual of unrestricted existence, standing in contrast to particular possible existences. Possible existences have quiddities that serve as their subjects, whereas the particular necessary nature does not, because existence is its very quiddity. Decisive demonstrations establish that the Necessary has no quiddity other than the nature of existence. This nature would therefore provide a counterexample to the preceding proof, and the author accordingly presents their position as an undifferentiated challenge to that proof.

The challenge can be stated as follows. Just as all the proof's premises entail a nature unrestricted in the genuine sense, they also entail a nature unrestricted insofar as it is unrestricted, one of the natures entailing unrestricted existence. This too is pure existence, with no consideration accompanying it except the absence of conditions. Although that

absence itself is an external condition, it is a negative conceptual consideration with no place within the nature of existence; taking it into account adds nothing to the nature itself. The nature would therefore remain sheer and unalloyed.

Furthermore, since they predicate unrestricted existence of particular existences by gradation, its predication of them must be that of a concomitant of the things entailing it, even if it is the very quiddity of some of its instances, as will shortly be explained. Hence the author's formulation: ‘If it is said: the nature which is among the grounds entailing the existence just mentioned…’

QT-009 — Objection developed: predication of existence by gradation

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Nor would it follow from this that that reality is a quiddity distinct from existence, such that it produces existence without being conditioned by existence. For that reality is existence itself, and does not differ from existence. Accordingly, predicating 'existence' of that underlying reality and of the remaining existences regarded as its corresponding underlying subjects would be by way of gradation (tashkīk).

SH-009 — Graded predication, conceptual attachment, and the highest instance

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: the author now begins to answer objections that could be raised against the later thinkers' position, so that their doctrine is first established in its strongest form. Afterwards he will explain its falsity, following the customary procedure already noted.

One objection is that the reality in question—the necessary nature—would have to be a quiddity different from existence, since what entails a concomitant must differ from that concomitant. The nature would then produce existence without being conditioned by existence: without its conjunction with existence being considered. For it is established that the necessary reality is the complete efficient cause, necessitating through itself, without needing an external factor or that factor's conjunction with it.

The answer is that this follows only if the reality is not pure existence itself but contains something else alongside it. If it is pure existence itself, as they maintain, none of those consequences follows. The distinctive character of the Necessary is, on their account, the intensification of existence in itself and its freedom from whatever would compromise its intrinsic purity. The particular necessary reality would therefore not differ essentially from unrestricted existence.

You may ask how an attribute attaching to something after its establishment and realization can be identical with its prior subject and also constitute that subject. We reply that such

attachment is conceived here only in intellect, as will be explained; externally it is the subject itself. Possible quiddities do not furnish a counterexample, although their relation to their respective shares of existence may seem similar. On the opponents' account, those shares have no separate external existence: they are intellectual considerations without an external counterpart. Nor does the unrestricted nature's being a subject of graded predication entail that all its shares are intellectual considerations. One of them is the real existent that exists through itself and through which other things exist. Neither does it follow that existence must attach as an additional attribute to that instance. What bears graded predication is the comprehensive unrestricted meaning; an attribute's belonging to a more general item does not entail its belonging to everything that entails or bears that item. The constituting reality may not admit that attribute. A concomitant's being predicated by gradation does not require the same of what entails it. The phrase ‘and the predication of existence…’ points to this argument.

There is a subtle point here worth explaining. Consider an unrestricted universal nature that attaches to diverse realities and different quiddities in relation to its particular shares. Either the shares are unchanged in their realities, so that the reality of each is simply that one unrestricted nature. Its predication of those shares will then be univocal and intrinsic, even though its predication of the subjects bearing those shares is extrinsic.

Alternatively, the shares differ in their realities. They all share in occurring to that fixed nature, which functions like a substrate for what are, as it were, its changing, non-enduring attributes. They proceed from a determinate starting-point in precedence with respect to that nature, perfection, intensity, or a similar respect, until a share is reached beyond which none is prior in relation to it. There is no other share in which the nature appears with all its properties as fully as in that one: the highest share possesses all the nature's proper concomitants, without its particularity hindering them. This occurs when the fixed nature in that share is free from the external particularities that function like changing and non-enduring attributes. The unrestricted nature is then, on their account, predicated of these shares by gradation and extrinsically.

It should not be objected that this freedom from particularities contradicts the earlier account, according to which the necessary reality has a distinctive particularity opposed to the others; without such a particularity, it would not be a share of the nature at all. We reply that freedom from particularities is itself a distinctive particularity opposed to the others. But the other particularities are external to the reality itself and therefore do not permit all the properties of that reality, just as itself, to appear through them. Precedence, intensity, and similar differences among shares arise through the variable degree to which their particularities hinder what belongs to the nature through itself from attaching to a given share. This continues until a share is reached in which no such hindering particularity is possible. Its distinguishing character is precisely its freedom from hindering particularities, as just explained.

Once this is understood, we say that the unrestricted nature's status as an attached attribute arises only when it is compared with changing factors and diverse shares conjoined with additional conditions and extrinsic considerations—the source of its qualification by possibility. Relative to the highest share, whose particularity consists in freedom from those external factors, no such attachment is conceivable, insofar as it is free of external conditions. It may nevertheless be considered an attached attribute from another standpoint, insofar as this very consideration constitutes a condition opposed to the other shares' particularities. A discerning reader, led along the path of verification by divinely granted success, can find a measure of reconciliation between this account and what was indicated in the introduction.

Verse: ‘Our expressions differ, while Your beauty is one; each points towards that beauty.’

QT-010 — The 'twice existent' objection

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> Nor would it follow that that reality is existent twice, as the remaining existences might be said to be; for the existentness common to it and the other existences is identical with that reality in external things, even though it is among the attributes additional to it from the standpoint of intellects and minds.

SH-010 — Answering the objection that the Necessary would exist twice

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this too answers an objection that might be raised here. If unrestricted existence is predicated of the necessary reality and other existences by gradation and as an attribute, the necessary reality would have to exist twice—an evidently false consequence. The entailment is explained as follows. If existence is a graded, attached predicate, it must be a meaning common to the other existences and to that reality. Just as the other existences would exist twice—once insofar as they are existences in themselves, and again insofar as unrestricted existence attaches to them—the same would hold of the necessary reality. This is especially so if that reality is necessary through itself: it must efficiently cause everything else and therefore precede everything in existence, even the common meaning of existentness, since an efficient cause necessarily precedes its effect through existence.

The answer is that this follows only if the existentness common to existents is something externally different from that reality. It is not. Existentness is that very reality externally, although intellectually and mentally it is an additional attribute.

It should not be objected that, if common existentness is externally identical with that reality, the necessary reality itself would externally attach to quiddities—an evidently false consequence. That follows only if there is an external realization of the attachment just

mentioned, which there is not. Common existentness has shares whose realities differ, and the relevant qualification obtains through each share. Consider the predicate ‘walker’ in relation to its instances in humans, horses, and other things. The unrestricted meaning has no external existence within those quiddities distinct from its diverse shares, even though intellectually it has an independent occurrence, like those shares, and is conceived as attaching to them. Attachment belongs to the unrestricted meaning only with respect to its occurrence in intellect. Externally there are only the diverse shares; no such attachment occurs there.

QT-011 — Reply: intrinsic and extrinsic modal status of instances

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> We reply: If the necessary nature to which absolute existence is necessarily concomitant could have mental or intellectual instances, then suppose one of its instances existed while the rest were impossible. All the instances would be possible in themselves. Thus, if some were impossible, they would be impossible through another, and if some were necessary, they would be necessary through another; for what belongs to a thing in itself cannot be removed by another.

SH-011 — Could a necessary nature have several conceivable individuals?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers the Peripatetic position offered as a counterexample to the preceding proof and thereby refutes their doctrine. The argument is this. The nature entailing unrestricted existence, which you identify as necessary, either can have individuals relative to which it is a universal reality, or cannot. This covers both real intelligible individuals, as with other real universals, and merely posited mental individuals, as with hypothetical universals such as nothingness and non-possibility. If it can have individuals, either one exists or more than one. The second case is evidently false. In the first, the individuals of the necessary nature must be possible through themselves, whether the remaining individuals are impossible or possible. They cannot be intrinsically necessary or intrinsically impossible without contradicting what has been supposed.

It should not be objected that the supposition establishes only the possibility of being qualified by the nature, not the possibility of existence. The necessary nature that entails existence is, on their own account, existence itself. The possibility of being qualified by it is therefore precisely the possibility of existence.

If all the individuals are possible in themselves, then any one's impossibility would arise through another, and any one's necessity would likewise arise through another. All would retain their intrinsic possibility, since what belongs intrinsically is not removed by an external factor. No individual could therefore be necessary through itself.

One may object: if possibility means possibility in the general sense, it does not follow that a necessary individual would be necessary through another; some individual could be intrinsically necessary. But if possibility is understood in the strict sense, it is treated as evident that, were a necessary nature to admit individuals, they would be strictly possible. How, though, could that follow, when the two descriptions cannot both be predicated? What follows from the supposition is only that the individuals are not intrinsically impossible. That is general possibility, not strict possibility.

We reply that the supposition concerns a simple necessary nature having individuals, one of which exists while the others are impossible. On that supposition, all the individuals must be possible in the strict sense. Otherwise their modal statuses would either differ—some necessary, some impossible, some possible—or agree. The Necessary's simplicity excludes the first alternative. If their statuses agree and they are not all strictly possible, they must all be necessary or all impossible. The first makes the supposed impossible individuals necessary; the second makes the supposed necessary individual impossible. This also shows why the nature of necessity requires intrinsic unity. Take heed.

QT-012 — Intrinsic determination and the impossibility of multiple instances

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> If, however, it cannot have individual instances in the mind or in intellection, this is either because its determination is identical with its reality in external existence; or because it entails its own determination in virtue of itself, so that the remaining purported existing instances are impossible in themselves as well; or because a nature determined in itself cannot become an intelligible object for any intellect, and so cannot possess a plurality of instances; or because such a nature cannot be joined to anything else, nor anything else to it, and so cannot have intellectual or mental instances.

SH-012 — Four explanations of a nature's inability to have multiple individuals

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this explains the second branch of the preceding division: the necessary nature cannot have mental or intelligible individuals. This is the true alternative, but intellect regards it as extremely remote because it assumes that an intelligible nature cannot lack individuals, and that a reality cannot become a genuine particular unless surrounded by extrinsic individuating attributes and alien limiting coverings. The author therefore seeks to establish the point through several approaches, showing that this sense of improbability originates in the entrenchment of habitual beliefs.

The impossibility of individuals of this nature can be conceived in several ways. First, its determination may be its very reality externally. Were two individuals of it to exist, the reality would have to be transformed into another, which is manifestly impossible.

Second, the determination may be required by the reality itself. In that case the reality considered in itself would have existing individuals, because it is a necessary nature; yet its intrinsically requiring a determination would make the remaining individuals, also intrinsically existent under the supposition, impossible. Those remaining individuals would intrinsically require nonexistence because the nature intrinsically requires the determination, while also intrinsically requiring existence. This is one kind of impossibility.

It should not be objected that the impossible falls under general possibility in the relevant broad division, in which one of the two necessities is denied; how can a concept containing both necessities be impossible? We reply that, although the concept contains both necessities, necessity of existence is intrinsically denied of it, while necessity of nonexistence is true of it. It is therefore impossible through itself.

These first two explanations apparently exclude intelligible individuals but not mental ones, since they establish the impossibility of multiple individuals of a reality intrinsically determined externally. They do not decisively establish anything about its occurrence in intellect, considered as a mental concept. The author therefore introduces two further explanations: one excluding mental individuals and one excluding individuals without qualification.

The first is that a nature determined through itself cannot be intelligible to any intellect, for two reasons. Intellection does not consist in the imprinting of the intelligible in the knower; it consists in a unifying relation between intelligible and intellect, such that they are not distinguished in existence, as will be explained. Determination, however, entails distinction from everything else. Intelligibility therefore cannot coexist with intrinsic determination. Furthermore, every intelligible is determined through the intellect knowing it. If it possessed another determination, one thing would have two determinations, which is impossible. If it cannot be intelligible to any intellect, it cannot have many individuals: individuals are conceived through an intelligible form's correspondence to them. Without that corresponding form, the individuals cannot be realized, since one of two corresponding terms cannot be realized without the other.

The second explanation is that a nature determined through itself is free in itself from conjunctions. Something else cannot be conjoined with it, nor can it be conjoined with something else. The conjunction of conditions is conceivable only for what admits particularization and determination, whereas what is self-determined does not. Once conjunction with conditions is impossible, multiple individuals—whether intelligible or mental—are impossible.

The multiplicity of these explanations also indicates that the cases of a nature unable to have individuals are exhausted by these four. Common predicability here consists in

correspondence between an intelligible form and multiple external forms. It cannot be conceived without both the intelligible form and the multiple forms. Its impossibility must therefore arise either from the absence of an intelligible form, because the reality cannot be intelligized, or from the absence of multiple forms. The latter absence arises either because their productive condition—the conjunction of qualifying conditions—is absent, or because a hindrance exists. A hindrance must be either the reality itself or something external but inseparable from it; otherwise it would not be a hindrance. In the first case, external identity is the nature itself; in the second, external identity is required by the nature itself. None of these cases permits the relevant reality to be predicated of an individual other than the nature itself, since that would transform the nature into something else, an evident impossibility.

You may object that this follows only if a universal nature must actually be predicated of individuals externally. Logic instead establishes that the possibility of supposing such predication suffices. We reply that the possibility of supposing predication is unavailable here, because it entails the transformation just mentioned. You may then say that, at most, the predication is impossible, whereas supposing an impossibility is itself possible; its predication can therefore still be supposed. We reply that what is possible is the supposition of something impossible. What follows here is an impossible supposition. The difference is evident.

QT-013 — The dilemma of distinct existence and a supposed necessary nature

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> If its reality, considered in itself, is different from the reality of external existence and objective being—through whose conjunction with different real quiddities those quiddities come to be in external reality—then applying the expression ‘existence’ to the two realities would involve verbal homonymy rather than a common meaning. Moreover, that supposed nature could not itself contain objective being, since it must be simple. It would consequently have to be either one of the real quiddities or something belonging to intellectual considerations; numerous impossibilities would follow. If, however, it is not distinct from that reality, then either the particular possible existences in external reality cannot entail the reality of absolute existence, share in it, or receive its true predication; or they must entail, share in, and be truly predicated of by the necessary reality. But it is impossible for particular possible existences to be intrinsic underlying terms to which the necessary reality belongs as a concomitant. For we have demonstrated in our philosophical writings that such a nature cannot contain a purely possible aspect or any receptivity for a real existential attribute.

SH-013 — The dilemma of intrinsic difference and common existential reality

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: once it has been established that the necessary nature entailing unrestricted existence cannot have mental or intelligible individuals, we argue as follows. Either that nature differs essentially from the reality of external existence and concrete being—the being by conjunction with which quiddities occur externally—so that they share no meaning and have only the word existence in common, or it does not differ in that way. If it does, the word existence applies to the two realities equivocally, not through a shared meaning.

One might say that mere essential difference between the necessary reality and concrete being does not entail verbal equivocity. Why could there not be a common attribute? Sharing an attribute is compatible with essential difference. The author anticipates this by saying, ‘Moreover, that nature…’. His point is that the alleged difference entails either equivocity or numerous impossibilities.

That nature must not contain concrete being in itself, whether as its identity or as a part. If concrete being were its identity, the supposed difference would be contradicted; if a part, composition would follow, contrary to necessary simplicity. The nature must therefore be other than concrete being and serve as its subject. This subject must either be a real quiddity, as the theologians maintain, or an intellectual conceptual consideration. Both alternatives entail numerous impossibilities.

If the necessary nature is a real subject of being, and being lies outside its reality, existence could be separated from the necessary nature. For that existence would have to be possible, and what is possible admits cessation and nonexistence. Existence would also precede itself, since the necessary nature, being the cause, must precede existence through existence. The necessary nature would further be both agent and recipient. All these consequences are manifestly impossible. One thing would moreover exist twice: conjunction with being would make it existent, as with other quiddities, while the Necessary's priority in existence would require it to exist before that existence.

If, instead, the necessary nature—the principle of everything—is merely conceptual, all those impossibilities follow, together with the absence of the cause externally despite the presence of its effect.

Take now the other branch: the necessary reality is not essentially different from concrete being. One of two consequences follows. Either particular possible existences cannot entail unrestricted existence, or external possible existences must entail the necessary reality. For the realities of particular external possible existences either differ essentially from the concrete being through conjunction with which quiddities occur, or they do not. If they differ, they cannot entail the reality of unrestricted existence, share in that unrestricted reality, or have it truly predicated of them. Essential difference between the two existences entails difference in existence, whereas entailment of the common reality, sharing in it, and its true predication each require unity in existence. The two requirements cannot coexist.

If those external possible existences do not differ essentially from unrestricted existence, the second consequence follows: possible existences must entail the necessary reality. The

particular necessarily entails its unrestricted general nature, and that nature, under this hypothesis, does not differ from the necessary reality. Possible existences would therefore share in that reality and have it predicated of them. Yet particular possible existences cannot intrinsically entail the necessary reality. The philosophers have themselves demonstrated that the nature in question cannot contain a purely possible aspect or admit any existential attribute, since otherwise the intrinsically Necessary would not be one in every respect.

It should not be objected that the absence of essential difference need not exclude every difference: there may still be differences arising from accompanying attributes and accidents. Such differences do not diversify the realities themselves. Even on that account, what entails the concomitant would still be none other than the necessary reality, and the foregoing consequences would follow.

QT-014 — Indistinguishable similars cannot have opposite ontological roles

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> Moreover, the coming together of things exactly alike, with one of the two assigned the status of what inheres and the other the status of a locus in which something inheres, and with one possessing a qualification that the other lacks despite there being no differentiating factor—these are among the judgments and states intrinsically impossible.

SH-014 — Why indistinguishable instances cannot receive opposing modal roles

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this is another independent proof against the second branch of the dilemma. If the necessary reality does not differ essentially from unrestricted existence, and possible existences do not differ from it either, all must be alike in reality. One of two alike things would then be assigned inhering status—that is, being an attribute—while the other would be assigned the status of a locus—that is, being a subject. One would likewise be assigned necessity and the other possibility, without any differentiating factor. Assigning mutually opposed and incompatible properties to indistinguishable things is intrinsically impossible. Incompatibility among concomitants arises only from incompatibility among what entails them; this is why the former is used to infer the latter. The incompatibility between being an attribute and being its subject, and between necessity and possibility, is evident.

One may object: while graded predication remains possible and unrefuted, how can complete likeness be established? The preceding division entails only that necessary and possible existents are alike in the reality of unrestricted existence, not that graded predication is altogether excluded. Every universal nature—whether predicated with

gradation or univocally, and whether accidentally or essentially—has particular, conceptually considered instances. It is predicated of these in a species-level manner, even though the predication of each type differs when applied to its real individuals.

We reply that the possibility of graded predication will shortly be excluded independently. The proof can be summarized as follows. The particular necessary existence that entails the reality of unrestricted existence either admits common predication of several instances or does not. The first contradicts intrinsic necessity, as already explained. In the second case, its reality is either different from the reality of unrestricted existence or identical with it. Difference is false because it entails a thing's preceding itself and the other impossibilities already stated. Identity entails either that particular possible existences cannot entail unrestricted existence, or that they entail the particular necessary existence. Both are manifestly impossible: the first because the particular necessarily entails its unrestricted general nature, the second because of what the philosophers themselves have demonstrated. It follows that the proposed nature entailing the concomitant, understood as a particular existence, is untenable.

QT-015 — Two alternatives for tashkīk—and the circularity of its proof

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Furthermore, the existence that obtains for differing quiddities and divergent natures does not, in virtue of itself, admit existence and nonexistence, as indicated in the appropriate place. It must therefore be necessary through itself. If some other existent distinct from it were found, that which is necessary through itself would be multiplied—a consequence the defender of gradation rejects utterly. This addresses the case in which the advocate of gradation advances no more than a rational possibility or supposition. If instead he claims that gradation is necessary and established with certainty, and appeals to priority, precedence, greater intensity, greater perfection, greater completeness, and similar qualifications on the part of the necessary nature underlying absolute external being, together with their opposites on the part of the other underlying terms, we deny this. For the obtaining of these relative conditions in the former as compared with the latter presupposes that the supposed underlying nature is established in reality in exactly the manner you allege. To demonstrate its establishment by these very conditions would beg the question.

SH-015 — Two dialectical defences of graded predication and the reply to each

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this is a proof against graded predication, on which the Peripatetics base their principles and chief commitments concerning this question. Since the author has undertaken to conduct the discussion according to the method of reflective investigators,

he must consider every argumentative route they might employ, completing his purpose and protecting his proof against possible defects. The preceding arguments have proceeded by positive reasoning and demonstration. The advocates of graded predication can therefore most suitably respond here by denying a premise on the basis of a rationally admissible possibility. The author accordingly addresses this route first. They might instead undertake a positive counterargument. He therefore secures his account against both breaches, so that neither route provides an opening.

The first response must be answered by establishing the denied premise. He does this by stating that unrestricted existence—existence taken without the condition of anything—which belongs to different quiddities and natures, has already been shown not to receive either existence or nonexistence through itself. Whatever is such must be necessary; existence must therefore be necessary through itself. We then argue that graded predication entails another existent among its instances possessing this same qualification. If another existent besides the unrestricted nature possessed it, there would be more than one intrinsically necessary existent, whether or not the second were a ground entailing the unrestricted nature. Yet the advocate of graded predication emphatically denies a plurality of necessary existents.

It should not be objected that plurality follows only if the nature entailing unrestricted existence is not itself existent through unrestricted existence and united with it in existence. If it is so united, the objection says, no plurality follows. We reply that the demonstration establishing the necessity of unrestricted existence also establishes its independent external existence: it exists through itself, without anything else being conjoined with it. If graded predication requires a further necessary nature entailing it, that nature must also exist independently. Plurality then necessarily follows.

This addresses the advocate who relies merely on rational possibility: ‘Plurality follows only if unrestricted existence is not predicated of the entailing nature and the remaining existences by gradation. If graded predication remains possible and reason admits it, plurality does not follow.’ One may object that this attacks only the support offered for a denial, an invalid procedure according to the rules of disputation. We reply: ordinarily, yes; but here the stated support is coextensive with the denial, as the denier's own formulation shows. Refuting it therefore removes the denial itself.

Suppose instead that the advocate offers a positive counterargument and claims graded predication to be necessary and self-evidently established. He argues that the necessary nature entailing unrestricted concrete being has precedence, priority, greater intensity, greater perfection, greater completeness, and similar properties, whereas the remaining grounds of particular possible existences have the opposites: lack of precedence or priority, deficiency, weakness, and the like. We deny the assignment of those properties specifically to the alleged necessary nature. Establishing these relational attributes in it by comparison with particular possible existences already depends on establishing that nature as necessary. They are relational properties of a necessary reality in comparison with what is

possible. Establishing a property, particularly a relational one, presupposes its subject, one of the related terms. To establish the necessary reality through those relations would therefore beg the original question. This reply accords with the present line of argument.

The author also develops a refutation in al-Iʿtimād al-Kabīr, whose gist is as follows. The occurrence of graded predication, insofar as it would establish that what bears it is accidental to its subjects, can arise only through successive changes either in the individual instances of that accompanying accident relative to a fixed locus, or in the kinds of that accident relative to it. The detail can be understood from the eminent al-Ṭūsī's commentary on the Ishārāt: ‘This is conceivable only in a reality that can be treated as occupying a fixed subject for a non-enduring state whose specific character changes when what occurs at one instant is compared with what occurs at another. What occurs at each instant is thus found to be intermediate, in the respect according to which the gradation obtains, between what occurs at two instants enclosing it.’ Here ends his wording.

Once this is established, we argue that successive replacement of existences differing in species or individuality upon one determinate real quiddity is plainly inadmissible. Without the condition of existence, that quiddity cannot remain numerically the same while passing from one state to another. Even if this is conceded, we do not grant that successive individual existences occur in relation to a specific quiddity precisely as one specific quiddity, if that is what is intended. If something else is intended, we do not grant that the quiddity cannot be constituted by existence. A common factor may have one instance stronger in relation to one quiddity and another weaker in relation to a different quiddity, yet still constitute those quiddities. For the Peripatetics regard corporeality as constitutive of the species of bodies, although its instance in the celestial spheres is stronger and more intense than its instance in the elements.

QT-016 — Can determination itself have differing meanings?

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> We further maintain that the concept of that nature is distinct from the concept of every determination that is an accident requiring the realization of a subject to which it attaches, whether in external or intellectual existence, and whether that determination is positive or privative. If it is objected that its determination, which is identical with that nature in external reality, may be the underlying term for determination absolutely, and that ‘determination’ is predicated of it and of the other determinations either by gradation or by mere verbal homonymy rather than a shared meaning, it could then be neither intelligible nor in need of an underlying subject under either supposition. We reply: in our philosophical writings we have established that the concept and meaning of determination are one self-evident concept, varying only with differences in relations to subjects. It is evident that understanding a relation does not require comprehending the intrinsic reality of the term to which it relates.

SH-016 — Can the necessary reality be determination itself?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: the proponents of the nature entailing unrestricted existence concede that it cannot have mental or intelligible individuals if it is to qualify as the necessary reality, as already explained. The cases in which a nature cannot have individuals mentally or externally have been restricted to four. The author now explains why none of the four applies to the alleged entailing nature. This establishes, for purposes of instruction and explanation, that even if its existence is conceded, it cannot qualify as necessary. It also follows the method of investigation by granting some of the opponent's premises.

The argument is that the entailing nature, even if established and realized, cannot be the necessary reality. A necessary reality construed as a particular existence must be unable to have individuals mentally or externally. The alleged entailing nature is not of that kind. Were it so, it would fall under one of the four cases; but it falls under none. The entailment follows from the exhaustive rational division already given. Its consequent is false for the following reasons.

The nature cannot belong to the first case, in which it is determination itself. Determination is an attribute requiring a subject on which it depends: in external existence when the determination is external, and in intellectual existence when it is mental. Even granting the entailing nature, it cannot be identical with this concept. On that concession it would have to be a self-subsistent reality sustaining others. How could it be the very attribute whose occurrence requires a subject to be realized externally or mentally? This holds whether the attribute is considered positive or negative, the familiar disagreement about determination.

An objection may be raised: the argument follows only if determination is one specific nature shared by all determinations as the individuals of a species share its nature. If determination is predicated extrinsically of its instances, and the determination identical with the necessary nature externally merely entails unrestricted determination, the conclusion does not follow. The instances of unrestricted determination might differ in their realities, some subsisting through themselves and others through something else. Even granting the first premise, why could unrestricted determination not be predicated of the necessary determination and the others either by gradation or merely equivocally? Under either alternative the necessary nature might itself be neither intelligible nor dependent upon a subject, unlike the remaining determinations.

We reply that the author, may his secret be sanctified, has established in his philosophical books that the concept and meaning of determination is one and necessarily known. A denial based on the possibility of gradation or verbal equivocity therefore does not apply. Its instances differ only through their different relations to subjects. If their differences derive from relations depending on subjects, they cannot be differences in their own realities; they can only be differences in attributes attaching to them by comparison with

external factors. The necessary determination cannot therefore be altogether unintelligible. The relation whose intellection is required to intelligize that determination is itself known. A relation does not require its terminus to be understood in the full depth of its reality, which would make the relation—and consequently the necessary determination—unintelligible. It requires only that the terminus be conceived under some aspect. That is plainly not impossible; indeed, such aspectual understanding is necessarily available.

QT-017 — Intrinsic determination is not merely bare thisness

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> The meaning of its determination being identical with itself in external reality is that it is distinguished from everything other than itself through itself, not through a quality externally additional to it. This does not entail that its very reality is identical with sheer individuality (shakhṣiyya); otherwise it could not intellectually apprehend itself and other things. Rather, through itself it provides for itself what the individuality of an individual provides to that individual in relation to other individuals of the same species.

SH-017 — Determination by opposition versus determination by all-comprehensiveness

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this indicates why the second of the four cases does not apply to the entailing nature, in a manner that explains what all the people of realization mean when they say that the Necessary's determination is itself. The author therefore omits an explicit statement that determination is required by the essence, although that was the formulation used in the earlier case: the present account plainly entails it.

The statement that the Necessary's determination is itself externally means that it is distinguished from everything else through itself, not that it requires an additional extrinsic attribute by which to be distinguished. Otherwise its defenders would fall into the very difficulty they sought to avoid: the Necessary's dependence upon something outside its essence.

One might then imagine that the Necessary's essence must be mere individuality. If saying that its determination is itself means that it is self-sufficient in being distinguished from everything else, the Necessary would seem to be individuality itself, understood as external identity or thisness. It could then neither know itself nor know anything else. For external thisness is the aggregate configuration of relational concomitants and accidents attaching to something by comparison with external things, enabling it to be distinguished from them. Natures of this sort plainly cannot be receptacles for knowing substances or their intelligible forms. The words ‘it does not follow…’ answer this misconception.

Having rejected the identification of the Necessary itself with bare individuality, the author explains the true meaning of determination's being the Necessary itself: the Necessary provides for itself what an individual's individuality provides for that individual in relation to other individuals.

It may be objected that one of two consequences follows. Either the fourfold division is not exhaustive, or the necessary nature admits common predication of multiple individuals. On the present account the necessary reality belongs to none of the four cases. If it nevertheless cannot have individuals, the first consequence follows; if it can, the second follows.

We reply that this would be impossible only if it entailed commonality opposed to distinction and individuation. It does not. Its individuation lies in the very commonality itself, as I have repeatedly indicated. Otherwise its distinction would arise through external relations, not through itself. Properly understood, this is the ultimate denial of both commonality and distinction in their oppositional senses: there is no independently other reality from which it is distinguished or through which it is individuated.

To explain this in the vocabulary of reflective investigation requires an experiential preliminary point. Perceiving it calls for refinement of inward awareness and precision of consideration. Determination is conceivable in only two ways: by opposition or by comprehensiveness. No distinction falls outside these. What distinguishes a thing from another is either a property established for the first and an opposing property established for the second, as with opposed things; or a property established for the first but not established for the second, as with the distinction of a whole precisely as whole, or of a general nature precisely as general, from its parts or particular instances.

In the first case the marks of distinction must be external to the determined thing, since they are relations or principles of relations between opposed items. In the second they cannot be something added to the determined reality: without the distinguishing character that reality would cease, and through it the reality is what it is. A whole is constituted as a whole through its encompassing its parts, and through this it differs from those parts. Likewise, the general is constituted as general through its comprehending and gathering its particularities and instances, and through this it differs from what falls under it.

The aggregate configurations and encompassing forms of things have no reality beyond the gathering of those particularities and the unity of their collection. We therefore say that the determination proper to the Necessary belongs to this second kind. Nothing stands opposed to Him, exalted is He, nor does He stand opposed to anything. For further clarification or evidence for this claim, reflect on His saying: ‘He neither begets nor is begotten, and none is comparable to Him.’ The negation extends through the two positive kinds among the forms and classes of opposition.

With this established, the statement that the Necessary supplies for itself what an individual's individuality supplies becomes intelligible. Reflect on this subtle point: it contains many meanings of great benefit.

QT-018 — The Necessary is intellect, intellection, and intelligible

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> We do not concede that it cannot be intelligible to any intellect. We have demonstrated in our other philosophical works that in virtue of itself it is an intellective knower, an intelligible object, and intellect. Moreover, it is intelligible to all intellects by virtue of considerations, relations, and relational aspects additional to it, even if most intellects do not grasp its intrinsic reality in its very essence.

SH-018 — Knowing the Necessary through itself and under an aspect

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this indicates why the third of the four cases does not apply to the entailing nature. The premise that it is unintelligible to any intellect is denied when stated without qualification. How could it be maintained, when philosophical demonstration establishes that this nature must be knower, intelligible, and intellect through itself? It cannot therefore be said to be altogether unintelligible to itself.

Even if we grant that it is not intelligible in itself to separate intellects, we [do not] grant that it is unintelligible under considerations and relations. Through the relations additional to it and the correlations attaching to it by comparison with other apprehending faculties, it must be intelligible to every intellect, even though most intellects do not know the full depth of its reality.

The point is this. One condition that would prevent a nature from having mental or intelligible individuals would be its being wholly unintelligible, neither in its full reality nor under any aspect. The commonality and correspondence necessary for individuals to count as individuals would then disappear. But if it is intelligible under an aspect to every intellect and in its full reality to some, that consequence does not follow.

QT-019 — Relation to something other is not necessarily contrariety

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Nor do we concede that it is impossible for it to be conjoined in some manner with another or for another to be conjoined with it, unless ‘another’ means something incompatible with it or opposed to it. For, as will become clear, relations, relational connections, and privative and positive conditions are associated with it in one manner of association, while it is associated with them in another. Consider this carefully.

SH-019 — Relation to another need not be opposition to another

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this indicates why the fourth of the four cases does not apply to the entailing nature. Conjunction with another would be impossible only if another meant what is incompatible and opposed. As I indicated above, the Necessary's distinction is not distinction from an opposite. What is other in the sense of an opposite here is sheer nonexistence and absolute nothingness.

If, however, another means something other than an opposite—one of the different matters related to the reality—we do not grant that conjunction is impossible. As will become clear, relations, correlations, and negative and positive states are not incapable of being conjoined with the necessary nature. They are conjoined with it in a certain manner, and it is conjoined with them in a certain manner.

The explanation returns to the distinction made in the introduction between relational multiplicity, in respect of which the many are called kawn and cosmos, and conceptually considered unity, in respect of which they are called the Real's names, affairs, and relations. Recall that distinction. If this is valid of the unrestricted nature which is intrinsically one, the alleged entailing nature is all the more entitled to it. Reflect on this.

QT-020 — A reciprocal objection against unrestricted necessary existence

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> If it is objected: ‘If your arguments are sound in showing that what is necessary through itself cannot be the nature to which absolute existence is a necessary concomitant, the same arguments could be used to show that it cannot be absolute existence itself. For if the reality of absolute existence admitted intellectual instances, one instance would have to exist, while the remaining instances would be impossible: neither could all of them exist nor could none exist. Then the necessity of some and the impossibility of the others would be due to another rather than to themselves. If it admits no intellectual instances for any of the reasons given, then either its reality differs from the realities of the particular possible existences in external reality—in which case the term “existence” would apply to them only equivocally—or it does not differ from them, in which case the possible existences themselves would possess intrinsic necessity.’ We reply: the supposed underlying necessary nature must, for the reasons already given, differ from external existence and be its underlying bearer. That does not apply to existence necessary through itself, subsisting through itself, and distinguished from everything else by its very reality.

SH-020 — Does the objection to a determinate Necessary also defeat unrestricted existence?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this is a general counter-objection to the argument just given. Its formulation is that, if all the premises of your argument showing that what is necessary through itself cannot be the nature to which unrestricted existence necessarily belongs were sound, unrestricted existence itself would likewise fail to be necessary, since the same argument applies to it.

The explanation is as follows. The Necessary cannot be unrestricted existence itself. For, if its reality admits intellectual instances, one instance must exist and the remaining instances must be impossible: it is impossible both that the necessary reality should have many actual instances and that none of them should exist. Once it is established that only one instance exists while the others are impossible, that instance must exist through another, and so its necessity must be through another. Likewise, the impossibility of the remaining instances must be through another, not through themselves. The reason is that the necessary nature must be a specific nature; otherwise its instances would have different realities, entailing composition in the Necessary, which is impossible. If it is a specific nature, what its instances intrinsically require cannot differ. Thus, if some instances required necessity and others impossibility [the reported alternative reading], that requirement would not arise through themselves but through another. The Necessary would then depend on another for its necessity, which is plainly impossible.

If, instead, it cannot have intellectual instances for any of the four reasons previously mentioned, then either this unrestricted reality differs from the reality of particular external existences called possible existences, or it does not. If it differs, the term existence is applied to it and to possible existences equivocally, not with a common meaning: the meanings are different, and all that they share is the application of the word. If it does not differ from external existences, possible existences must be qualified by intrinsic necessity, since each particular instance of a reality must possess that reality's necessary concomitants.

The author replies that this counter-objection applies only to someone who makes the necessary nature a determinate thing standing over against the other determinate things. It would then differ from external existence and be that to which existence necessarily belongs. If the commonality is one of meaning, and that nature is itself a case of external being, the unrestricted being predicated both of it and of other things must nevertheless differ from it and necessarily accompany it. The objection does not apply when we identify the Necessary with unrestricted, all-encompassing, self-subsistent existence. Nothing other than it sustains it, and it is distinguished from everything else by its own reality: everything other than it is sheer nonbeing, so it needs no extrinsic differentiator.

In sum, once they hold that the Necessary is a particular determinate nature like the other determinate things, it follows that it differs from the unrestricted meaning predicated both of it and of what stands opposite it. It must also stand opposite the other possible determinate things. The consequences already stated then follow. But if the Necessary is all-encompassing unrestricted existence, from which no relation, attribute, or instance—whether similar or incompatible—falls outside, none of the impossibilities facing those who assert such a determination applies.

One may object that this account must still entail one of two things: either there can be no possibility, possible things, or other quiddities, or there must be an aspect of possibility within the Necessary. Both are plainly impossible. We reply that, if the denial of possibility means denying it without qualification, the alleged consequence is not conceded. If it means denying possibility of existence insofar as it is existence, the consequence is conceded, but its impossibility is not. As explained in the prolegomenon, possibility is a consideration that attaches to things in respect of the manifestation of knowledge; and the manifestation of knowledge is plainly distinct from the manifestation of existence.

Know that, for discerning people of spiritual taste, discussions of this kind belong among the clearest self-evident matters. For other learned persons, bound by the necklaces of uncritical adherence, they are scarcely intelligible. Nor is this surprising: ‘For anyone to whom God gives no light, there is no light.’

QT-021 — Necessity need not restrict absolute existence

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> If it is objected: ‘Were the absolute reality necessary through itself and self-subsisting, it would cease to be absolute and would instead be restricted by its intrinsic necessity.’ We reply: the absolute reality, precisely insofar as it is absolute, may have necessary characteristics that do not take it outside the scope of absoluteness or entail any extramental restriction by those characteristics.

SH-021 — Why necessary predicates need not restrict unrestricted existence

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: the author now begins to state and answer objections to the apparent meaning of the doctrine of the people of realization. These objections mislead disputants of weak understanding and shallow thought, and unsettle some seekers of guidance whose minds have grown accustomed to intellectual sophistries and dialectical associations.

One objection is this. The unrestricted nature which they identify as the Necessary is considered without any conditions or relations whatever—even without this negative consideration itself, since, on their doctrine, it is not restricted by unrestrictedness. If this

nature were necessary through itself, the supposition would therefore be contradicted. For, if it were necessary through itself and necessity were required by its essence, necessity could not be separated from it. It would then no longer be unrestricted but would be qualified by intrinsic necessity. A qualification means nothing other than the consideration of a meaning additional to the nature itself. If that meaning is intrinsically required and necessarily accompanies it, it must be considered along with it. Thus the unrestricted nature would not be unrestricted: a contradiction.

The author answers that the unrestricted nature, precisely as unrestricted, can possess necessary judgments which do not take it outside unrestrictedness. Judgments do so only if they are additional to it through an additional extramental meaning, and their realization and attachment depend upon that external meaning. But suppose they are intellectual considerations belonging to the nature in relation to itself, without any additional meaning contaminating its pure unrestrictedness and without an external relation ascribing restriction to it. None of them then removes it from its extramental unrestrictedness or makes it externally qualified by any of them.

It should not be objected that every concept distinct from the unrestricted nature must, when considered along with it, take it outside intrinsic unrestrictedness—whether the concept is an intellectual consideration belonging to it through itself or an actual feature accruing to it from another. We reply that this would follow only if these were additional extramental things joined to it, or if the source and origin of their attachment were something other than its intrinsic unrestrictedness. When they are considerations arising in intellect precisely in view of that unrestrictedness, they do not remove it from it. A thing cannot be incompatible with the very source from which it arises.

From this one can understand the basis of the distinction between divine names and cosmic names.

QT-022 — Why answer objections even after a demonstration?

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> If it is objected: ‘If absolute existence, considered precisely as absolute, could subsist through itself in external reality without needing to be joined to any specifying or individuating factor, and its necessity through itself could be established demonstratively, there would be no proper occasion to raise the hypothesis just mentioned, nor would it be appropriate for you to begin answering it. To undertake an answer would depart from the proper procedure of directing an objection and would serve only to prolong the discussion, multiply premises, and give an adversary opportunities to deny, counterargue, and undermine the proof. Moreover, we necessarily know that each particular possible existence in external reality is an instance of absolute extramental existence; and we likewise necessarily know that existence which is necessary through itself, and which is incompatible with each particular possible

> existence, is one of its instances.’ We reply: the perceptive thinker endowed with intellectual intuition knows with certainty that objective being, subsisting through itself externally, cannot acquire being through any of the things that themselves obtain being through it and through conjunction with it. The majority, however, suppose that unrestricted existence is governed by the same rule as other unrestricted natures belonging to real external quiddities. They fail to distinguish the two cases, and so the hypothesis just stated readily occurs to them. Refuting it even after provisionally conceding that it is a properly formed objection, and removing other doubts that obstruct certainty and intellectual conviction in a matter unfamiliar to most people, is therefore useful for those who are more perceptive and less burdened by dullness and entrenched habits of imaginative imitation. Removing such suppositions and doubts prepares weaker minds for the truth to dawn upon them, restraining the disordered movements of thought generated by habitual misgivings and entrenched erroneous beliefs in receptive seekers.

SH-022 — Why answer a flawed objection? Intuition, instruction, and the analogy of light

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this points to two difficult objections which reflective investigators have found profoundly troublesome. Most discerning opponents regard them as an incurable affliction. In truth, each is a root from which varieties of contentious dispute branch out, a foundation supporting boughs of doubt and perplexity. Their source cannot be cut off without the aid of sound intellectual intuition and thought free of the taint of partisanship and uncritical adherence.

The first objection rests upon a premise counted among the conceded truths because of its strong resemblance to them. The premise is that an unrestricted nature, insofar as it is unrestricted, cannot, even for those who admit its existence, subsist by itself in external reality without being conjoined with some qualification. On their view, the existence of what is unrestricted—assuming it exists—is nothing other than the existence of what is qualified.

With this understood, the objection runs as follows. Suppose that the unrestricted nature as unrestricted, whose conception the generality regard as self-evident, could subsist independently in external things without any particularizing factor, and that its intrinsic necessity had been demonstratively established, as was just argued. There would then be no legitimate way of raising the previously mentioned possibility, either by denying a premise or by presenting a counter-instance. Denial could not affect either premise of the argument: the first has been demonstrated, and the second is self-evident. Nor would a counter-instance be available. Failure of the conclusion to follow despite the proof would have to occur in something outside the instances covered by the proposition established; but the nature to which existence necessarily belongs is itself an instance of the unrestricted as unrestricted, and so cannot serve as such a counter-instance.

If that is so, anyone acquainted with the methods of acquiring knowledge should not embark on answering objections of this kind. Answering what has no standing under the rules of inquiry and disputation is virtually an error. Apart from departing from proper argumentative procedure, undertaking an answer adds nothing except lengthening the discussion, multiplying premises, and enabling an opponent to deny, counter, and impugn the exposition. All these are to be avoided according to the rules of dialectic and demonstration.

The second objection is this. If unrestricted existence as unrestricted were necessary, it could not be an attribute common to the other instances of existence. But that consequent is false. The implication is obvious; the falsity of the consequent follows because we necessarily know every particular possible external existence to be an instance of unrestricted external existence. We likewise necessarily know intrinsically necessary existence—which excludes each particular possible existence as one division excludes the other—to be among its instances.

Both objections contain premises accepted by, and familiar to, most acute minds, especially the premise forming the foundation of the first difficulty. Removing them therefore requires a kind of intellectual intuition. Through it the discerning thinker escapes the bonds of accepted rhetorical propositions and deceptive or unsophisticated dialectical arguments. When it dawns, the knots of inherited convictions and deeply rooted beliefs are loosened. Intuition is free from the interference of contrived operations arising from the cognitive faculties during the pursuit of theoretical conclusions, and possesses the firmness and assurance accompanying freely bestowed gifts. In reflective inquiry, the relation of discursive thought to intuition is like the relation of spiritual wayfaring to attraction in the other path.

For this reason the author replies that an intelligent person endowed with intuition knows with certainty that external being, subsisting of itself outside the mind, cannot acquire its being through any of the things which themselves acquire external being only through it and through conjunction with it. Those other things exist only through the shining of a flash of its light and become manifest through the scattering of a gleam of its manifestation.

This premise is so evident to the first principles of intellect that even someone with the slightest discernment should have no doubt about it, much less those who lead the field in subtle intellectual questions and the difficult matters of certainty. The author therefore wished to identify where their errors had gone astray. In doing so he explains both how they came to commit this conspicuous mistake and why he himself undertakes to answer them, thereby permitting their denials and counter-objections. Hence his words, ‘But the generality believe that what holds of its unrestricted form holds of the other unrestricted natures.’

The explanation is that they observe a rule applying to the other unrestricted natures: these do not exist externally until they have been specified by constitutive differentiae and

individuating accidents. In short, extramental existence attaches to them and sustains them within their instances. They assume that existence itself is another case of the same kind. They therefore conclude that unrestricted existence cannot subsist by itself and so cannot be the Necessary; it must possess a particularizing and sustaining factor before it can subsist externally and qualify as necessary.

An analogous mistake in sensible experience would be to reason that, since no visible thing can be seen without some light making it manifest, and since that manifestation requires the sensible thing to have coloured surfaces, light too—as something visible—must be manifested by another light under the same conditions. But because estimation has no role in overriding direct observation in this example, those who see it have no doubt. Presented to a blind person, however, the objection might well leave him unable to answer. Our present question concerns intelligible meanings, and most intellects lacking insight, subject to estimation and imagination, are in the same position as the blind person confronted with that example.

Among God's marvellous acts of wisdom is His making estimation a guard over His inaccessible presence, preventing it from becoming a watering-place open to every cross-eyed insight and mutilated cleverness. An exception is made for His sincere servants, whose inward sight He opens by the light of certainty so that they see the Real as He is through His illuminating light: ‘For anyone to whom God gives no light, there is no light.’ O God, make us among those over whom Satan has no authority. This has been a parenthetical remark; we must return to the present purpose.

Because they fail to distinguish this unrestricted reality from other unrestricted natures, they believe that unrestricted existence is realized only within something qualified, just as real external quiddities, indeterminate in themselves, are realized through another. It is therefore unsurprising that the stated possibility immediately occurs to them: the Necessary must be one of the particular existences and individual determinations, or else it would not be self-subsistent but would depend on another for its realization and subsistence outside the mind. Refuting this possibility, after granting for argument's sake that the objection is properly raised, is not outside sound argumentative procedure. Rather, removing doubts that obstruct intellectual certainty in a matter unfamiliar to ordinary dispositions benefits those distinguished by exceptional intelligence; addressing them is therefore obligatory from the standpoint of instruction.

Most rational disputants remain with conceded premises and theoretical propositions requiring nothing beyond the arrangement of necessary and primary truths. Premises which, in addition to that discursive arrangement, need a measure of intuition and spiritual taste lie very far from their accustomed dispositions. The doubts obstructing their ascent toward the realities must therefore be removed. Although this does not benefit all of them, it benefits the more intelligent and those furthest from dullness and deeply rooted submission to estimation and imagination. This intimates that the treatise does not address

the generality of rational thinkers, but those endowed with exceptional intelligence and discernment, together with powerful intuition and experiential unveiling.

Even conceding that answering this possibility has no proper argumentative role with such opponents, removing the various objections and doubts that may occur to students and seekers of guidance plainly prepares their weaker minds for the truth to become apparent. It restrains the disordered movements of thought arising from habitual suggestions and ingrained, objectionable imitations within their receptive and seeking souls.

Instruction and learning therefore require attention to whatever cleanses the receptacle of entrenched inherited convictions and the obstructive, distracting movements they produce. Here that is the removal of impediments, called emptying or purification. Equally necessary is attention to the certain premises that prepare the receptacle to receive an effusion: these function as the positive requisite, called adornment.

QT-023 — Four ways to understand a particular existent

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> It is self-evident that a claim to self-evidence cannot be accepted at the very point in dispute. As for the particular possible existent in question: if this means the subject of some determination, quality, or state, without taking that qualification into account with it, it is in reality pure existence, necessary through itself. If it means one of those accidents, which exists only accidentally, apart from existence that exists through itself, we deny that it is an instance of absolute existence. If it means the sum of both, we deny that such a composite can exist in external reality; accordingly, mentally supposed individuals of that sort would be intrinsically impossible externally. If, finally, it means the bearer of an accident precisely as its bearer—that is, with that accident taken into account as it exists outside the mind—then each particular existent, indeed all of them, is one existent necessary through itself, multiple only through possible attributes additional to the essence. Absolute existence would therefore have no individuals differing intrinsically as necessary, possible, or impossible. As for the alleged incompatibility between such instances, there is nothing in the claim, for the reasons already explained.

SH-023 — Four interpretations of a particular existent and the proper subject of possibility

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this points to the answer to the second of the two objections. Since the questioner claims necessary knowledge precisely where the matter is disputed, he could be answered by saying that an appeal to necessity within the point at issue is not admissible under the discipline of inquiry. The proposition ‘Every self-evident matter is undisputed’ converts by

contraposition into ‘Whatever is disputed is not self-evident.’ But this would be dialectical disputation, leaving the substance of the difficulty intact.

The answer that cuts off its source is to say that a particular possible existence—meaning existence specified by determinations, relations, and relative privative states—cannot be an instance of unrestricted existence in the required sense. For what is meant by the particular existences alleged to be its instances must be one of the following: the subject of those determinations, without considering the accruing determinations along with it; those accruing determinations, without considering their subject at all; or the subject together with the accruing determination. In the last case the determination is considered either as something accruing to the subject or as a constituent part.

Four exhaustive alternatives result, both intellectually and in existence. None permits unrestricted existence to have instances that are possible in themselves. Under the first, what is meant is the subject of some determination, attribute, or state without considering that feature along with it. This is in truth pure, one existence, necessary through itself. Under the second, what is meant is an incidentally existing feature without considering the existence which exists through itself along with it. We do not concede that such a feature is an instance of unrestricted existence: under that consideration it is intrinsically nonexistent. How, then, could existent be predicated of it as what it is, making it an instance? An instance of existence is what exists through itself and of which the concept of existence is truly predicated as what it is.

Under the third, what is meant is the sum of both, a composite of the accruing feature and its subject. We do not concede that such a composite can exist, since, as they themselves establish, existence cannot be a constituent of quiddities in external reality. On this supposition the intellectual instances would therefore be intrinsically impossible in external things. Differences among the instances of existence would follow, although their impossibility has already been demonstrated.

You may object that the impossible consequence follows only if the composite is impossible without qualification, whereas its being impossible externally alone need not be impossible in the required sense. I reply that anything which is an instance of unrestricted existence, and of which existence is predicated as what it is, must require existence through itself. It cannot therefore require nonbeing at any of its levels.

Under the fourth alternative, what is meant is the subject of an accruing feature insofar as it is that feature's subject: the feature is considered along with it as accruing to it, as is actually the case externally. Particular existences in external reality are simply that to which these determinations belong. Under this consideration each particular existence is intrinsically identical with the others; indeed, all of them together are nothing but one reality necessary through itself. What belongs intrinsically does not change through the addition of concomitants and accruing features. Unity is intrinsic to it, while multiplicity consists in features accruing through attributes that are intrinsically nonexistent and exist

incidentally. It is therefore only these intrinsically nonexistent concomitants, additional to the essence, that are qualified by possibility.

This investigation establishes that unrestricted existence as unrestricted existence cannot possess intrinsic instances differing in necessity, possibility, and impossibility, because genuine unity belongs to it intrinsically. It further clarifies what we explained in the prolegomenon: possibility accrues in consideration of the manifest aspect of knowledge, and necessity in consideration of the manifest aspect of existence. The distinction between their manifest aspects is evident.

As for the assertion that the possible and the necessary exclude each other, it rests upon positing multiple instances of existence and assigning necessity to one rather than the others. The defect in that position has already been explained, so there is no need to prolong the discussion.

QT-024 — Mental existence and external existence are one in essence

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> If it is objected: ‘Mental existence, which cannot exist externally, is an instance of absolute existence, just as the instance externally necessary through itself is one of its instances.’ We reply: mental being is external being in its essence, although it differs from it under a conceptual consideration. Intellectual meanings are attributed to external existence at certain of its levels, or when it is considered as qualified by other accidental attributes. We are not concerned here with the existentness predicated incidentally to intellectual meanings, as it may be imputed to other quiddities and to relations, attributes, and states; the discussion here concerns existence that exists through itself and is necessary through itself.

SH-024 — Mental and external being: one reality, different considerations

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this presents a counter-instance to the demonstration that instances of unrestricted existence cannot differ in necessity, possibility, and impossibility. Mental existence is one of the divisions, and therefore one of the instances, of unrestricted existence. Yet, insofar as it is mental, it cannot exist externally: otherwise it would cease to be mental existence. The Necessary is likewise an instance of unrestricted existence, yet must exist externally through itself. Its instances would therefore differ in necessity and impossibility.

It should not be replied that what cannot exist externally is the thing in the mind insofar as it is in the mind, not mental being itself, which belongs among external accidents. On this reply, mental being means the occurrence of an intelligible form, and that form, insofar as it accrues to intellects, unquestionably exists externally. For we answer that intelligible forms

are what accrue to intellects, whereas what constitutes their being there is something else, distinct from the form itself. Intellect considers it when attending to the form's coming to be within intellect. It thus occurs at the second level of intellection, cannot exist externally, and yields the difference just alleged.

The answer is that mental being is intrinsically the same as external being, though it differs from it in consideration. Establishing this requires a preliminary explanation. Unrestricted existence, in the sense adopted by the people of realization—not the meaning conventionally adopted by later thinkers, as the prolegomenon explained—has primary states. These are called intrinsic affairs because they require the essence to manifest according to them. Or, equivalently, the essence requires that it manifest according to them, coloured by their governing properties, so as to display the perfections of the names necessarily accompanying essential perfection. This will be explained in detail, God willing.

Those affairs, called fixed entities at another level and names under another consideration, differ in comprehensiveness and essential proximity. Some are universals whose manifestation actually encompasses the manifestation of all the particulars falling under them; these are called levels. The essence cannot manifest in the more remote levels without first manifesting in the nearer. Manifestation proceeds through these comprehensive levels, from the world of spirits and the imaginal world, until it reaches completion in the world of sense. This is the last of the comprehensive levels, which the people of realization call loci of disclosure. In another terminology, existence at this level is called external being.

Now recall what the preceding discussions have established. These states and the judgments that follow them in specifying existence—whether comprehensive states called levels or particular states encompassed by them—are merely conceptual considerations and privative relations. They do not enter into the reality of existence as such. Mental being, which is one of those levels, is therefore intrinsically external being, though distinct in consideration. Intelligible meanings too accrue to external being, but at certain levels or on condition that it is qualified by other accruing attributes. Some concomitants arise only after a prior concomitant has attached, as explained above. In short, all these considerations and judgments, at whatever level, belong only to external being: it is last in manifestation and first in rank. Take heed.

The author's words, ‘Existence by supposition is not considered here,’ answer a possible renewed objection. The intellectually considered meaning of existence, which accrues to intelligible meanings as it accrues to other conceptually considered quiddities and privative relations, differs from the primary real meaning identical with external being. All existential realities and real quiddities are forms of the determinations and levels of the latter, as established at the opening of the treatise. The proposed counter-instance concerns the first meaning, not the second, and so the given answer would not remove it.

The objection is answered by observing that the intellectually considered meaning is outside the present inquiry. Here, in this treatise, the discussion concerns existence which exists through itself and is intrinsically necessary. It does not concern the conceptually considered meaning belonging to the relations and correlations that are privative considerations.

QT-025 — The First Principle cannot be one separate species among existents

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> An admonition: Know that to regard the First Principle, necessary through itself, as a particular species-like entity involves—on their own assumptions—undermining what they believe concerning it. For they also believe that it is the cause of the other things and kinds in external reality while being entirely distinct from them and lacking any affinity with them, and yet that it falls under absolute external existence, which encompasses all the other external things dependent upon it—whether existence is treated as a conceptual consideration, as some hold, or as a real self-subsisting reality, as others hold. They likewise subsume it under all the inclusive universals and general notions, as well as many other universals. This account is remote from illuminating intuition, sound intellect, and correct reasoning. Reflect upon the preceding and forthcoming discussions; perhaps truth will become apparent and certainty clear to you, if you possess intelligence, discernment, and excellent developed dispositions. Furthermore, we maintain that the being in which external beings share is itself objective being, and that the nature of that being is the very reality of those external beings, both outside the mind and in thought; their difference and multiplicity come solely from particularizing relations, connections, and considerations.

SH-025 — Can a wholly unrelated First Principle also be cause and share general predicates?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: after establishing the first objective through reflective investigation and inference, answering the possible objections, and refuting the opponent's position by exposing the weakness of its foundations—as promised at the opening—the author wishes to add an indication to those discussions. It will suffice for the denying opponent who looks with fairness and consideration, while giving the aspiring student further disclosure and insight. Its purpose is to intimate that the objective belongs among self-evident matters which do not need such indications for their acquisition. The point is that they attribute to the Necessary's existent reality and identity something incompatible with the attributes which they themselves hold must belong to Him. Any doctrine or judgment incompatible with His necessary concomitants will reveal its falsity to someone who examines it attentively. Hence the author calls this discussion an indication.

They believe that the Necessary is a particular specific existent reality: a particular external being intrinsically different from all other external beings. Yet they also hold it to be the principle and cause of all the other beings and species, while asserting separation and the absence of any affinity. At the same time they place it under unrestricted external existence, which encompasses all the external things dependent on it, whatever account they give of existence—whether a conceptual consideration, as some hold, or a reality, as the others maintain.

In short, they judge it to fall under existence, just as under the other comprehensive universals and general notions: being a reality, a cause, a determinate thing, and one. They also place it under many further universals, the attributes they hold necessarily established of it, such as being knowing, powerful, willing, and the rest. But to attribute principiality—which is itself a relation—and priority to something plainly conflicts with denying every affinity between it and any of its effects. Denying affinity likewise conflicts with holding it to share in external being, which is what its particular existent reality is said to be. Its inclusion under any universal or general notion similarly conflicts with denying affinity between it and all effects, and entails sharing something with the other external species included under that common notion. Anyone who has caught the scent of certainty about existence can see that such an account of the Necessary is far from clear intuition—indeed, from sound intellect and correct thought—because of its manifest contradiction and explicit impossibility.

An objection may be raised that the commonality required in these cases concerns only extrinsic accruing predicates. On their view unrestricted being accrues to the necessary existent reality; principiality too is one of the privative relations and extrinsic concomitants arising when it is considered in relation to external things. The same applies to other comprehensive universals, such as quiddity and causality. Moreover, on their account existence is an intellectual consideration which accrues mentally to existent realities and particular existences, as are the other comprehensive attributes. Their necessary reality and the dependent existent realities can therefore share such considerations without contradicting their extramental separation.

We reply that the preceding discussions, together with the experiential indications and rational demonstrations to follow, establish that existence cannot have instances with different realities qua existence, such that unrestricted existence would be predicated of them accidentally and in a graded manner. Anyone even slightly trained in the methods of discerning people with perfected spiritual taste and excellent acquired dispositions will also recognize the necessary judgment that external being, shared by the external beings through which entities come to be outside the mind, must itself be external being. Those beings, whether external or mental, must be the very reality and nature of that being. Their differences and multiplicity arise only through the particularizing relations and conceptually considered correlations. As repeatedly explained, what they understand by the word existence as a mere intellectual consideration has no standing in the vocabulary of

realization. The author's concluding injunction to reflect points toward answering these two objections.

QT-026 — Why absolute existence, not its determinations, is primordial

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> Once this is understood, we say: what is most fitting—and indeed most necessary—is to regard real objective being as absolute being that encompasses every determinate thing, and to regard determinate things, precisely insofar as they are determinate, as intelligible meanings and natures considered together with conceptual relations and relational aspects.

SH-026 — Gathering and distinction: why unrestricted being is prior to its determinations

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: the author has established the question as intended and rejected positions liable to mislead the discerning student, exposing where their adherents stumble. He has removed the powerful doubts and evident difficulties that led them into error—difficulties escaped only by sound intellects and upright minds after refinement of the inward secret and precision of reflection, aided by clear intuition and a share of spiritual taste and certainty. He now wishes to explain genuine undifferentiated comprehensiveness and intrinsic unrestrictedness, so that the way in which the differentiated names arise from it may be established upon this foundation.

This completes his purpose and fulfils his undertaking to explain divine unity according to the vocabulary of realization. Such an account must bring distinction and gathering together, and transcend both the exclusive assertion of incomparability and assimilation. That is what the reality of divine unity requires, as the saying attributed here to al-Ṣādiq, peace be upon him, indicates: ‘Gathering without distinction is heresy; distinction without gathering is divestment; joining the two is divine unity.’

The author therefore says that it is more fitting and more necessary to identify real external being with unrestricted being which encompasses all determinations. The explanation is that external being, as established above, subsists through itself and sustains the determinate quiddities conjoined with it. Insofar as they are determinate, those quiddities are intellectual meanings and natures taken together with conceptually considered relations and correlations. They have no existence except in relation to external being. It is therefore undoubtedly more fitting to identify unrestricted necessary being with external being than with those determinations.

It should not be objected that the language of ‘more fitting’ is inappropriate because it signifies merely the preference of one alternative over another, whereas that is not the

intended conclusion. We reply that, after refuting the opponent's claim that determinations and quiddities are external realities rather than that through which they come to be, this expression is preferable to others for its irony and reproach. These can impel the opponent to abandon his conviction—indeed, sever those deeply rooted beliefs from his inward being—in accordance with the art of rhetoric. Determinate things, precisely as determinate, must therefore be regarded as intellectual meanings and natures taken with conceptually considered relations and correlations. This reverses the view that unrestricted being is merely a consideration occurring at the second level of intellection, while the intrinsically real things are determinate quiddities.

In sensible experience this resembles someone whose weak sight leads him to suppose that the different colours alone manifest themselves to perception externally, and that unrestricted light, which is evident in itself and makes other things evident, has no external manifestation except within colours. Such a judgment arises from the accumulated obscuration of compound ignorance, produced by ingrained uncritical adherence, which prevents perception of light apart from dense, dark loci of manifestation. A discerning knower need not contradict what such people report, but should acknowledge the condition they are actually describing: their report concerns the limit of their apprehension and the point at which their visual ray comes to rest. Because of its weakness it does not go beyond colours.

‘When a person has no sound eye,
it is no wonder that he doubts, though morning shines.’

This too is a level of the Real's manifestation according to their faculties of awareness, a locus of His perfection and a place of His beauty's disclosure, and so is not to be denied. Hence the author and other people of realization do not simply judge their position and other positions to be false. This meaning too may be sensed in his expression ‘more fitting’.

‘All within Your sanctuary love You; yet
I alone [am] for all within Your sanctuary.’

QT-027 — Pure absolute existence and the non-attribution of names

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Once this has been established, you will understand that the Real is absolute existence, in which there is neither difference nor multiplicity: it is sheer existence, unmixed with anything other than itself. In this respect there is neither composition nor plurality in it, nor any genuine name or distinguishing description—indeed, no attribute or qualification. For attributes, names, and judgments cannot be assigned to the absolute Essence without considering determinations and modes of particularization. Even the denial of everything other than sheer absoluteness—which entails denying judgments, attributes, and real determinations of it—is a negative judgment whose principle is a

> determination that is not itself real. Consequently it does not constitute a genuine contradiction upon investigation. Consider this.

SH-027 — How the unqualified essence can be named without becoming qualified

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: once it is established that real external being, self-subsistent and sustaining others, is unrestricted being, it is unquestionably genuinely one. The other quiddities and particularities, considered precisely as such, are nonentities. Anyone who has purified his heart of natural impurities and freed his soul and faculties from inherited convictions and imaginative and estimative forms can then see that the Real, glorified is He, is unrestricted existence without difference or multiplicity. Genuine intrinsic unity is what He requires through Himself, and is the first name and first expression by which He is designated.

Multiplicity and difference are intelligible only where duality and plurality can be conceived and where some part has a judgment not belonging to another. How could the genuinely one, unrestricted reality encompassing the many—everything outside which is sheer negation and nonbeing—be subject to difference and multiplicity? Difference and multiplicity may indeed be conceived in the levels of its descent and loci of its manifestation according to its intrinsic affairs and states, where the relations of the names encounter one another and the conceptual correlations differ.

But in the presence of intrinsic unrestrictedness, which the people of this discipline call the hiddenness of identity and nondetermination, no considerations have any place—not even this consideration. No conceptually considered concomitant mingles with it. It is sheer, pure existence, unmixed with anything else. In this respect, namely intrinsic unrestrictedness, it has neither composition nor multiplicity; indeed, it has neither any real name nor a descriptive definition. In their terminology a name is the essence considered under some meaning, whether privative or existential; they call that meaning an attribute or qualification. Where there is no attribute there is no name, and where nothing is considered along with the essence there is no attribute. Under this consideration the essence is unrestricted, with no determinations or particularizing aspects taken into account, and is therefore stripped of all judgments and names.

Nevertheless, when this very consideration is entertained, a name does arise for the essence through it. It is not, however, one of the real names: it arises not from considering a meaning together with the essence but from not considering meanings. The objection that this is itself a meaning does not overturn the principle. It is not one of the real meanings, since its nature is precisely to negate and remove the consideration of a meaning. Its possessing the status of a meaning thus arises only by supposition and consideration. Hence the author qualifies ‘names’ with ‘real’. It is also clear that no descriptive definition

is available: such a definition proceeds through properties, which are attributes peculiar to a thing, and negating the general class excludes its particular members.

The author's words, ‘Negating everything other than unrestrictedness of it,’ answer an implicit objection. The rule that attributing meanings and judgments to the essence requires considering their origins in relations and determinations appears to be refuted by this very judgment. Negating everything other than unrestrictedness is itself a judgment, yet it presupposes none of those features; otherwise the supposition would be contradicted.

He answers that, although this is a judgment, it is negative, so its source is a determination that is not real in the relevant sense. The discussion concerns real determinations and real names; this is therefore not a valid counter-objection. ‘Counter-objection’ here means a general rebuttal, although the word is more commonly used for a detailed rebuttal of a particular premise. The former sense is more evident here.

You may object that, on this account, all determinations are conceptually considered, privative matters rather than realities, whether they ground existential or negative judgments. There is therefore no reason for the distinction. I reply that, although all determinations are matters of consideration, there is a difference between those that can ground real names and those that cannot. When intellect considers another meaning along with the essence, whether existential or privative, a real name arises for the essence under that meaning. But when it considers the essence stripped of all meanings and judgments, even of this consideration itself, no determination or particular form arises capable of serving as such a ground.

When the soul nevertheless conceives it, that conception acquires an incidental determination from the particular features of the receptacle in which it occurs. Without intellect's consideration, the reality itself would not require this determination. This is the non-real determination grounding the negative judgments now under discussion. It is this consideration that licenses the expressions nondetermination, unrestricted existence, and hiddenness of identity.

It should not be objected that it therefore no longer remains purely unrestricted once this consideration is added. Intellect can abstract from the consideration even while it accrues, since intellect can abstract things from the very descriptions under which it conceives them —as with the wholly unknown, the wholly nonexistent, and other unrestricted concepts discussed earlier. Take heed. Then reflect on the expressions ‘gathering-place of opposites’ and ‘the presence where opposites press together’, and on the subtle question in which unaided intellect has no scope. Do so with refined certainty and a purified orientation, so that the Real may become apparent according to your degree. The author's ‘reflect’ points to subtleties of this kind.

QT-028 — Knowledge as the first relation of the Absolute Essence

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Know that this absolute identity, one through true unity, has as its first necessary concomitant a relation of knowledge: its self-presence in itself to itself. Through this concomitant there follow intrinsic necessity, the power of necessitation, effusiveness or bestowal, and the other ordered and non-ordered attributes that belong to it through itself.

SH-028 — The first determination, four primordial names, and the relation of knowledge to causality

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this begins the explanation of how the differentiation of the names branches from essential undifferentiated comprehensiveness, how those names arise in their genera, species, and kinds, and what each concerns and where it is considered. Every name has a source which appears only in a particular domain of the essence's varieties and at a particular level of its descent. The name is applied to the essence only under that consideration. This is one sense of the authorities of the revealed law's statement that the Real's names are tawqīfī—authoritatively fixed. It is among the fundamental questions of this discipline, as the prolegomenon explained.

As has repeatedly been said, this treatise addresses reflective investigators and reasoners according to their established ways of presenting arguments and demonstrations. We must therefore not depart from their familiar technical terms and customary forms of address. We descend to the range of their understanding, in the hope that God may release them from the confinement of their estimations. At the same time, instruction requires us to draw attention to the terms used by the people of this discipline and to interpret the author's words through their terminology, making matters easier for students seeking guidance. A subtle affinity joins the experiential meanings disclosed through unveiling to the terms that express them in this vocabulary. That affinity greatly assists understanding, yet is discerned only through the light of sainthood and the niche of prophecy. We should therefore explain something of it in the course of these lines.

Know that the essence considered under nondetermination, called now the unseen of the unseen and now absolute identity, cannot include any consideration entailing determination, restriction, multiplicity, or plurality. The first descriptive meaning considered of it is genuine unity, in which neither multiplicity nor otherness can be considered in any respect. Multiplicity itself does not differ from unity relative to it, just as unity does not differ from the essence. This is clarified by the earlier distinction between two senses of unity. The first is absolute intrinsic unity, whose concept includes nothing suggesting a multiplicity of aspects or duality. Even the non-consideration of multiplicity is not included, since it would suggest opposition to multiplicity and thereby entail duality.

The second is relational unity: a thing's not being divided into participating items insofar as it is considered in that way. This is the unity opposed to multiplicity, whether accidentally or intrinsically.

Here unity is understood in the first sense, and absolute identity denotes that which is one through it. Under this consideration the essence has universal comprehensiveness from which no level is excluded, even sensible things. Consequently, the relation of knowledge necessarily belongs to it through its being present to itself in itself.

A subtle point containing important benefits must now be understood. Unity as considered here has two aspects. One concerns the essence's inwardness and hiddenness: all relations and correlations are set aside, and under this consideration the essence is called aḥad, uniquely one. The other concerns its manifestation and unfolding: all relations and correlations are affirmed, and under this consideration it is called wāḥid, one. Through the latter consideration the essence becomes the source of names and attributes.

Numerical one illustrates this. Considered simply as one, without its principiality for numbers, it is unrestricted one, with no multiplicity of relations and correlations. Considered as the principle of numbers, however, it becomes the source of indefinitely many names: being half of two, a third of three, a quarter of four, and so on without end. In relation to each numerical level it acquires a special relation and name, although none of these relations or names is anything within it beyond that consideration.

The essence's hiddenness and manifestation are distinguished only relative to faculties of apprehension and witnessing: it appears to them under one consideration and is hidden from them under another, being called Manifest through the former and Hidden through the latter. Relative to the essence itself, however, no manifestation stands over against hiddenness, and no hiddenness over against manifestation. Thus the two considerations of unity have no distinction relative to the essence; what is designated by wāḥid is not distinguished there from what is designated by aḥad. Reflect on this subtle point, which contains great mysteries. May God grant us and you realization through guidance toward them.

The essence's being qualified by genuine unity requires a determination called, in this discipline, the first determination, and also the Muḥammadan Reality. It should not be objected that determination means that by which distinction occurs, while in this presence otherness has neither effect nor standing because it contradicts absolute unity. What need, then, is there for distinction, and how can determination be conceived? We reply that distinction sometimes arises through opposition and contrariety and sometimes through encompassing comprehensiveness. The determination of this presence is understood in the latter sense, as already established.

Determination here requires self-disclosure to the essence itself. As you have learned, it is the essence's orientation from the innermost hiddenness and infinity of its identity toward the presence of encompassing and delimitation. This is the manifestation and self-

disclosure expressed as the relation of knowledge. Through this determination the essence requires that it disclose itself to itself, appearing to itself with the affairs, states, and considerations enfolded within it, finding them, making them manifest, and present with them. In relation to those affairs, four names arise for the essence. They are the first names, called the keys of the unseen of the essence, ascribed to the presence of identity in the words, ‘With Him are the keys of the unseen; none knows them but He.’ They are knowledge, understood as manifestation; existence, here understood as finding; light, understood as making manifest; and witnessing, understood as presence.

The way these names are considered in this order is apparent to the discerning reader. The author points to all four here in that order, using expressions suited to this treatise, and also to the other names necessarily accompanying them—some ordered in this sequence and some not—which are called names of the essence. Reflect.

Another preliminary distinction must be understood. The manifestation just described entails awareness of all the essence's affairs, states, and considerations, with their levels, conditions, governing properties, and necessary concomitants, including sensible things, in a universal and comprehensive manner. The object of that awareness may be the essence in its hiddenness, with everything established and witnessed within it, as all numerical levels are established in one. In their terminology this awareness is called essential perfection. It entails absolute self-sufficiency: the essence manifests in its hiddenness to itself in the manner described, without needing to assume alien forms or pass through the cycles of otherness. Alternatively, the object may be the intrinsic affairs themselves, through the manifestation of their entities to themselves or of some to others within the levels. In that case this awareness is called the perfection of the names.

Under the first consideration there is no otherness between the essence and any of the four names, or between one of those names and another. Under the second, there is a relational distinction. Knowledge and existence therefore each admit two considerations. Considered from the side of hiddenness, they are not distinguished at all. Considered from the side of manifestation, existence concerns the affairs just mentioned insofar as they manifest; knowledge concerns them too, but insofar as they are objects of knowledge in the world of meanings. Their manifest aspects are thus relationally distinguished in this presence of comprehensive unity.

It should not be objected that the author's expressions contradict what he earlier demonstrated about unrestricted essential unity, the rejection of particular determination, and the denial of duality. To speak of cognitive presence seems to imply a different existent that previously was not; necessitation seems to require causality, which entails separation and a particular necessary determination, as the opponent holds. Applying these expressions where only emergence from latency or manifestation from hiddenness is conceivable would therefore suggest confusion and lack of firm understanding.

We reply that this dispute concerns the expressions alone: the author adopts these terms rather than expressing the intended meanings in the technical vocabulary of the people of realization. He does so because at the beginning he undertook to establish the question by the Peripatetic method, following its procedures and terminology. Once the meanings of these terms and what is intended by them here are clarified, none of the alleged problems remains. He will explicitly affirm in this discussion that the knowing essence and the known entities are not different, and that presence here does not have the meaning commonly assumed by the Peripatetics.

We further say that cognitive presence and necessitation, as the author explains them in his work entitled al-Ḥikma al-Rashīdiyya, devoted to establishing Peripatetic principles, imply none of what the opponent alleges and do not conflict with emergence and manifestation. In the metaphysical part of that work he says:

‘Cognition is not constituted merely by presence to an immaterial thing, nor by any arbitrary kind of presence falling under the unrestricted term, as already explained. What is required is the presence of a thing to an immaterial being that exerts some kind of influence upon it. If that being intrinsically necessitates the thing cognized, without depending on another for this necessitation, its cognition requires no additional condition beyond that necessitation. Otherwise—if it does not necessitate it—another condition is needed: conjunction with it in the manner of an accident's conjunction with its subject, securing the influence required. This does not contradict our account of necessitation. Necessitation makes the effect related and close to its necessitating principle as the principle is related to itself. Requiring the weaker does not exclude the stronger.’ Here ends his statement.

An alert reader will recognize its substance: the reality of cognition—intellectual cognition ascribed to immaterial beings—is not presence without qualification, but a particular presence consisting in an agent's having present its effect connected with it. This varies with the cognizing agents' efficacy. The stronger the agent's influence and the less it needs intermediaries, the stronger that connection; the weaker its influence and the more intermediaries it requires, the weaker the connection.

Some agents attain the strength of intrinsic necessitation, producing an effect so that its connection with the agent is like the agent's connection with itself, without any intermediaries or instruments. This is the utmost efficacy, beyond which nothing more can be conceived. The relational connection and subtle unifying link with the cognized object likewise admit no increase. Others are so weak that they cannot act without an additional will and choice and, even then, need many intermediaries and diverse causes. This is the extremity of weakness in efficacy; the relational connection and subtle unifying link are correspondingly weak and remote, eventually reaching merely accidental conjunction [a contextual reading of the displayed alternatives].

Thus, far from implying the alleged conflict and inconsistency, the terms presence and necessitation convey what emergence and manifestation convey in an especially complete and effective way, with further subtle points and noble indications discerned only by the rare acute reader. The other expressions used by the ancient sages are similar: they are unobjectionable as means of conveying realization and guiding a worthy seeker to the truth. Confusion and disagreement arose when later Peripatetics approached them and interpreted them according to their own lower, mixed apprehensions. Those expressions had been inherited generation after generation from the masters of unveiling and pillars of prophecy, such as Hermes, called Idrīs in the language of revelation, and Agathodaimon, here called Seth, peace be upon them. These are the two authorities to whom the chain of ancient instruction returns, distinguished by recording wisdom and establishing its foundations. Do not neglect the subtleties of their noble symbolic expressions: how many hidden treasures lie in concealed corners!

QT-029 — Knowing the Essence entails knowledge of its necessary attributes

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Moreover, its apprehension of itself includes apprehension of all the attributes necessarily belonging to it, since they are identical with its very essence, and apprehension of everything entailed by those attributes, both collectively and individually.

SH-029 — Four modes of the essence's manifestation to itself

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: since absolute identity necessarily entails the manifestation called the first self-disclosure, expressed as the relation of knowledge, that manifestation must encompass all attributes necessarily belonging to the essence. Under this determination they are identical with the essence, even though under another determination they are necessarily accompanying attributes. It also encompasses awareness of the governing properties necessarily belonging to each attribute. For every level, including sensible things, is witnessed in that presence insofar as it is identical with it. As the Shaykh says:

‘I am you; you are we; we are He.
All, within He, are He: ask one who has arrived.’

This is what is called the perfection of the names. The determination in question therefore includes awareness of essential perfection and of the perfection of the names: the essence's manifestation to itself in its determinations within itself, arising through the most holy effusion. It is most holy in being beyond any difference between the recipient of the effusion, its source, and the effusion itself. This is what is expressed as istijlā’, self-beholding through disclosure. It is confined to four cases, with no further case possible.

For the essence's manifestation to itself within its determinate loci of manifestation is considered either from the side of what is manifest or from the side of the locus. The first can occur only through a universal affair and a locus comprehending all the essence's affairs and considerations, such as the Perfect Human. Through such a locus the manifest essence appears to itself in its entirety and the oneness of its comprehensive gathering. This is possible only in a locus possessing complete comprehensiveness and perfect receptivity, so that each aspect corresponds to what confronts it. This is the Perfect Human alone, since nothing else is like him. Such manifestation may then be considered either through the comprehensive universality of that affair—as in ‘You did not throw when you threw’—or through the particulars included within it, as when the tree called to Moses, peace be upon him, ‘Indeed, I am God.’

The second case is the essence's manifestation to itself from the side of the loci. It is either manifestation through a particular locus to that locus itself, with its distinguishing particularity—as with the particulars of the world considered in themselves according to their levels—or manifestation to another particular standing over against it through various affinities. Each individual in the world has, in itself, a manifestation to itself. This is the source of the glorification indicated in ‘There is nothing that does not glorify Him with praise.’ Manifestation to another appears in the relations of agreement and opposition among the world's individuals. All four cases can be understood from the author's words ‘collectively and individually’.

QT-030 — Comprehensive divine knowledge and a criticism of Peripatetic causality

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> It also entails knowledge of them in the order that obtains in external existence: a comprehensive and gathered knowledge, not a knowledge partitioned into distinct details. This is not because, as the Peripatetics maintain, knowing a cause entails knowing an effect that is existentially separate from it. Quiddities and the fixed entities are neither made nor caused in themselves. To consider them intelligible is to consider them as not distinct, in external reality, from the essence that knows. Insofar as they are regarded as distinct from it, they are not actually existent here, nor are they intelligible in the sense accepted by the investigators among the Peripatetics—namely, as a thing's being present to a receptive cause or to a productive, necessitating cause distinct from it. It is thus incorrect to say that they depend on that essence in either of the two non-incidental modes of existence.

SH-030 — Ordered divine knowledge without externally separated known objects

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: having explained the reality that is one through genuine unity and intimated how conceptual multiplicity arises from it in an ordered existence, the author now wishes to indicate the limits of Peripatetic understanding of this question and the source of their mistaken conceptions.

The reality's apprehension of itself includes the apprehension of all its attributes in the manner described. It also necessitates their apprehension according to the firm, ordered sequence of external existence, in an undifferentiated and comprehensive cognition, not a detailed one. No differentiation of governing properties has any scope in this presence, as repeatedly explained. For the essence's manifestation in its entirety and the oneness of its comprehensive gathering—one of the four cases necessarily included in its awareness—cannot be apprehended without an ordering relation giving some particulars precedence and placing others after them. Otherwise neither comprehensiveness nor its oneness could be conceived.

This is what necessitates knowledge of the existential order, not the Peripatetic claim that knowledge of a cause necessitates knowledge of an effect separate from it in existence. Having denied volition and the will which determines a freely choosing agent, they were compelled to posit an attribute of the Principle that requires this ordered arrangement. They call it providence: the representation of the order within the Creator's knowledge, understood as the presence to Him of the first effect together with the ordered effects it encompasses from eternity to eternity. Their account rests upon the premise that knowing the cause necessitates knowing an effect separated from it.

An account founded upon what is false must be unsound. It presupposes that quiddities and fixed entities, insofar as they are separate from the essence in existence, have existence through themselves, whether described as made or as caused, according to the two positions. Yet it has already been explained that, under this consideration, the entities have never caught the scent of existence. Sheer nonbeing cannot be made or caused.

One might think that this contradicts the earlier assertion that the Necessary's apprehension of His essence entails apprehension of the other attributes and entities because they are identical with it. That assertion apparently requires the entities to exist, whereas the present assertion denies their existence. Hence the author's clarification: quiddities and entities are considered as intelligible precisely insofar as they are not different from the knowing essence. This differs from considering them made or caused things separate from it in existence. Since the considerations differ, the judgments are not incompatible.

Why is their intelligibility considered only insofar as they are not different from the knowing essence? Because, insofar as they are different, they have no existence at all, either externally or intellectually. Not externally: under this consideration they would be separate from the essence in external existence. But nothing so separate can exist externally, since existence has been shown to be one reality in itself, with no separation

among its instances. What is separate from existence qua existence therefore cannot exist externally.

Nor intellectually: intelligibility in the sense maintained by the accomplished Peripatetic investigator is a thing's presence either to a receptive cause—the impression through which cognition is explained, called receptive knowledge—or to a necessitating efficient cause—the presence called active knowledge. Neither applies to quiddities under the consideration at issue. Insofar as they are different from the knowing essence, they would be separate from existence in the way a cause, receptive or efficient, is separate from its effect. But what is separate from existence qua existence cannot possess any share of existence or presence, either in itself or for another. Moreover, the intelligible, precisely as intelligible, must not differ from its knower except through a kind of relation. Something separate from another in existence cannot, under that consideration, be intelligible to it, as explained earlier.

This is supported by the statement of a realized practitioner of spiritual taste: ‘Knowledge of something—whatever kind of knowledge—according to sound spiritual taste and clear unveiling is the knower's beholding that known object within himself through the common element by which knower and known are united and not different. It is also his beholding it through the factor distinguishing known from knower, on account of which one is called known and the other knower. In undifferentiated oneness there is neither such naming nor plurality. Even in this second case, which requires distinction, there must be a meaning shared by knowledge, knower, and known: namely distinction itself, together with another necessary concomitant which may not be disclosed.’

I have quoted these words here because this question is so remote from the apprehension of reasoners lacking sound spiritual taste. Perhaps they will reflect upon the implications of these clear expressions and God will acquaint them with something of the hidden meanings indicated. That is no difficult matter for God.

Once it is established that quiddities and entities, considered as different from the essence, have no share in existence, existence cannot be attributed to or considered with them under that consideration. If existence is nevertheless attributed to them in any respect, it can only be real intrinsic existence. It would then be incorrect to say that they depend on the knowing essence in respect of either of the two non-suppositional modes of existence [the displayed reading]. The existence attributed to the quiddity would be real intrinsic existence, in respect of which its subject cannot depend on anything. Dependence belongs only to something existent through suppositional existence [with ‘incidental existence’ reported as an alternative], whose independent standing has been denied.

In sum, if quiddities and entities are taken with the consideration of otherness, they are necessarily nonexistent and cannot be qualified as made, caused, or by any other attribute. If taken without that consideration, existence can be attributed to them, but they cannot be qualified by what entails dependence and need, such as being made or caused. For the

existence then attributed is real existence, which possesses absolute self-sufficiency. Thus the account of making and causation criticized here is unsound on either supposition.

QT-031 — Knowing and being known do not necessitate two divine realities

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> If it is objected: ‘Being an intellective knower stands opposite to being an intelligible object; where all difference is absent, there can be neither knowing nor being known.’ We reply: If your claim were universally sound, neither the Necessary Existent nor any separate angelic intellect could know itself. Here, however, difference obtains only through an intellectual consideration, as is the case when those quiddities are considered distinct from the knowing essence. It is evident that, precisely insofar as they are distinct from it, those quiddities are only relations and determining connections, without actual extramental differentiation among themselves, because their underlying reality is one with that true unity. Thus none of them, considered under that aspect, can be said to exist in either mode of existence at this level. Yet insofar as they are identical with that identity in external reality, they are present to it through its own presence to itself.

SH-031 — Self-intellection, relational opposition, and the coloured-glass analogy

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this indicates a possible objection and its answer. On your position, quiddities and entities are intelligible only insofar as they are not different from the knowing essence. But that is impossible: knowing and being known stand in the opposition of correlatives, which can be conceived only when the two relations are realized in subjects distinct in existence. Without otherness between their subjects, there can be neither knowing nor being known.

The author answers in two ways. The first is a dialectical counter-instance. If the premises asserting the opposition of knowing and being known and the necessary existential and real difference between their subjects were sound, neither the Necessary through Himself nor any immaterial angel could know itself, even according to the opponent. But that is not their position. This answer, however, does not remove the difficulty; it merely extends the range of cases affected. The author therefore indicates a substantive explanation which uproots its source. Although the difference between knowing and being known is an oppositional difference, consideration alone suffices for it to arise. Consideration similarly suffices for the very real quiddities that ground opposition and difference, since their occurrence and existence at this level are conceivable through consideration alone. What derives its existence from them has an even stronger claim to the same account.

Why does consideration suffice for the occurrence of these quiddities? Insofar as quiddities differ from the essence, they are nothing but determining relations and correlations. You have learned that genuine unity, expressed as all-encompassing unrestricted existence, outside which there is sheer nonbeing and nullity, makes another thing outside it impossible:

‘Indeed, everything apart from God is null.’

Quiddities insofar as they are different therefore have no realization at all. But that reality requires manifestation as disclosure and self-beholding through disclosure. The levels of its manifestations differ in clarity and hiddenness according to our apprehension, not according to the reality itself. When we compare one manifestation with another, we find some clearer and more complete to our faculties because their effects are more abundant in the domain of manifestation, and others less complete because their effects are fewer. Comparing them produces a relative distinction according to our apprehension alone. These multiple manifestations and their determinations are therefore cognitive relations and conceptually considered correlations. The reality itself remains free of them.

Consider sunlight. When its ray falls upon polished bodies of different colours, such as pieces of coloured glass, some portions of the ray inevitably appear relatively distinct from others, with a multiplicity considered according to our apprehension. Estimation judges the light itself to have taken on the colours. The reality is otherwise: light has no colour of its own in the terms of the analogy; its radiance becomes apparent in the glass, and colours are seen in it. Thus those quiddities occur through conceptually considered determinations.

It follows that there is no actual extramental distinction among them at this level. Such a distinction would require their subjects to be externally distinct and multiple, whereas their subject is one through genuine unity. None of the quiddities, insofar as it differs from that identity, can therefore be said to exist in either mode of existence in this subject—that is, at this level. Yet insofar as they are externally identical with that identity, they are present to it as it is present to itself. They are existent under the consideration of this relative presence and their relation to it; the relation is a matter of consideration alone. Reflect on what you have heard, for it is the fullest clarification at this point. Perhaps God will bring you to the goal.

QT-032 — Manifestation from hiddenness into witnessing

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> It then entailed manifestation and emergence from the realm of the unseen into that of witnessing, the actual presence of those attributes and determinations as differentiated in external reality, and their intellectual apprehension in detail.

SH-032 — The Breath of the All-Merciful and the unfolding of the names

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: in the first determination, which gathers comprehensive unity and undifferentiated oneness together and is called intrinsic unity or absolute identity, the governing properties of hiddenness and existence predominate over those of manifestation and making manifest. The meanings of the names and determinations considered there are consequently not distinguished. There is no otherness at all: even the multiplicity considered there is identical with unity, as you have learned.

There is thus no scope there for those determinations to appear in the manner required by the perfection of the names, namely the appearance of that identity in the determinations of the names according to their particular character. The levels that serve as their loci of manifestation and as the settings of their differentiation remain hidden and enfolded, their governing properties absorbed. They resemble the letters absorbed and enfolded in a person's breath while it remains at its source, within the chest and the heart's grasp, before emerging through the levels of articulation and appearing with its many determinate properties.

That identity accordingly requires manifestation and emergence—not insofar as it is the essence itself, but insofar as its considerations and affairs require it, in response to their petitions through the tongues of their most holy preparednesses and receptivities. From that disclosure and its innermost hiddenness there arises a volitional inclination, a movement of love, and a loving yearning toward disclosure through another determination and a more manifest mode. It is like an outspread breath through which those attributes and entities can become actually distinct, as letters are distinguished when breath spreads toward the points of articulation. They can then be conceived in detail, in accordance with the levels of the perfection of the names.

This disclosure is called the Breath of the All-Merciful. One reason is its resemblance to human breath, a vaporous reality simple in itself whose particulars differ through the qualities assumed at the levels of articulation. The Breath of the All-Merciful is the underlying material for the world's forms, just as breath is the material for the forms of letters and words. Another reason is that through it distress is relieved. As the Shaykh, may God be pleased with him, says in the Bezels of Wisdom:

‘The world appeared in the Breath of the All-Merciful, through which God relieved the divine names of the distress they experienced from the nonmanifestation of their effects, by manifesting their effects. He thus bestowed favour upon Himself through what He brought into being in His Breath. The first effect of the Breath was therefore in that presence. Thereafter the process continued its descent through the relief of griefs until the last thing brought into being.

All is within the very Breath,
like light within the twilight.
Knowledge through demonstration [comes]
as daylight is stripped away for one who dozes.
He sees what I have said
in a vision pointing to the Breath.
It relieves him of every grief,
as in his recitation of “He frowned”.
He disclosed Himself to the one
who came in search of a firebrand.
He saw Him as fire, though He is light
among kings and among night-watchmen.
If you understand my saying,
know that you are afflicted.
Had he sought something other than this,
he would have seen Him in it and not turned back.’

I have quoted the whole of this passage here because it contains matters directly relevant to the present treatise. Reflect.

QT-033 — The worlds of spirits, image, and bodies

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> It then brought into manifestation the world of spirits—that is, the world of intellects and souls—for the disclosure of munificence there is more complete than in the world of meanings; then the imaginal world; then the world of bodies. In the latter world the manifestation of existence reached completion, for existential self-disclosure attained its fullness with the origination of the first celestial body: the sphere delimiting spatial directions, the bodily Throne, identified in divine discourse with the station of ‘establishment’. As for the order obtaining in each of these worlds, the subdivisions of the levels contained within them, and the summary of proofs and demonstrations concerning each of these matters, we have treated them fully in our other writings devoted to philosophical science.

SH-033 — Divine action, the worlds, and the five comprehensive levels

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: after explaining the divine level and the preceding levels determined through disclosure—required by essential perfection, in which the properties of the essence's unrestrictedness and real existence predominate over the determinations of the names and their considered manifestation—the author turns to the levels determined through self-beholding in disclosure. These are required by the perfection of the names, in which

determinations and their considered manifestation predominate over the essence's unrestrictedness and real existence. What was manifest in the earlier levels becomes hidden here, and what was hidden there becomes manifest here. This is the intended sense of the saying, ‘The inward aspect of creation is the manifest aspect of the Real, and the outward aspect of creation is the hidden aspect of the Real.’

Before these levels, the names creation, bringing into existence, and the other expressions suggesting an agent distinguished from its product are not used. For the people of realization, bringing into existence means the conjunction of the most holy receptivities fixed in the first determination—the source of determinations and receptivities—with the manifest aspect of existence, the outward side of the Breath of the All-Merciful. What results from the conjunction of two distinct terms differs from both, as a child differs from its parents and a conclusion from its premises. It possesses a particular existence in its own right, to which judgments appropriate to independently existing things can be attributed, such as the inscription of the forms of existents, and effects ascribed to them can belong to it. Hence they call it a world, and call the relation between it and its principle bringing into existence and creation.

A preliminary distinction of considerable benefit must be understood. An act may be attributed to the Real through His essence: the act follows from Him with no intermediary between His essence and the product except an intelligible relation distinguishing it from essential unrestrictedness. At this level the product is called exalted letters, original letters, or first keys, and also keys of the unseen, names of the essence, and original affairs. These designations correspond to ordered considerations descending within the first determination.

In the second determination, the presence in which known things are inscribed within the domain of essential knowledge, the distinction is relational. This is the presence meant by the great masters of realization and the divinized sages when they say that things are inscribed within the Real Himself. There is, however, a difference here between the taste of the sage and that of the person of realization. For the latter, inscription qualifies knowledge insofar as knowledge is relationally distinguished from the essence. It does not qualify the essence itself, nor knowledge insofar as it is identical with the essence. Under this consideration the things are called intelligible letters, intelligible words, and fixed entities; also divine realities, lordly names, and existential letters [the displayed reading].

Alternatively, the act is mediated: between the Real as agent and what He brings into existence stands an existential instrument or a form serving as a locus of manifestation, required by the level of the product. This is called bringing into existence and saying. Divine speech alludes to this relation by saying, ‘Our saying to a thing, when We will it…’ Under this consideration the things are called existential words, quiddities, and possible entities. Hence this world is called the world of the Command, since command is an expression of saying.

Among the beings within the worlds, the nearest in relation and simplest in essence is the First Intellect. It has only one kind of composition: a quiddity qualified by existence. This is the first level of possibility, and it belongs to the world of spirits. The world nearest in relation to the divine level is therefore the world of spirits. It, not the world of meanings, is the first of the originated worlds, since it possesses existence in its own right, appears according to its determination, and gives rise to the effusion of governing properties and the production of effects. The world of meanings does not do so.

You may ask under what consideration the latter is called a world. We reply: under one of the two aspects necessarily belonging to attributes as attributes, namely that by which they differ from the essence. Since they have no existence under this aspect, it is not counted among the existing worlds. Its status as a world is a matter of consideration alone.

Next is the imaginal world, in which meanings appear through the forms of figures. This additional meaning introduces another kind of composition. Then comes the world of bodies, to which all the foregoing accrues together with being spatially situated and occupying a location. This is the furthest extent of composition, and through it the manifestation of existence is completed: nothing is more intensely manifest than sensible things. Because it reaches the utmost possible multiplicity, it becomes suitable as a locus for existential unity, for what passes its limit reverses into its opposite. When the first body —the mighty Throne, the Throne of the All-Merciful—is brought into existence, existential self-disclosure reaches its completion. This is the station of istiwāʾ in divine speech. One of the linguistic meanings of istiwāʾ is completion, as when one says that a man has attained full stature, meaning that his growth has reached its end and his youth is complete.

There are thus three worlds together with the level of disclosure embracing the two determinations already mentioned: four levels in all. The fifth, comprehending them all, is the human level. These determinate levels are called loci of disclosure, places of display, and horizons of rising. Levels without qualification number six, since they include the hiddenness of identity and nondetermination; here only the determinate levels are counted. The Breath of the All-Merciful pervades and manifests according to these five. The principal articulatory sources of human letters likewise number five in this account: the inner heart, chest, throat, palate, and teeth [with lips reported as an alternative]. They correspond to the levels within the Breath of the All-Merciful.

This order of bringing into existence is also observed in divine speech and the heavenly revealed Book. Its first level is a letter, then a word, then a verse, then a sūra, and the Book comprehends them. The principal revealed books are likewise four: Torah, Gospel, Psalms, and Furqān; the Qurʾān comprehends them.

The same applies to other intellectual or external beings, universal or particular. Intellectual universals have four levels whether considered without hierarchical order—genus, differentia, property, and common accident, with species comprehending them—or in order: highest, intermediate, lowest, and isolated genus, with species comprehending

them. Likewise, external particulars contain four natures, with temperament as the fifth. If those natures combine according to the existential order, the temperament is balanced and completely blended; otherwise it is deficient and incompletely blended. Priority in that order belongs to heat, then moisture, then cold, then dryness. All this arises from the essence's pervasion through the four first names. There are important mysteries and subtle points of great value here, but this book is not the place for their detailed exposition. We have indicated a few in outline; reflect on them and, God willing, further ones will become apparent.

Each of these worlds has detailed subdivisions according to its particular levels and the relations between their governing properties. The world of spirits, for example, contains the levels of immaterial intellects, celestial souls, and human spirits. Each contains particular levels with their own details and governing properties. The same is true of the imaginal world and the world of bodies. But the disciplines charged with explaining all this are natural philosophy and what precedes it. The author, may God have mercy on him, therefore refers their discussion to those disciplines.

QT-034 — Six objections: possibility, generation, imagination, and the scale of perfection

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> If it is objected: ‘On this account, it is impossible to speak of possibility: existence is necessary in itself, whereas quiddities, relations, and relational qualifications are neither made nor caused, for they do not exist and are not even capable of existence. Once this is established, possibility has no place; there can only be necessitation and entailment. This is clear enough to require no lengthy elaboration. Nor can one speak of manifestation. If by manifestation you mean existence itself, it hardly needs further argument to show that existence cannot produce its own manifestation. If you mean existence qualified by a particular determining condition, neither constituent can undergo making or causal production, as indicated earlier. The same applies to the aggregate considered as an aggregate: what subsists in something else does not receive existence either. Intellectual existence admits neither extramental nor intellectual existence; and we have already seen the correct account of the further specifying qualifications beyond those two modes of existence. This concerns the intellectual composite, and need not be repeated. If manifestation means some quiddity or relation, the objections already considered suffice. Nor is there any distinction between your so-called world of meanings and world of witnessing, since the obtaining of existents in both is in reality one and the same. As for names, specific forms, intellectual relations and connections—in short, the fixed entities, which are accidents of existence or of absolute existence—none differs except by subject or locus, and not by intelligible meaning or another accident. Distinguishing summary from detail achieves nothing, because both worlds share the subject that entails those quiddities and attributes: there is no additional condition or realized impediment in one rather than the other. Nor is

> there substance in positing an imaginal world, which most Peripatetics have denied, supporting the denial with decisive demonstrations set out in their works. Finally, the doctrine that the farther a level is from the source of existence, and the nearer it is to pure possibility and sheer nonexistence, the more fully existence is manifested in it, is far from the truth. It would be more reasonable to reverse the assertion: that which is farther from corruption, change and perishing must disclose existence and its distinctive properties more completely.’

SH-034 — Six objections: possibility, causation, manifestation, worlds, imagination, and perfection

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: having established his purpose through the firmest demonstrations, as he undertook to do, refuted opposing doctrines liable to unsettle minds, and answered doubts obstructing the truth's manifestation to students, the author now turns to objections against the fundamental principles and crucial foundations of this account. Such questions reveal the depth and precision of his investigations: through them the knots of accumulated restrictions within beliefs are loosened, and the veils preventing inward vision from apprehending realities are removed. The objection is that the account given of this question is unsound in six respects.

First, on this account the assertion of possibility is invalid. Whether possibility is a positive attribute or a relational meaning, it must have a subject sustaining it, yet nothing available can serve that role. Existence cannot, because it is intrinsically necessary and so cannot be qualified by possibility. Quiddities, understood as relations and correlations arising from attributes, cannot either: on your account they are neither made nor caused, because they do not exist and indeed cannot receive existence. The alternatives are exhausted, so nothing is qualified by possibility.

It should not be replied that this follows only if possibility is a positive real attribute, not if it is a privative conceptual consideration. Even granting the latter, possibility must have a subject to which it is truly predicated and which can receive existence. Impossible things cannot be qualified as possible, since that would reverse their realities. The author's words ‘indeed, incapable of receiving existence’ anticipate this reply.

Second, necessitation and requirement are also plainly invalid. These are relational meanings which can be realized only between distinct things. If what exists, whether essence or attribute, is one, while everything else—the meanings of the names and the fixed entities—is sheer nonbeing, as you maintain, these relations have no conceivable meaning here. Relational meanings cannot subsist in one subject alone. This is evident without lengthy explanation.

Third, manifestation here appears to have no conceivable meaning. What is intended must be either existence itself or the entities grounding its relations and correlations. In the former case it must be unrestricted or qualified existence. The qualification must then either be an extramental individuating determination or an intellectual specification producing a kind. None of these alternatives works. If manifestation means unrestricted existence itself, the absurdity of existence's requiring manifestation needs no further explanation: a thing does not require itself.

If qualified existence is intended, and the qualifications are individuating determinations occurring in the cosmic realm, neither component of the qualified whole can receive making or causal influence. As already indicated in the demonstration, existence cannot be acted upon, nor can privative matters, since nonbeing too cannot receive influence. Manifestation preceded by hiddenness, which requires such influence, is therefore inconceivable in either. The same holds of the aggregate as aggregate: what depends on something incapable of receiving existence is itself incapable of receiving it.

If the qualifications are instead universal intellectual specifications accruing to existences and making existence intellectual, their subject cannot receive either mode of existence. Two identical instances cannot be combined any more than incompatible ones can. The author's words ‘As for intellectual existence, it receives neither external nor intellectual existence’ reject this alternative. The specifying qualifications fare no better: apart from the two modes of existence, these qualifications have been shown to reduce to nonbeing, which cannot receive existence. The same applies to the aggregate of the universal specification and what it qualifies, since that would compose a thing out of existence and something else. This has repeatedly been discussed and need not be repeated.

If manifestation means the entities understood as the affirmation of quiddities, relations, and correlations insofar as they differ from existence, their incapacity for existence and manifestation has already been explained. No further elaboration is needed.

Fourth, on your principles there is no intelligible distinction between the world of meanings and the witnessed world, or between the other worlds. Particular existences throughout them are in truth one, without difference. Any difference would have to arise from the nature of existence, which serves as their receptacle and subject; from the fixed entities, which are relations and correlations accruing to existence; or from the collective configuration arising between the two. These are the only possibilities, and none is viable.

The names, specific forms, intellectual relations and correlations—in short, fixed entities accruing to existence—are sheer nonentities insofar as they are fixed entities, abstracting from existence. They cannot therefore ground anything. Unrestricted existence is genuinely one, as established, so how can it ground multiple differences? The external configuration has the same status as the other accruing features: sheer nonbeing. There is thus no difference in subject or receptacle, which is intrinsically one, in the meaning of the names, or through any accruing feature.

Speaking of undifferentiation and differentiation is therefore empty wording here. Both worlds—indeed, all worlds—share the subject that requires and sustains those quiddities and attributes. None has a condition of realization absent from another, nor an obstacle excluding it, since everything other than the one subject has been declared sheer nonbeing.

Fifth, asserting a world called the imaginal world is likewise a corrupt imagining and an empty expression. Most Peripatetics deny it and have recorded powerful arguments and decisive demonstrations against it in their books. What so great a multitude has maintained and established by conclusive demonstrations cannot be contrary to reality. Otherwise confidence in certainties and in the probative force of demonstration would disappear altogether.

Sixth, your established principle—that the further something is from the source of existence and the nearer it is to sheer possibility and nonbeing, the more complete and perfect existence's manifestation within it becomes—is very far from the truth. It would be preferable to reverse the account. Self-evidence shows that proximity of any kind allows the effect of one of two distinct interacting things to appear in the other, whereas remoteness opposes this. In the present case, things farthest from corruption, change, and cessation, such as intellects and souls near the Principle, unquestionably display more of existence's governing properties and manifest its distinctive character more completely. Things susceptible to generation and corruption, remaining on no steady course even for an hour, such as the sensible world and the neighbouring world of images, are remote from the Principle and display it less completely.

QT-035 — What bears possibility? Existing quiddities versus existence itself

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

We reply: the subjects of possibility, and the things to which it naturally pertains, are determinations. We do not grant that quiddities, relations, and relational connections are incapable of existence. If existence were conjoined with them, they would thereby become existent. Among determinations, some naturally have external existence as their subject; others have intellectual existence as their subject; still others naturally have absolute existence as their subject. Admittedly, they do not exist by an existence identical with their own essence or constituting one of their essential elements. And although a quiddity considered precisely in itself is neither made nor caused, it does not follow that existing quiddities are neither made nor caused. When they become existent through conjunction with existence, their being-existent necessarily depends upon that conjunction with existence, which is distinct from them. It is not necessary for every existent to exist through itself: some things are existent only incidentally. Consider this. This being-existent is one of the intellect's considerations; hence even privative attributes and mental accidents may be predicated as existing. Whoever regards absolute existence itself as a mere intellectual consideration has perhaps failed to distinguish it from this being-existent, confusing the two categories and relegating the

> self-realized reality that grounds all other realities to the status of a mere mental consideration. Understand this.

SH-035 — Possible determinations, accidental existence, and the recovery of making and causation

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this begins the dissolution of those difficulties and the answering of those objections, while establishing the principles and foundations so that doubts cannot weaken or shake them. The answer to the first is that the subjects of possibility and of its associated determinations—being made, caused, originated, and the like—are relative determinations. As explained in the prolegomenon, possibility is described in relation to objects of knowledge. The displayed wording speaks of existence in relation to the known, then of the manifest aspect of knowledge distinguished from existence by its relation to the known [the clause is textually disordered; see note].

Those determinations which are known are the states and attributes of existence, according to which alone existence is apprehended. Whatever cognition reaches of existence is its attributes and states accruing at levels where the governing properties of its unrestrictedness and unity are absorbed. As states, accidents, and features accruing to existence, they require conjunction with it. How, then, can they be called wholly incapable of existence? When they are conjoined with existence and existence with them, they necessarily exist. Considered in themselves, apart from their subject and conjunction with it, they deserve neither existence nor nonbeing. Under that consideration they require only the absence of an intrinsic claim to either. This is the meaning of possibility.

We therefore do not concede that the relative determinations naturally serving as subjects of possibility cannot receive existence. Their natures require no intrinsic entitlement to existence, not an intrinsic entitlement to nonbeing. When existence accompanies those states and they accompany it, they necessarily become existent. If their natures intrinsically required nonbeing without qualification [the reported alternative reading], something intrinsically impossible would become existent through the necessity of an attribute, which is plainly impossible. It is therefore the absence of an intrinsic claim to either existence or nonbeing that belongs to the natures of determinations. This is the meaning of ‘The subjects of possibility and what pertains to it are determinations.’

Although determinations as such require this absence of intrinsic entitlement, as states and attributes of existence they naturally require existence at some level to serve as their subject. Some have external existence as their natural subject because they are judgments specific to that level. Others have intellectual existence as their natural subject because they belong specifically to the intellectual level. Still others naturally have unrestricted existence as their subject. Under this consideration the determinations necessarily exist. Yet they do not exist through an existence identical with them or constituting one of their

components. When they are said to be incapable of existence, that is the sense intended and no other.

Up to this point the author has prepared the answer. His words ‘Even if quiddities…’ begin to reject the questioner's premises: that quiddities are neither made nor caused because they neither exist nor can receive existence, and therefore cannot be subjects of possibility. The answer is that, even if quiddities considered simply as themselves are neither made nor caused in the sense just explained, it does not follow that quiddities to which existence is joined, and which exist through that conjunction, are neither made nor caused. Once they become existent through the conjunction of existence extrinsic to their own essence, they necessarily depend for their existence on that accompanying factor, which is distinct from them. Being caused or made means precisely dependence in existence on an extrinsic factor.

An objection may be raised: you have maintained that existence is one reality, that everything besides it is sheer nonbeing, and that multiplicity is a privative matter with no realization in itself. How can you now admit anything suggesting multiple existences or what follows from such multiplicity? We reply that existence is indeed one reality, existent through itself, and that everything outside this one is sheer nonbeing. But the one has states, as repeatedly explained, in which it manifests according to their character. Every cognition reaches those states according to that character. The one simply as itself is neither conceived nor apprehended.

If existence is attributed to an apprehended state on the basis of the effects witnessed there, that existent is existent incidentally, not through itself. The attribution depends only on the perceiver's estimation and consideration; what exists in itself contains no relation. Relations as considered by estimation do not alter the realities of things. The saying ‘Divine unity is the removal of attributions’ points to this meaning. The author's ‘Not every existent must exist through itself’ indicates this objection and answer. The explanation given makes apparent what requires reflection in the author's wording; do not overlook it.

The existence attributed to quiddities, related to determinations, and predicated of them is thus a conceptually considered meaning, occurring only through the consideration of the cognitive faculties. As you have learned, it has no corresponding counterpart outside them. Their apprehended existentness is therefore an intellectual consideration and can also attach to negative attributes and privative features.

Perhaps later thinkers who made unrestricted existence itself an intellectual consideration failed to distinguish it from the states in which they apprehend it, where the properties of unity and unrestrictedness are absorbed. Confusing the two, they treated the reality that is true through itself and grounds all other realities as a merely considered matter. Understand this. Such a mistake is unsurprising: someone who, guided by cross-eyed inward sight, attempts to approach this sanctuary resembles a rider mounted upon blindness, stumbling about at random.

ADDITIONAL ORIGINAL QUOTATION

Speaking of manifestation here means unrestricted reality's becoming determined through a determination. You have learned that what naturally bears possibility is the determinations.

SH-035-B — Manifestation is determination, not existence produced from nothing

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this indicates how the second and third difficulties are resolved. Manifestation here does not mean that a thing was nonexistent and then existed, nor that it was hidden from the senses and then became perceptible. Rather, absolute identity entails pure genuine unity, which excludes the consideration of relations and correlations. It therefore does not admit the attribution of manifestation and similar meanings, since these entail multiplicity, as you have learned. Even supposing it to be the subject of one of two opposed terms, after considering their opposition, only hiddenness would be attributed to it. The language of the revealed law expresses this in ‘I was a hidden treasure’, because hiddenness involves the nonmanifestation that consists in the absence of multiplicity. Even this is considered only after descent from pure unrestrictedness and the consideration of relations, since no relation has any standing in that presence itself.

Manifestation therefore consists in descent from pure unrestrictedness and unity into association with qualifications and the coloration of multiple determinations. Realities become manifest through what stands opposite them. For, in the precise account, manifestation is the manifest reality's assuming the form of its effect. There must therefore be a receptive term opposite it, capable of being affected, so that it acts upon that term, the term receives its influence, and the reality appears through its form, making it a locus of manifestation. Reflection shows this rule operating at every level, even sensible things. Unless the sun's rays reach a dense body capable of confronting and receiving them, they do not act upon it or appear through its form in colours and lights; subtle transparent bodies are not receptive to illumination in the sense intended by this analogy.

The same applies to natural qualities. Without action and reception between them, the agent cannot appear in an affected form so that a third thing distinct from agent and recipient results from their intermixture. Otherwise the mixture is sterile and defective.

Determinations, as you have learned, are what naturally bear possibility. They are therefore nonexistent considered through themselves and can stand opposite unrestricted existence, receive its influence, and allow it to appear through their forms. You may object that determinations could be intrinsically nonexistent only if they required nonbeing, whereas it has been established that in themselves they require neither existence nor nonbeing. We reply that their not requiring existence suffices for their being nonexistent through themselves. If the determinations do not provide a cause requiring existence, they are

nonexistent when considered in themselves, since the absence of existence's cause suffices as a cause of nonbeing. They may exist through something extrinsic to their essences, but when that factor is left out of consideration, nonbeing alone belongs to them. This is what we mean when we say that nonbeing is intrinsic to the possible.

The two objections are now answered. The second is answered because, on this account, necessitation and requirement operate in respect of these possible determinations, which are the reality's loci of manifestation and disclosure. This is evident without further explanation. The third is answered by saying that manifestation is attributed to those determinations.

You may object, repeating the author's formulation of the difficulty, that the determinations are sheer nonentities. We reply that this is so only when they are considered merely as determinations. It is not so when they are considered as states of existence, conjoined with it and serving as loci through which it manifests. Determinations are considered at one time as genuine multiplicity, under which consideration they are sheer nonentities, and at another as the subject of unity, under which consideration they exist. They can then be qualified by manifestation and the other existential meanings requiring existent subjects, such as necessitation and requirement.

QT-036 — Kinds and modes of manifestation at successive levels

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> As for the specific nature which embraces both the externally realized kind and its intelligible counterpart: when it entails external manifestation, it becomes determinate through external determination, and the attributes necessarily belonging to it become external as well. Through some of its attributes there then arise other determinate external kinds complete in themselves; and through other attributes there arise other external kinds not complete in themselves. Again, the text speaks of other attributes giving rise to further external kinds not complete in themselves, with everything belonging to the higher level distinguished from everything in the manifestation immediately below it. Reflect on this point so that the distinction between the two cases and between the two worlds becomes evident. For a thing's presence in unrestricted being, insofar as it is unrestricted being, occurs according to unrestrictedness. A full account of this question would require a much more extensive discussion than this short treatise permits; consult our book entitled *al-Ḥikmah al-Manīʿah*.

SH-036 — Distinguishing the worlds by analogy with substances and dependent properties

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this prepares a preliminary point from which the answer to the fourth difficulty can be understood. The objection originates in minds accustomed to sensible things and nearby levels, whose understanding therefore fails to apprehend levels remote from sense. They need indicative premises and explanatory comparisons that bring those levels within reach, so that they may pass beyond the limitation at which they have stopped. Demonstrative premises have little role here: at most they can remove an alleged impossibility and show that the proposed reality may be established. The author therefore confines himself to an illustrative case that serves this purpose. It suffices for an intelligent student with sound spiritual taste; for someone lacking these, multiplying premises and demonstrations will not suffice either.

The example is that the unrestricted nature, encompassing both the external and intellectual kinds, requires external manifestation through the existential movement of love already mentioned. It therefore becomes determined by an external determination: extramental individuating factors and states accruing to entities outside the mind, such as subsistence in existence, admitting the supposition of dimensions, and what follows from these. The attributes necessarily accompanying those states are likewise external: occupying space, assuming shape, receiving colours and positions, and the like.

When that nature manifests according to some of its external states, such as substance, there result determinate kinds complete in themselves: independently existent, not dependent on something else for their existence. These are called the realities upon which others depend. Through other attributes, or manifestation according to other states, there result external kinds incomplete in themselves, dependent on something else in existence. They are called dependent realities and occurring forms, such as the divisions of quantity and quality.

Intellectual existence, considered precisely as such, belongs to this latter division, so it is not separately discussed. External existence thus has two kinds ordered in manifestation. Every substantial reality in the higher level is distinguished from every accidental form in the level following and below it.

Now, if qualified external existence can have two comprehensive levels ordered as dependent and independent, with everything in the higher distinguished from everything in the lower, it is still more fitting that unrestricted existence encompassing both it and what stands opposite it should admit a similar ordering. Reflect on this point and the difference between unrestricted existence and qualified external existence will become apparent, and with it the difference between the two worlds.

The world of meanings is existence divested of formal determinations and extramental individuating conditions. A thing's occurrence in unrestricted being corresponds to unrestrictedness: it is stripped of its external, intellectual, and imaginal determinations and the forms following them. The beings of the world of meanings are therefore free of those individuating conditions, whereas those of the witnessed and imaginal worlds must be

surrounded by them. The difference between the world of meanings and the witnessed world is thus precisely that between unrestricted and restricted. Here unrestricted must be understood as what encompasses the external and intellectual, as indicated at the beginning of this preliminary account, not the genuinely unrestricted itself, in which the occurrence of another thing is impossible.

Although this explanation carries the inquiry as far as it can go here, it indicates only the existence of that world in outline. It does not disclose its reality. The author therefore refers the detailed investigation to al-Ḥikma al-Manīʿa [the displayed title, whose textual form remains uncertain].

> ADDITIONAL ORIGINAL QUOTATION
>
> The same extended discussion applies to the imaginal world. We have treated it fully there. The purpose of this brief work is to establish another inquiry; embarking upon this subject here would therefore be superfluous.

SH-036-B — Establishing the imaginal world's existence without digressing into its full reality

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this points to the answer to the fifth question. The method is the same as in answering the fourth; indeed, the same example serves. The imaginal world's relation to the witnessed world is likewise precisely the relation of unrestricted to restricted, as was explained in establishing the world of meanings. That comparison suffices to establish its existence, which is what the objection disputes.

Explaining its reality and investigating its full account lie outside the purpose of this treatise. Undertaking that discussion here would therefore be superfluous. The objection is removed without it, and the purpose for which these discussions are arranged does not depend on it. Their end is to establish divine unity as maintained by the Sufis who possess the truth. That has already been explained in the fullest manner. But comparing their fundamental principles with the rules of reflective investigators gives rise to doubts which must be answered separately.

One of these concerns the imaginal world's existence—the simple question whether it is. Since this can be explained through the same illustrative case that establishes the world of meanings, the author is content to use it in answering the objection. Explaining the reality of either world serves neither the treatise's purpose nor the resolution of these doubts. It is therefore not a necessary part of this inquiry, and addressing it would be superfluous.

QT-037 — Why greater manifestation may occur at the lowest ontological level

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> As for calling the manifestation of existence ‘more complete’ at the final level, perhaps what is meant is this: a thing apprehended comprehensively in an undifferentiated way, understood in detail, represented in imagination, apprehended by estimation, and perceived by the outward senses possesses more numerous and complete existential properties and effects than something that is not apprehended through all these modes. It is evident that the apprehending and acting ‘that-it-is’ at the final level is subject to all these modes of apprehension, unlike the apprehending and acting ‘that-it-is’ at the remaining levels above it. Consider this.

SH-037 — Why a lower level can display more comprehensive manifestation

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this investigation resolves the final difficulty. What they mean by the greater perfection of the last level in the manifestation of existence is the variety of the ways in which existence appears and the multiplicity of its effects. A level is an effect serving as the form and locus of manifestation of its cause. The more ways the cause appears in that effect, and the more comprehensively the effect receives its diverse operations, the more complete it necessarily is. This is evident in sensible examples.

A thing may be apprehended in an undifferentiated way through its universal attributes and general concomitants, such as being existent and alive. It may also be intellectually apprehended in detail according to its quiddity and reality, through its essential and constitutive features, such as sensation, movement, and rational speech. These considerations concern its universal reality. Considered in its particular individuation and external determination, when absent from the senses and remote it may be imagined according to its individual form, with a determinate quantity, quality, and position. It may be apprehended by estimation through the particular meanings determining it, such as specific relations: being one person's father, another's son, a lover, a beloved, and so on. When present and near, it may be perceived through the external senses.

The effects and properties of existence are unquestionably more numerous in something apprehensible through all these levels than in something not apprehensible through them all. Its one determination, the furthest goal of the movement that brings into existence, encompasses all these multiple varieties of manifestation. Manifestation through the oneness of the gathering of gathering is the goal.

Other corporeal material things also encompass these receptive ways of being manifested and apprehended, but lack the corresponding active ways of making manifest, apprehending, and operating. The exception is their final level, the elemental human constitution. Just as it comprehends all ways and levels of appearing, it comprehends all levels of making manifest. The cognizing and operating existent reality within it apprehends through all these modes. The cognizing and operating realities at the other levels, intellects and souls, do not have the same variety of modes of apprehension.

The human level therefore possesses a unity of comprehensive gathering from each side, manifestation and making manifest. It is in truth the meeting of the two seas, receptivity and agency. Hence its reality is expressed as the distance of two bows, the bows of necessity and possibility. This question will be explained more fully below, God willing.

It should not be objected that the question applies to every descending level compared with the one above it, whereas the author's answer concerns only the final level, so that the two do not correspond. We reply that, although the illustrative form adopted to bring the argument within students' understanding apparently concerns the last level, a discerning reader can see how to generalize it. When each descending level is closely compared with what is above, the effect of manifestation proves more complete and its modes more numerous: animals compared with plants, plants with minerals, minerals with their simple constituents, and so forth. In each lower case the modes of manifestation are more comprehensive. This is the explanation from effects which the author provides to assist understanding.

The explanation of why this occurs is that manifestation to cognitive faculties corresponds to the concealment of the reality and its intrinsic unrestricted properties, and to the appearance of the relations of the names. This proceeds through the accumulation of possible qualifications and the mutual reflection of cosmic aspects. Every level lower in existential rank must contain more such qualifications, because it includes those of the higher level together with what becomes proper to it in its descent. The lower it is, the more properties and governing characteristics it comprehends; and the more comprehensive it is, the more complete it is. Perfection consists in the comprehensiveness which entails divine vicegerency, as you will learn, God willing.

This is the meaning on which the people of this discipline agree. But the author aims to silence the opponent by the method he has undertaken, so it would be improper argumentative procedure simply to place the school's accepted propositions among his premises. He therefore leaves their customary expressions for an account functioning as an inference from effects, making the disputed matter as accessible as direct observations, about which no sound mind can doubt. His words ‘Perhaps they intended’ indicate this choice.

QT-038 — The perfected human being, stable cognitive dispositions, and death

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> The perfected human being attains perfection only through acquiring stable dispositions for these modes of apprehension in their respective degrees. Sensory apprehension, together with the restrictions naturally attending it, does not preclude the other kinds of apprehension, which generally become available only through effort and deliberate choice. Nor does death truly diminish the soul; rather, it perfects it, for perfected souls retain after death the capacity for all they were capable of before it. Establishing this

> thesis and its necessary distinctions would require a longer exposition than this concise treatise allows.

SH-038 — Sensory discipline, the holy faculty, and the soul's perfection after death

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers something that may occur to seekers of guidance. If diversity of apprehension perfects a person and brings perfection, as you maintain, it cannot also obstruct perfection: a positive preparatory cause cannot become an impediment. Yet the consequent is plainly false, since spiritual guides direct students and travellers to restrain their cognitive faculties and prevent the instrumental senses from acting upon their objects.

Moreover, death would then diminish souls, because it strips them of bodily faculties which are causes of perfection. Being deprived of what produces perfection is clearly a complete deficiency. The author answers the first objection by denying that particular apprehensions as such prevent perfection. The human being's perfection consists in acquiring stable capacities for these apprehensions at their appropriate levels. What guides do with students aims to acquire this capacity and train their faculties so that sensory perceptions and their accompanying restrictions no longer obstruct the other modes, which for most people arise only through deliberate acquisition and chosen effort.

A deeper account is needed here, containing important mysteries apprehended only after refinement of the inward secret and purification of the heart. Beyond the familiar external and internal modes of apprehension, a human being has another, unfamiliar kind. Its relation to them is like that of a genus to its specific portions, which are forms of its diversification. This is a person's apprehending through his unrestricted reality and hidden secret, through the disclosure concealed within him and determined from the Real's intrinsic unrestrictedness by his comprehensive preparedness. Through that preparedness he receives his particular share of unrestricted existence.

This determination is in truth the attribute necessarily accompanying the form in which the thing is eternally known to the Real. It specifies the relation of knowledge, which entails the relation of will. The existentially productive orientation is ascribed to will among the possibilities, seeking to bring the intended thing into existence. This is the thing referred to in the words, ‘Our saying to a thing, when We will it, is only to say to it: Be, and it is.’

The divine orientation that brings into existence proceeds from the unrestricted Real but becomes determined and qualified through the preparedness of that toward which it is directed. It is therefore said to accompany every existent. Through this consideration we conceive the Real's being with things and His sustaining them: this orientation causes each thing's existence and preserves it. It is called existential replenishment. Through that

orientation and disclosure, replenishment reaches the existent from the Real in the form of existence sustaining it. Through the same aspect it longs to seek the Real, know Him, and draw near to Him. Without it there would be no established affinity joining the possible as possible to the Real as necessary.

A human being's apprehension through inward spiritual faculties, rather than bodily ones, occurs through the aid reaching him from the Real's essential knowledge, which is not different from Him in respect of that disclosure. This comes from the station of the name Hidden, one of the attributes of the determination comprehending the other determinations. Apprehension through bodily faculties also occurs through that aid, but from the level of the name Manifest. [The displayed text immediately adds ‘not from the level of the name Manifest’; this repetition or displaced negation leaves the sentence textually unsettled.]

Now suppose that a human being follows the path of the people of realization through detachment, purification, and the other disciplines taught by an experienced traveller. The governing properties of his possible multiplicity are absorbed into his comprehensive unities, and those unities into the oneness of his fixed entity, the form of being known just described. In his true orientation through the disclosure mentioned, he seeks connection with the Real through witnessing and knowledge. The effect of union between this determinate disclosure and the unrestricted Real then becomes manifest.

The external and internal faculties, both spiritual and bodily, acquire the character of that determinate disclosure. The governing properties of their multiplicity are finally absorbed into it, just as the disclosure was initially concealed within possible veils, garments, and their governing properties. By virtue of this union, another kind of apprehension arises for the human being. It belongs neither to inward psychic apprehensions nor to outward natural bodily apprehensions. In the breadth of what it knows and the scope of its governing properties, its relation to psychic faculties is like the relation of their scope of knowledge to bodily faculties.

This is the apprehension acquired through effort and choice, called unveiling at one time and the holy faculty at another. Deal gently and subtly with your soul, and then reflect upon this account. Perhaps you will attain what you could not learn through reflection and inference or through acquiring forms and constructing images.

The author then answers the second possible difficulty: ‘Death does not in truth diminish the soul but perfects it. Perfected souls after death can perform all the acts of perfection they could perform before it…’ Their power and capability derive from perfected acquired capacities. The bodily faculties that disintegrate under death's blows stand to those capacities as instruments preparing the existence of something stand to the thing prepared. Once that thing's existence is complete and perfected, the instruments may become impediments to its intended operations, rather than continuing to prepare them.

Bodily instruments stand in the same relation once the perfected capacity has been acquired.

A full account requires explaining the intermediate world and what perfected spirits possess within it. That depends upon premises for which the present discussion has no room.

QT-039 — The need for a comprehensive manifestation of the One

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Once this is understood, we say: when the one absolute identity, one through true unity, has the characteristics of unity prevailing over those of multiplicity—indeed, when multiplicity is effaced beneath the dominance of oneness in the station of comprehensive intelligible unity—and then appears through separate, non-comprehensive manifestations within the externally realized worlds, differentiated and distributed so that multiplicity prevails over unity in their characteristics and unity becomes concealed by their actual dispersion and external differentiation, it wills to manifest itself in a complete locus of manifestation. Such a locus embraces all the luminous manifestations and shadow-like realities, encompasses the hidden and openly disclosed realities, and contains all the subtle correspondences of inward and outward existence.

SH-039 — Why the human constitution joins divine comprehensiveness and cosmic differentiation

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: having established the question of divine unity and answered the objections to its foundations—the comprehensive principles and general rules already indicated—the author now wishes to explain the principal aims and questions that follow from them. The discussion thereby proceeds toward the ultimate purpose of this treatise: establishing the human being's comprehensiveness and perfection, in which no other existent equals him and no other being approaches him. Establishing this requires a preliminary explanation.

The genuine unity attributed to the identity of the Real is absolute unity, in which all oppositions—contradictories, contraries, and the rest—are absorbed. It intrinsically encompasses everything that exists, whether one or many. Just as it encompasses every kind of unity, it encompasses every kind of multiplicity. It therefore intrinsically joins all opposites. In respect of this unity, the Real is said to have neither contrary nor peer, and to be one without number: not one by the unity opposed to multiplicity, since under that consideration the many stand opposite the one, which is the principle of number.

Relational unity and relational multiplicity therefore stand equally in relation to absolute unity insofar as it encompasses them both. Nevertheless, relational unity differs from absolute unity only through a negative consideration, whereas multiplicity differs through

the addition of further qualifications. Relational unity consequently has intrinsic priority over multiplicity. In any determination where the governing properties of unity predominate, the effects of existence and unrestrictedness are more manifest; where the properties of multiplicity predominate, those effects are concealed.

As already indicated, determination is of two kinds. In one, the source of the distinguishing character is comprehensiveness and inclusion with respect to the distinct things encompassed: the determination of a whole relative to its parts, or of a general concept relative to its particulars. In the other, the source of the distinction is opposition and mutual exclusion, as with a thing relative to what stands opposite it. The determination of opposed species and particulars relative to their counterparts belongs to this second kind.

Of the two, it is clearly the first in which unity predominates over multiplicity. Accordingly, if you carefully examine determinate levels and distinct existents, you find that, wherever nonoppositional unifying meanings predominate in their determination—as in the worlds of spirits and images—more effects of existence appear, such as life, apprehension, and diverse movements. Wherever multiple meanings and opposed governing properties predominate, the existential effects and fundamental realities remain latent. This is so in the realm of intense conflict among natures and the opposition of the elements. There, life and diversity of movement are concealed because opposition predominates in the determinations, with contrariety manifesting the furthest development of possible multiplicity.

When this contrariety is broken, the thing again becomes receptive to the manifestation of those effects. The more fully the opposition is overcome, the more receptive it becomes: as in the progression from minerals to plants and from plants to animals, until the opposition is thoroughly overcome and a receptivity for the full manifestation of unity is obtained. It then becomes capable of manifesting the human reality, the shadow of essential unity, from which is the beginning and to which is the return. Reflect on this remarkable point: it contains many great mysteries.

We may now explain the author's passage. In that identity which is one through absolute unity, the governing properties of unrestricted essential unity predominate over those of the multiplicity of names and existential realities. Indeed, multiplicity's manifestation is absorbed and effaced under the manifestation of the essential subjugation of oneness: the properties of opposed qualifications are concealed in the station of gathered meanings, the determination comprehending all determinations. As already explained, the distinguishing character of unrestricted determination is precisely to gather opposites.

The identity then appears through the existential disclosure of the Breath in dispersed, noncomprehensive loci within the external worlds, just as breath spreads through its points of articulation as letters and words. Existents are differentiated in their levels, each determined by its own particular character, and the whole appears through those particularities. As explained in discussing the perfection of the names, this requires the

whole to appear through a particular, the properties of the whole's unity being subdued beneath those of the manifest particular's multiplicity. Unity is consequently concealed, as the essence requires intellectual differentiation and external articulation, to display the particular perfections belonging to their particulars.

The identity therefore wills to manifest its essence—which has appeared in detail—in its entirety and the oneness of its comprehensiveness, through a complete locus. This locus embraces all the luminous divine names and shadow-like cosmic realities through which the essence appears in detail; all the secret realities of the intrinsic names and the manifest realities of the attributive and active names; and all the subtle inward divine and outward creaturely relations, within the comprehensive human level.

The substance of the account is this. Essential unity and absolute identity, because unrestrictedness predominates in them, allow no scope for differentiated names. Conversely, the detailed loci of manifestation which are the parts of the macrocosm, because cosmic qualifications and possible multiplicity predominate in them, cannot display the divine comprehensiveness that is the form of genuine unity. The divine affair therefore requires a balanced form in which essential unity does not predominate and possible multiplicity exercises no dominion. Through the breadth of its receptivity and the comprehensiveness of its balance, this form can manifest the Real both in the differentiation of His names and in the essential oneness of His gathering. It is the elemental human constitution. Nothing possible is more comprehensive than the human being, who encompasses the unrestricted divine level and the restricted level of servanthood.

The Shaykh, may his secret be sanctified, expressly states this in his treatise The Construction of Circles. We shall quote his words so that attentive readers may attain some of their subtle meanings:

‘It is established among us that the human being has two copies, outward and inward. His outward copy corresponds to the whole cosmos, while his inward copy corresponds to the divine presence. The human being is therefore the whole in the genuinely unrestricted sense, being receptive to all existents, originated and eternal. No other existent possesses this receptivity. No individual part of the cosmos receives divinity, and the Divine does not receive servanthood. Rather, the whole cosmos is servant, while the Real alone is God, one and self-sufficient. He cannot be qualified by the originated, creaturely attributes of servanthood that oppose His divinity.

‘The human being has two complete relationships: through one he enters the divine presence, through the other the cosmic presence. He is called servant insofar as obligations are laid upon him and he did not exist and then came to be; he is called lord insofar as he is vicegerent and is of the finest constitution. He is thus an isthmus between the two worlds, gathering creation and the Real together, and the dividing line between the divine and cosmic presences, like the line between shade and sunlight. This is his reality.

He possesses comprehensive perfection with respect to origination and eternity. The Real possesses comprehensive perfection in eternity and has no participation in origination—exalted is He above that. The cosmos possesses comprehensive perfection in origination and has no participation in eternity. The human being is therefore comprehensive: praise belongs to God for this.

‘How noble a reality, how manifest an existence! Yet how base and sullied it can also be in existence, for from it have come Muḥammad, may God bless him and his family, as well as Abū Jahl, Pharaoh, and Moses, peace be upon him. Recognize the finest constitution and make it the station of the obedient and those brought near; recognize the lowest of the low and make it the station of unbelievers and deniers. Glorified is He: nothing is like Him, and He is the Hearing, the Seeing.’

These are his own words. Reflect upon them after cleansing your inward being of merely inherited and conventional material, and refining your inward secret through the subtleties of spiritual taste and longing. Perhaps God will grant you an understanding of some of his purposes.

> ADDITIONAL ORIGINAL QUOTATION
>
> For that identity which is necessary through itself apprehends its essence in its essence for its essence, in an apprehension neither additional to nor distinct from its essence, whether in intellection or in reality. It likewise apprehends its attributes and names as intrinsic unseen relations whose effects are not manifest and whose entities are not distinguished from one another.
>
> Then, when it manifests in differentiated form within the dispersed loci of these worlds, according to particularizing will, differing preparednesses, and multiple intermediaries, it does not apprehend its essence and reality as comprehending all external perfections and all divine attributes and names. Its appearance in each particular locus is only according to that locus. Do you not see that the Real's manifestation in the spiritual world is unlike His manifestation in the bodily world? In the first it is simple, active, and luminous; in the second, dark, receptive, and composite.

SH-039-B — Why primordial self-knowledge does not replace comprehensive manifested knowledge

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this explains in detail the point just indicated in outline: no level, whether one of disclosure or self-beholding in disclosure, can become a complete locus and comprehensive place of manifestation for the necessary identity except the elemental human constitution. The words ‘For that necessary identity…’ address a possible objection: if bringing the comprehensive human being into existence aims at the identity's appearing to itself in all its levels, this would merely acquire what has already been acquired. It already apprehends

itself in all its levels, including sensible things, within the determination comprehending all determinations.

The author replies that the identity does indeed apprehend itself within that determination, together with the levels and determinations it contains, but insofar as these are its very essence. That apprehension occurs in itself and for itself, that is, for its essential perfection. The apprehension itself is neither additional to its essence nor distinct from it, either conceptually or existentially. As explained, this presence allows no multiplicity: knowledge is not distinguished from known and knower. Such distinction occurs only where the two bows of necessity and possibility are differentiated, which is another level, where unity is distinguished from multiplicity. Likewise, its other attributes and names are apprehended here as intrinsic relations whose effects are not manifest and whose entities are not distinct from one another.

The identity then manifests in the Breath of the All-Merciful, the domain where the names are differentiated and the determinations of otherness appear. This takes place according to particularizing will, preparednesses differing with the intrinsic affairs established through the most holy effusion, and multiple intermediaries. For they maintain that the pervading identity and descending reality cannot assume lower forms before assuming higher ones. The names have a tawqīfī, authoritatively fixed character: attaining the higher prepares for attaining the lower. Thus matter cannot assume animal form, for example, before assuming vegetal form and acquiring the corresponding preparedness. ‘Intermediaries’ here means the ordered preparednesses within the circle of existential levels, not the causal separation that the expression might at first suggest.

The identity thus appears in distinct, differentiated and dispersed loci, but manifestation is still not complete. Although the entities are now distinct and the designation other becomes applicable, because the effects and properties of the names appear in the separate determinations of these worlds, the identity has not apprehended its essence and reality there through the oneness of its comprehensiveness, as encompassing every external perfection and every divine attribute and name. Its appearance in any particular locus is only according to that locus. Its appearance in the spiritual world is not like its appearance in the bodily world: the former is simple, active, and luminous; the latter composite, receptive, and dark. The same is true of the other worlds, levels, and particulars. Each appears through its own determinations and displays the effects proper to them, as explained in discussing the perfection of the names.

QT-040 — Volitional self-disclosure in the Perfect Human

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> Thus a volitional movement proceeds toward the universal locus of manifestation, the comprehensive mode of being that encompasses the divine command: the Perfect Human. For the human unites the capacity to manifest the absolute Essence with the

> capacity to manifest the divine names, attributes, and acts, through the comprehensiveness and equilibrium of the human's universal constitution and through the breadth and perfection of that capacity for manifestation. The human likewise brings together the realities of necessity and the relations of the divine names with the realities of possibility and the attributes of creatures. Thus the human joins the level of comprehensive unity to that of differentiation, encompassing the principal levels in the chain of existence, so that the Real may become manifest in the human according to that capacity and apprehend its own reality under the comprehensive and perfected aspect just described.

SH-040 — The human terminus and return of the existential movement

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: the author has explained that neither the first disclosure, the presence of gathering, nor the second, the domain of differentiation, is suitable for the manifestation in question. There must therefore be an impulsion toward a locus joining gathering and differentiation. This impulsion is volitional, because its principle is a specifying act of knowledge prior in rank. The movement toward what is specified is consequently volitional, not an involuntary necessitation of the kind ascribed here to the Peripatetics.

Considered inwardly, what is sought is the universal locus of manifestation: the human reality, the isthmus joining necessity and possibility and encompassing the realities belonging to both. Considered outwardly, it is comprehensive being: the elemental human constitution, the last descent of existence. It therefore comprehends the divine affair, since every lower level encompasses the higher, and so it encompasses all existents. In their terminology, command means making the governing property of unity manifest within multiplicity. This is expressed at one time as the existential movement and at another as the all-pervading conjunction. The contrasting expression, prohibition (al-nahy), means making multiplicity's governing property manifest and returning it to unity.

Know, then, that the divine relation, in accordance with essential unity, requires the movement bringing things into existence to be circular and returning, as will be explained, God Most High willing. The divine replenishment determined from unrestricted essential effusion through the isthmic reality just mentioned reaches the First Intellect, designated the Pen; then the Tablet, Throne, Footstool, and remaining spheres, one after another. It then pervades the elements and generated beings, finally reaching the human being, coloured by the distinctive properties of every level through which it has passed.

Suppose that the human recipient of this replenishment ascends by spiritual wayfaring, unites with the levels of souls and intellects, and passes beyond them through the essential affinity necessarily accompanying his balanced form, until he unites with the isthmic reality which is his original level. The replenishment has reached the furthest degree of multiplicity in him. That multiplicity must possess an encompassing form from which

nothing escapes: its oneness. Through this oneness he reaches the isthmic reality, among whose qualifications is the unitive character next to genuine unity. The circle is then completed by reaching the station from which the effusion arriving at the Intellect was first determined.

Reflect on this great mystery. Through it you will understand the orientation from its principle and the movement toward it: inwardly the universal locus, outwardly the comprehensive being embracing the divine affair. This is the Perfect Human. He joins manifestation of the unrestricted essence to manifestation of the names, attributes, and acts, through the comprehensiveness and balance of his universal constitution and the breadth and perfection of his receptivity, the comprehensive isthmic reality.

He also joins necessary and possible realities, the relations of the divine names and the attributes of creatures. The reality expressed as the distance of the two bows of necessity and possibility is the source of all relations, attributes, and realities, whether necessary or possible, belonging to the Real or to creation. He therefore joins gathering and differentiation and encompasses every level in the chain of existence. The words ‘so that He may manifest in him according to him’ depend on ‘He was impelled’: this impulsion toward the universal locus is for manifestation according to that locus's comprehensive oneness.

In sum, He wills to manifest Himself to Himself in a universal affair encompassing all the particulars of His affairs, according to that affair. His comprehensiveness and perfected comprehensive oneness can appear only in such an encompassing, noble affair, whose like is not possible: nothing else is like it. In it He apprehends His essence under that comprehensive consideration beyond which no further possibility remains, through its perfect, encompassing aspect. This is the goal of the existential movement and the loving pervasion expressed here as impulsion.

> ADDITIONAL ORIGINAL QUOTATION
>
> An objection may be raised: the Necessary through Himself apprehends Himself through His own essence being present to Him. He apprehends His first effect, which apprehends all things through their differentiated forms occurring within it, through that effect's being present to Him, since He requires and necessitates it and bestows upon it all the differentiated forms occurring within it.
>
> Moreover, according to your position, He apprehends all things through unseen, undifferentiated knowledge. He also apprehends them through the occurrence of their differentiated forms externally, in detailed knowledge. By His genuinely one reality He therefore apprehends all things and knows them in both ways together. As for originated material particulars, He apprehends them in the manner appropriate to Himself and His real perfection: universally, not in a manner entailing deficiency and change in His essence.

SH-040-B — Objection: why are divine self-knowledge and the First Intellect insufficient?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: after establishing this universal principle and explaining that the human being is the goal of the movement bringing things into existence according to their method, the author turns to objections against both the claim and the route leading to it, formulated according to philosophical principles and dialectical rules. One objection is that the Necessary through Himself, possessing manifestation in the manner described, needs no locus other than Himself in order to manifest Himself to Himself. Even if another locus is conceded, the First Intellect suffices.

The Necessary apprehends Himself through His own essence being present to Him, as explained. He likewise apprehends His first effect—which apprehends all things through their differentiated forms within it—through that effect's being present to Him. Necessitation entails the necessitated thing's presence to its necessitating principle through a closely binding relation. The first effect is accordingly present to the Necessary with all its differentiated forms, because He requires and necessitates it and bestows every form present in it.

Moreover, on your own account, the Necessary knows all things through an unseen, undifferentiated knowledge by His essence's presence to itself in the comprehensive determination. He also knows them in detail through the occurrence of their differentiated forms externally in the Breath of the All-Merciful. By His genuinely one reality He therefore apprehends all things both comprehensively and in detail. What you have proposed as the goal of the existential movement and essential pervasion cannot be its goal, since it is attained without that movement.

It may be replied that the goal is detailed apprehension of things without qualification, universals and particulars alike, whereas the Necessary through His genuine unity apprehends only universals in this way. We answer that His apprehension of particulars is not denied without qualification. He apprehends them in the manner appropriate to His real perfection: universally, not in a way entailing deficiency and change. It is impossible for the divine will to aim at the latter manner. Failure to apprehend particulars in that way does not entail failure to apprehend them altogether. The author's words ‘As for particulars…’ address this possible reply.

QT-041 — Critique of the mirror analogy: intellectual vision versus sensory vision

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> As for the saying, ‘A thing's seeing itself by itself is not like its seeing itself in something else that functions as a mirror: in the latter, it appears to itself in a form supplied by the

> locus in which it looks, a form that would not have appeared without that locus and its disclosure to it,’ this requires scrutiny. If ‘seeing’ here means perception by inner vision —that is, intellectual cognition—then the thing that could serve as a mirror for its self-perception is the First Intellect, one of its effects. If, however, it means the perception belonging to eyesight—that is, particular sensory cognition—it is evident that the Necessary Existent cannot be a sensory particular; for, as already explained, every particular must be possible through itself. Indeed, everything seen directly by eyesight must be a corporeal accident, and whatever is seen by eyesight in a derivative manner must be material, whether a body or something corporeal.

SH-041 — Seeing in a mirror: intellectual apprehension, sensible forms, and transcendence

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this refers to what Shaykh Muḥyī al-Dīn, may his secret be sanctified, says in the Bezels of Wisdom, intimating an answer to the preceding difficulty. A thing's seeing itself through itself, without a locus distinguished from what manifests in it and independently displaying its own properties, is not like its seeing itself in something else. The latter is externally and sensibly distinct through the manifestation of its properties, like a mirror: the thing sees itself in the form supplied by the locus in which it is viewed, which would not appear without that locus. The recipient influences what appears within it by supplying its own form; the form’s particular features result from an influence generated by that recipient. Ḥusayn ibn Manṣūr al-Ḥallāj, chief of those who affirm divine unity, expresses this in the words, ‘My mother gave birth to her father: this is among the marvels.’

The author objects that, if seeing here means the apprehension attributed to inward sight—that is, intellectual apprehension—the First Intellect can serve as the mirror. It is distinct in existence and independently established, since it is an effect and possesses its own possible determination. If seeing instead means apprehension by eyesight, a particular apprehension, the Necessary through Himself plainly cannot be particular. Anything subject to individuation and determination, through which it becomes particular, must be possible. Moreover, anything seen by the visual faculty is apprehended either primarily and intrinsically or secondarily and incidentally. What is seen intrinsically must be a bodily accident, since sight occurs either through the emission of rays or through an impression: rays terminate at coloured surfaces, and those surfaces are what can produce the impression. What is seen incidentally is material, whether a natural body or something bodily.

But this argument admits discussion. If by saying that visual apprehension concerns bodily accidents you mean that whatever reaches intellect through this instrument is confined to them, this is denied: you yourselves establish the universal after the many. If you mean only that the instrument's primary act of apprehension is such, then, even granting this, intellect can abstract from the external concomitants of the form conveyed through the instruments.

It is therefore incorrect to say that intellect cannot apprehend that form at all, especially for someone who admits the externally existing natural universal. It does not follow that the Necessary is altogether unapprehensible through the mediation of instruments.

One may object that what is apprehended in this manner must be surrounded by material, external attributes, whereas the Necessary insofar as necessary cannot be so qualified; seeing therefore cannot be attributed to Him. We reply that what the viewed locus supplies must be among the external concomitants of the necessary nature, for otherwise it could not be ascribed to that locus. The nature's appearing clothed in these forms within faculties of apprehension is part of the intended goal motivating the existential movement. It must therefore be witnessed and apprehended under this consideration. Admittedly, the name Necessary should not then be applied, since, as indicated, the names have a tawqīfī, authoritatively fixed character. But the nonapplication of this name at one level does not entail that the reality is altogether invisible.

The Shaykh does not apply that name to it under this consideration. He calls it the Real, and not without qualification, but insofar as it bears the most beautiful names. This is supported by the saying attributed to one of the Imams, ‘I have not worshipped a lord whom I have not seen,’ and by the Shaykh's statements in various places: ‘The eye looks upon none but Him, and judgment falls upon none but Him’; and, ‘If you say hidden, you do not lie; if you say seen, that is what I know.’ Similar statements are innumerable in their writings.

All this concerns the attribution of seeing to the true reality with regard to its unrestrictedness and manifestation at the station of proximity through supererogatory works. If, however, seeing is attributed to it without consideration of its restriction and its creaturely loci of servanthood, all faculties of apprehension and awareness are equally incapable of apprehending its beauty. Intellect, no less than sense, falls short of reaching the pavilion of its majesty, because the originated and the eternal have no affinity. Concerning this, the Shaykh says in the Meccan Opening: ‘If affinity is ever predicated of Him, as the unique Imam Abū Ḥāmid al-Ghazālī—may God be pleased with him—and others predicate it in their books, this involves a certain strain and an intention remote from the realities. Otherwise, what relation could there be between the originated and the eternal? How could the relation of what admits no likeness resemble that of what does admit likeness? This is impossible.’

Know that the author's earlier argument occurs here in the course of raising difficulties and formulating objections. Since his subsequent replies do not address this particular argument, it was necessary to answer it here [lest it be mistaken for his settled position].

QT-042 — Can the entire human cosmos mirror the complete divine image?

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> If it is objected: ‘The First Intellect cannot serve as the mirror of the comprehensive image embracing all the divine attributes of perfection and the determinations of the names. Only comprehensive being can serve as the mirror of that image, since every name, attribute, and determination appears through it, and in its manifestation it preserves their representation from distortion or alteration. For there is no receptive locus receiving the holy effusion in a particular manner, nor any locus in which the divine forms appear through a given determination, without a more complete analogue of it in the Perfect Human.’ We reply: the reality pervading every manifestation in its true unity is not apprehended across all the levels present in comprehensive being; rather, only some of its levels disclose its image here, so that certain images of the names remain known solely through intellectual apprehension of the unseen. Once this is recognized, it is evident that the comprehensive world cannot serve as the mirror of that reality's entire image.

SH-042 — Does the comprehensive human mirror actually disclose every level?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this objects to the questioner's claim that only the First Intellect is suited to be a mirror and that comprehensive being has no such suitability. The First Intellect is confined to one level of the reality. It therefore cannot mirror the form comprehending all its perfective attributes of majesty and beauty and all its levels of disclosure and self-beholding in disclosure. It could do so only if it had a specific relation to every level, without being confined to one rather than another. Each level would need a share within it, through which it could mirror that level with all its particulars. Only then could it mirror the comprehensive form, displaying everything belonging to it without distortion or alteration.

Consequently, only comprehensive being is suitable for this rank. It is not confined to one level rather than another; there is no level of which it does not possess a part, as will be explained. All names, attributes, and determinations can therefore manifest through it, and in manifesting them it protects them from distortion and alteration. Whether a possible receptivity receives the effusion of cosmic forms from the holy Principle in a particular manner, or a necessary receptivity manifests the forms of the names through a particular determination, the Perfect Human contains a counterpart of it in a more complete manner. He comprehends the perfections of disclosure and self-beholding, of appearing and making manifest, as already explained.

The reply to this claim is that comprehensive being could serve as such a mirror only if what looks within it apprehended all the names and attributes at the levels present within it as they are. But this is not the case. The reality pervading all manifestations, which in truth is the one looking because of its genuine unity, is not apprehended through all the levels present in its comprehensive being when it looks within it. Otherwise every human individual would apprehend it in the described way, which does not happen. As experience

shows, the reality apprehends its form here only at some levels. Some of the names are therefore apprehended only intellectually and unseen. Comprehensive being cannot then be a mirror for the comprehensive form, because it does not display every level without qualification.

QT-043 — Three possible subjects of the perfect mirror—and the infinity of human perfections

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

We further maintain that if the reality of the Real and its true image were identical with the reality and image of the human being, there would remain no difference between what manifests and its locus of manifestation, or between a mirror and what appears in it. If it were something other than the human reality, then, supposing it were the reality of unrestricted existence itself, something besides the Perfect Human—such as a separate intellect—could also serve as its place of disclosure and manifestation. But if the reality in question were existence as determined by all these determinations, attributes and relations, the entire great cosmos could serve as its manifestation. For the totality of the parts of the great cosmos, united in subject and in its collective formal configuration, is comparable to the totality constituting a human being: separate soul, intellectual and sensory faculty, and material body. If one may posit true unity and a specific natural form here, one could also posit such unity and form in the cosmos as a whole, governing and coordinating all its parts and apprehending them together, as the interlocutors maintain. Moreover, among the cosmos's parts are indefinitely many kinds: some existed in earlier times and have entirely passed away; others exist now but will disappear in future times; still others will appear only in times to come and will ultimately pass away too. Nor could every possible perfection of the human species belong to any one of its perfected individuals: individuals differ in their capacities across unbounded times. None of them, therefore, could serve as a completely exhaustive manifestation of that reality's image. Indeed, the perfection belonging to the Seal of the Prophets could not belong to another prophet, nor, in their account, could the perfection of the Seal of the Saints belong to any other saint.

SH-043 — Could the whole cosmos, rather than one human, be the comprehensive mirror?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this seeks to invalidate the account of mirroring, manifestation, and a locus of manifestation altogether. The explanation is that the Perfect Human's suitability—or that of any particular existent—to mirror the true reality cannot be conceived in any way. If anything could serve as that mirror, it would be the macrocosm; yet that too is unsuitable.

The true reality and its real form must either be the human reality itself or something different. The latter has only two possibilities: the reality of unrestricted existence, or existence restricted and determined by all determinations. Existence restricted to one particular determination standing opposite others has already been excluded by the preceding arguments.

If the true reality is the human reality itself, the impossibility is evident: there would be no difference between what manifests and its locus, or between mirror and what is seen. If it is the reality of unrestricted existence, every other individual existent would also be suitable as its mirror. Something other than the Perfect Human would possess that suitability, especially the immaterial intellect, which is nearer in rank and earlier and more enduring in suitability. Neither the human being nor any other particular existent would possess it exclusively.

If, third, the reality is existence determined by all determinations, attributes, and correlations, only the whole macrocosm with all its parts could manifest it. The macrocosm too has a unifying form. Its totality, one in subject and collective formal configuration, is comparable to the human totality composed of immaterial soul, intellectual and sensory—or intuitive—faculty, and material human body. If a genuine unity and natural specific form can be asserted here, they can likewise be asserted of the macrocosm: a natural specific form that governs, acts upon, and brings into being all its parts and apprehends them all, universals and particulars, according to your position. This is contrary to the questioner's doctrine [the displayed wording], yet the world's parts include indefinitely many kinds. Some existed in the past and vanished altogether; others exist in the present and will vanish; still others arise in future times without having existed in the past or present, and later vanish in turn.

Moreover, no one perfected individual of the human kind can possess all the perfections possible for that kind. Its individuals differ according to preparednesses arising over unlimited times. Were one individual to possess all the kind's perfections, that individual would encompass what is without limit, which is impossible. On this account, no one individual can constitute a complete locus of manifestation.

The words ‘It is therefore impossible…’ answer the preceding conditional. Even if genuine unity could apprehend and govern the macrocosm, with its unlimited parts each requiring unlimited perfections, one individual among those parts could not be a complete and comprehensive locus for the form of the reality pervading the whole macrocosm with all its parts and perfections. How could this be possible when you yourselves hold that the perfections peculiar to the Seal of the Prophets cannot belong to another prophet, and those of the Seal of the Friends cannot belong to another friend of God? If the perfections of one part cannot belong to another, how could one human individual—himself just one part of the macrocosm—contain all its individuals and their perfections?

QT-044 — Can the cosmos be the mirror without making divine perfection dependent on it?

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> If, then, that locus of manifestation were taken to be all the parts of the cosmos, including human beings and their individual members, we would face the following dilemma. Suppose that the reality's apprehension of itself as embracing all perfections in the manner described is not itself a real, efficacious perfection sought for its own sake. Then it could not be the final cause of the world's creation, as you maintain, nor could a particularizing divine will and essential love be directed toward it. But if such self-apprehension is necessarily one of those perfections, the Necessary Existent would depend, with respect to one of its real perfections, upon something other than itself—a being possible in itself and originated in its particular constitution. It would therefore no longer be necessary in every respect. If someone objects that the relevant dependence upon comprehensive being cannot be dependence upon it insofar as it is other than the Real, we reply that the dependence is upon it precisely because it encompasses all receptive subjects and loci of manifestation, their mutual conjunction, and similar relations. Considered in that way, comprehensive being is unquestionably distinct from the Real.

SH-044 — Would the divine goal make the Necessary dependent on a possible being?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this completes the objection invalidating mirroring and manifestation altogether. It has been argued that the human reality cannot serve as the locus in question. Suppose, then, that the suitable locus were the macrocosm with all its cosmic parts. An impossibility would still follow.

If the macrocosm—the totality of the world's parts, including the human being and his individuals—could mirror the necessary true reality, then that reality's apprehension of itself as comprehending all the perfections of the names would occur in the order described. It would appear through every level of the world, including sensible things, in a constitution joining appearing and making manifest, apprehending and making apprehensible: the true human constitution. If this were not a real, preferred perfection sought for itself, it could not be the final cause for bringing the worlds into existence and the motive for the loving existential movement, as you maintain. Neither particularizing will nor essential divine love should then be directed toward it.

If, on the other hand, it must be counted among such real perfections, the Necessary through Himself would need something other than Himself—possible in itself and originated in its constitution—for one of His real perfections, and would depend on it for that perfection. If the world's mirroring entails this apprehension, and that apprehension

entails the Necessary's need and dependence on another, the success of that mirroring would mean that the Necessary through Himself is not necessary in every respect. The author's words ‘He would not be necessary in every respect’ are the consequent of the stated conditional.

It is then objected that the reality's dependence for these perfections on comprehensive being—the human constitution—cannot be considered insofar as the constitution differs from the reality. Under that consideration the constitution is altogether nonexistent, as repeatedly explained, and cannot be that on which necessary perfections depend.

The reply is that dependence concerns the constitution precisely insofar as it embraces all the multiple receptivities and loci of manifestation, making it suitable to display the realities and distinguishing characters of the names. It also concerns its inclusion of the relations of conjunction between those receptivities and other relations, such as incompatibility and opposition, which produce the mutual reflection of the rays of making manifest and the shadows of appearing. Through these it can manifest the relations obtaining among the receptivities, whose particular characters are known only through such relations. Under this consideration comprehensive being unquestionably differs from the Necessary: the difference arises from privative possible multiplicity.

QT-045 — Objection: detachment from bodily faculties versus the comprehensiveness of the Perfect Human

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Furthermore, they have agreed that a human being cannot attain true perfection except by untying the knots, casting off restrictions, becoming released, and reaching the level of unrestrictedness. On their view, neither true perfection nor an objective apprehension of reality is attained by travellers of the path until they reach that level. The apprehension and knowledge they call perfection is what becomes disclosed when they arrive there: the bodily faculties responsible for cognition and assisting it cease to act or be affected; the holy and intellective faculties turn wholly toward holiness and enter the company of the higher assembly of separate spirits; and the traveller ceases, in that state, to employ the bodily faculties. Accordingly, sensory, imaginative, estimative, and discursive cognition carry no weight for them; indeed, they regard these as impediments to true perfection. For they hold that perfection requires subduing the natural faculties, strengthening the holy faculties, exchanging bad dispositions for good, and consistently undertaking noble actions. On this account, the Perfect Human becomes one who shares in the qualities of separate intellects and perfected spirits. But then one cannot call such a human the comprehensive cosmos: there are no counterparts within this human of powerful rebellious spirits, predatory or wild animals, beasts, or harmful insects. Equally, nothing within the human corresponds to the celestial spheres and stars which, on the inherited cosmological account, do not admit rupture or rejoining and move continually without interruption.

SH-045 — Objection: does liberation from restrictions destroy human comprehensiveness?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: the preceding difficulties concern the theoretical part of their sciences; the present objections concern their practical part. One is that they agree that the human being's attainment of genuine perfection—reaching the level of his reality comprehending all names and realities—requires the dissolution of bonds acquired through his provisional and settled stages, and release from the restrictions acquired as he assumed each level and developed according to it. Only then does he enter original unrestrictedness and attain the essential absoluteness required by that reality. He thereby reaches genuine perfection: apprehending realities as they are through true and direct apprehension.

According to them, no traveller attains this apprehension without reaching the level of unrestrictedness. Apprehension at any particular level is according to that level and mixed with its proper governing properties. The true apprehension and certain knowledge which they call perfection must therefore be what becomes unveiled upon reaching unrestrictedness, when the other bodily faculties that apprehend or assist apprehension cease their agency and reception. This prevents universal realities from being mixed with the faculties' limiting external attributes and material concomitants, which obstruct their apprehension. The realities remain in their unrestricted purity, enabling the holy and intellectual faculties to turn wholly toward holiness and enter the company of the higher immaterial spirits and proximate intellects. This occurs by acquiring affinities through continuous attention to the true Principle and release from the sources of difference.

In that condition the person is plainly apart from employing bodily faculties. Sensory, imaginative, estimative, and discursive apprehensions therefore count for nothing on their account; indeed, they obstruct genuine perfection.

They also agree that perfection can be acquired only by subduing natural faculties, strengthening the holy faculties, replacing bad character with good, and persevering in beautiful actions. It follows that the Perfect Human shares the complete attributes of immaterial intellects and perfected spirits. He cannot then be called comprehensive being, since on this supposition, while at this level, he contains nothing corresponding to rebellious spirits and demons, predators, wild animals, beasts, or harmful insects. Nor, at any level, does he contain anything resembling the celestial spheres and stars, which admit neither rupture nor reunion and move continually without interruption. Immediate intellectual judgment testifies that there is nothing of that kind in the human being.

QT-046 — Objection: if perfection transcends intellect and expression, how can it be attained?

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> It is also evident, the objection continues, that the perfection of which they speak appears to be something impossible. For were a traveller to attain and apprehend it, the traveller could not grasp it through the intellectual faculty: they themselves agree that the intellect cannot apprehend it, since it belongs to a mode beyond intellect. Consequently the intellect cannot reach it, and neither could any bodily faculty involved in retention, sensation, imagination, or representation take it as an object. This is clear without further elaboration; accordingly it could not be expressed in words. Furthermore, the complete release of the holy rational faculty from its natural restrictions is realized only at death, not by merely turning away from those restrictions and withholding attention from them and from their demands, activities, and ends. Concentrating thought upon what is absolute, even continually, does not thereby remove the natural restrictions or reduce them to nonexistence. Nor, even at death, does the rational spirit shed many restrictions that are necessary concomitants of it and stand to it as though they were its parts.

SH-046 — Objection: an attainment beyond intellect would be inexpressible and unattainable

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this is another difficulty alleged to show that their intended end—the perfection they seek—is impossible to attain. The perfection they describe appears impossible because attaining it would entail its being incapable of apprehension, and anything whose attainment entails that it cannot be apprehended cannot be acquired. Their absolute perfection would therefore be unattainable, and thus impossible.

The explanation is that, among their accepted principles, even if a traveller reached and apprehended true absolute perfection, he could not conceive it through intellect or encompass it in an intellectual form. Intellect is agreed to possess a particular range of apprehension beyond which it cannot pass, just like the other faculties. Each has a specific level and proper objects, to which alone its apprehension relates. As eyesight cannot go beyond visible qualities to apprehend sounds and melodies, intellect cannot go beyond intelligible universals to apprehend realities disclosed by unveiling and meanings received through spiritual taste.

If the perfection in question cannot be encompassed in an intellectual form, none of the bodily cognitive faculties can relate to it through remembering, sensing, imagining, or representing it. The immaterial intellectual faculty, nearest to pure holiness and furthest from material concomitants, cannot apprehend it; still less can bodily faculties which apprehend only things surrounded by those concomitants. This is clear without further explanation.

Nor, then, can it be expressed in words. Words are instituted for intelligible meanings; what has not been conceived cannot be signified by them. Verbal signification presupposes

expression, and expression presupposes conception of meanings and their impression in memory, followed by their imagining, representation by words, and perception through the common sense. A meaning that cannot be conceived or imagined cannot be indicated through sensible words and conventionally instituted signs. The end they call perfection therefore cannot be expressed in any formulation, and must belong among impossibilities and sheer nonentities. For whatever is not impossible or sheer nonbeing can be expressed; by contraposition, whatever cannot be expressed is impossible and sheer nonbeing.

Furthermore, the detachment of the holy rational faculty from the natural restrictions grounding bad character and base actions—the detachment they require for perfection—cannot occur except through death. Mere turning away from those restrictions, and the soul's refusal to attend to their requirements, operations, and ends, cannot produce it. Natural dispositions cannot depart from a person merely through representations or contrary actions.

The claim that uninterrupted attention to the unrestricted removes restrictions is therefore false. Confining attention to the unrestricted does not remove them or reduce them to the status of nonbeing. Naturally established features necessarily belonging to particular levels and accompanying them in existence cannot be eliminated merely by conceptual acts such as attention and watchfulness. Indeed, even in death the rational spirit does not lose many restrictions that are necessary concomitants and virtually constituent parts of it. How, then, could it lose them without death?

QT-047 — Dialectical counter-objection: ascetic practice, humoral imbalance, and the validity of perception

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Moreover, we say: if it were legitimate to describe the actual perfections grounded in powerful arguments and decisive demonstrations—attained by the rational soul through sound thinking while the temperaments of the body, its organs, and its animal, psychic, and natural faculties remain in balance—as deficiencies, false imaginings, and veils barring true perfection, then it would likewise be legitimate to classify perceptions brought about by repeatedly uttering particular phrases in powerful voices, which dissipate the psychic spirits and overwhelm the senses, among the perceptions of those suffering from melancholy or disorders of the humours. This charge would seem especially pertinent when such recitation is accompanied by withdrawal from others, remaining in dark places, consuming unsuitable foods that produce corrupted humours at harmful times, and pursuing what is called 'opposition to the soul'. Those afflicted by such disorders judge what lacks external reality to exist and perceive forms and sounds that do not exist outside themselves, owing to defective suppositions, disordered thought, and imbalance of their constitutions. As for what is called 'opposition to the soul', it entails inflicting pain on the spirit and exhausting the body by excessive hunger and sleeplessness, which dry out the brain and disturb the equilibrium of the organs,

> psychic spirits, and body. Voluntary hardship and deprivation produce a strained psychic habit marked by sorrow, tears, anxiety, fear, abasement, loss of vigour and aspiration, destitution and misery, while extinguishing the joy and temperamental equilibrium conducive to bodily and spiritual pleasure. Such a condition weakens the constitution, disturbs the human temperaments, and produces bodily and psychological illnesses that hasten death and diminish strength. Perceptions arising from this procedure would therefore be classified as corrupt perceptions.

SH-047 — Objection: are ascetic perceptions effects of a disordered temperament?

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this refers back to the objection raised at the beginning of the treatise: certainty about what necessarily contradicts intellect indicates an entrenched disorder of temperament. Intellectual perfections acquired through strong arguments and decisive demonstrations, attained by the rational soul through sound thinking when the body and its instrumental organs, cognitive faculties, and assisting animal, psychic, and natural faculties are balanced, are genuine perfection and true apprehension. No faculty has been driven away from the equilibrium which is the form and manifestation of genuine unity and the source of true attributes and sound effects.

If such cognitions could be called deficiencies, corrupt imaginings, and veils barring genuine perfection, the same could be said of perceptions acquired by repeating particular expressions in powerful voices that dissipate the psychic spirits—the bearers of knowledge and cognition—and overwhelm the senses that assist them in their perfective operations. This seems especially plausible when such repetition is accompanied by withdrawal from others, remaining in dark places, consuming unsuitable foods that produce corrupted humours at harmful times, and pursuing what is called opposition to the soul. Experience and rational inference are claimed to show that such practices strengthen imagination and estimation by disturbing the brain's balanced constitution, turning its subtle human equilibrium toward coarse animal dryness. Continued practice would make those faculties dominate the constitution and allow black bile to overwhelm the other cognitive powers.

The resulting apprehension would then belong with that of people afflicted by melancholy and humoral disorders, who assert the reality of what has no external existence because their suppositions and thoughts are defective and the balanced instruments of cognition are disordered. They perceive forms and sounds that do not exist at all, owing to the disturbance of their temperaments and constitution. The appearance of symptoms after undertaking their causes is alleged to establish the presence of disease with certainty.

As for opposition to the soul, the objection describes it as tormenting the spirit by undertaking what it dislikes, and exhausting the body through excessive hunger and sleeplessness. These dry the brain and the parts serving as instruments of psychic and

discursive powers, disturbing the temperaments of the organs and psychic spirits, and indeed of the whole body that bears these faculties. By deliberately undergoing pain and hardship, abandoning comfort, and tormenting the soul, one acquires a forced psychic disposition producing sorrow, tears, fear, anxiety, misery, humiliation, diminished spirit, poverty, destitution, and diminished aspiration. This arises through undertaking contemptible activities, degrading appearances, enduring others' harm, and similar practices associated here with people of blame.

The objection treats all these as base qualities lying at the deficient extreme, away from perfected genuine balance. It also claims that they remove joy and the balanced temperament supporting bodily and spiritual pleasure, through which animal life is maintained. Such a condition must therefore weaken constitution and power, disturb human equilibrium, produce bodily and psychic illnesses, prepare the approach of death, and destroy strength. Perceptions arising from this method would consequently be corrupt imaginings and false apprehensions.

QT-048 — Four degrees of the comprehensive manifestation and the Perfect Human's modes of knowing

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

We reply: the complete locus of manifestation is the comprehensive being that embraces every locus of manifestation in all the levels contained within it. At the first level there is knowledge of the essences, attributes, determinations, and quiddities, an unseen and undifferentiated knowledge, not yet detailed. At the second there is knowledge of the totality that is objective, unseen, and differentiated in detail. At the third those meanings possess differentiated objective existence, and the whole is apprehended through several kinds of cognition. At the fourth, everything present in the preceding levels is present because this level embraces them, together with a real and perfectional unity-in-comprehensiveness, beyond which no further completeness or perfection can be conceived. Thus the most complete form disclosed through all these loci cannot appear as such except within this locus of manifestation. Consider this carefully. As for the claim that apprehension of certain forms and names would be only intellectual and unseen, it must be rejected. The reality pervading all things knows itself by itself, as well as what belongs to it as its necessary concomitants, with an unseen, comprehensive knowledge in the Perfect Human, the comprehensive being encompassing all these levels. Through certain divine names and determinations and their corresponding receptivities it apprehends both aspects in differentiated intellectual cognition; through others it apprehends them in estimative and imaginative cognition; and through still others it acquires sensory perceptions according to their corresponding receptivities. Thus it apprehends the whole by means of the whole, in virtue of all that it contains: a complete apprehension to which nothing can be added. Reflect on this.

SH-048 — Four levels of manifestation and the human union of comprehensive and differentiated knowing

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this begins the replies to those objections in their order. First comes the answer to the claim that the human being cannot be a complete locus of manifestation and that another determination—the cognitive determination, the First Intellect, or the macrocosm—has a greater claim. A complete locus is comprehensive being, embracing every manifestation at all the levels present within it. This is the elemental human constitution alone, the last descent of the loci of manifestation within the last descent of the levels.

You have learned that every lower locus includes the higher, and every lower level includes the higher level with its manifestations. The elemental human being therefore possesses all levels and manifestations. No other can serve as the complete mirror of every divine presence and cosmic world. Such a mirror must contain, for each comprehensive level, a model proper to it, functioning as a copy that includes every particular of that level, divine or cosmic. Each individual manifestation has a particular level in which it appears with its proper character; it does not appear in that way at another level. The perfected may appear in all levels, but according to each and under a particular aspect. Alongside all this, the complete locus must possess the oneness of the gathering of gathering, through which it can mirror the presence that is one through genuine unity. This belongs specifically to the elemental human constitution.

Since it is the final descent of existence, as it reaches and passes through each level it acquires a model and comprehensive copy in which everything belonging to that level appears. This copy can serve within it as a mirror for the contents of that level. The human constitution is therefore a totality of all these copies, models, and mirrors, together with the oneness of the gathering of gathering:

‘The essence—or core—and subtlety of everything
is deposited within this collection.’

The first level, the first cognitive determination, cannot provide this complete manifestation, although it comprehends all levels. The manifestations and levels present in it are neither distinct from one another nor distinct from it. Its manifestation is therefore unseen, undifferentiated knowledge, not detailed knowledge. The second level, the First Intellect, likewise possesses comprehensiveness and the distinct forms of everything, knowing them through unseen, differentiated knowledge. Yet these distinct forms are only forms according to its own particular level.

The third level here is the macrocosm. Although the meanings possess differentiated external existence in it and are apprehended through several kinds of apprehension, it lacks the oneness of the gathering of gathering. The fourth, the elemental human constitution, possesses everything in the preceding levels, since it comprehends them all

with their manifestations. It also possesses perfected comprehensive oneness, beyond which no greater completeness or perfection is conceivable. Through it the divine presences and cosmic worlds have one unified form encompassing every manifestation, leaving nothing in existence outside it. Thus the most complete perfected form appearing through the oneness of all these manifestations can appear as such only in the complete human locus.

The questioner's claim that some forms and names would then be apprehended as an unseen intellection, so that the human being could not mirror the whole, is rejected. The reality pervading all things and appearing through them has two kinds of apprehension in this comprehensive constitution. One is apprehension from the side of the manifest reality: it apprehends its essence through itself, together with what necessarily accompanies it—the necessary divine names and possible cosmic realities. It apprehends every affair within a comprehensive affair from the side of its essence, in undifferentiated cognition. This comprehensive affair is the human being, encompassing all levels through its perfected reality and through its circle embracing both bows.

The other kind is again apprehension of itself, but not from the side of the manifest reality through itself. It apprehends through the loci and their determinations in differentiated, objective cognition. This kind has instances of differing realities at every level. At each level the reality apprehends itself from the side of that level through a mode appropriate to it. Such apprehension must take place through that level, so its principle must arise from the corresponding aspect.

Thus, through certain possible determinations and divine names, the reality apprehends universals intellectually and in detail, according to its universal receptivities. Through other determinations and names it apprehends from the two sides just mentioned. When accompanied by particular concomitants and individuating attributes belonging to meanings and imaginal forms, it apprehends through determinations of faculties and loci of awareness in estimative and imaginative cognition, according to its particular receptivities. Through still other determinations and names, when accompanied by particular formal concomitants and external individuating attributes, it apprehends through sensory faculties and outward awareness in sensory cognition. All these follow the receptivities within it to which the determinations of the faculties relate.

The author mentions the two aspects in the first two cases but not the last, because the outward senses, proper to the final case, relate intrinsically only to cosmic forms and possible attributes. If they relate to the realities of the names and necessary substances, they do so incidentally and through an intermediary, not intrinsically. Their objects therefore concern only one of the reality's two aspects and one of the circle's two bows.

Once these premises are understood, it becomes clear that, through the elemental human constitution—a collection of copies of every level—the true reality surveys each level by examining its particular copy. It apprehends the whole through the whole, according to the

whole contained within it, in complete and perfected apprehension. Through the comprehensive oneness of this collection it apprehends the comprehensive oneness of the whole. Its cognition therefore joins gathering and differentiation, and none is more complete. The words ‘Reflect upon this’ point to this subtlety.

‘All of my whole is occupied with all of Your whole;
so all of my whole flees from You to You.’

QT-049 — The form of the whole, active and receptive determinations, and the One manifest in many respects

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> By the reality and form of the whole one must mean existence as determined by all the determinations through which it becomes the source of every perfection-producing action and the entire range of actual effects. Human beings, precisely insofar as they gather every higher and lower receptivity—spiritual, imaginal, natural, and corporeal—through genuine combination, composition, and intermixture, can in this respect become the locus in which that form is manifested. If someone objects that existence determined by the totality of receptive determinations is not really distinct from its own reality and form, so that the distinction between the manifest and its locus of manifestation vanishes, and further argues that making reality under its active determinations the form of the whole rather than reality under its receptive determinations is an arbitrary assertion contradicting the claimed comprehensiveness—since such a form would encompass only some determinations—we reply: reality considered under the realizations and necessary aspects by which it is the Real and the originating principle differs, under that consideration, from reality considered under the possible aspects by which creaturehood and being an effect are established. Yet the reality of realities is not, as unrestricted reality, different from the reality and determinations of created things. Under one consideration this reality is hidden; under another it is manifest; under others it constitutes the loci of manifestation and the places of concealment. All are one in respect of absolute, unqualified reality, but not one in respect of the conceptual additions and relations under which they are differentiated.

SH-049 — Active and receptive determinations: one reality, distinct relational aspects

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers the objection denying manifestation altogether. A preliminary explanation is required. When the unrestricted reality—the reality of realities—appears through the first determination and requires essential unity, multiplicity is enfolded within it. Names suggesting multiplicity and opposition, such as manifest reality and locus of

manifestation, divinity and creaturehood, do not then appear. Neither form nor any other opposed name is therefore attributed to it.

When it appears in the second determination, however, knowledge is distinguished from existence, manifest from hidden, and the bow of necessity from that of possibility. Opposed names become manifest: divinity is distinguished from creaturehood, and manifest reality from locus. The designation form can then be applied.

Of the alternatives proposed by the questioner, we therefore choose this: the whole's form and reality is existence determined by every determination through which it is the source of all acts and active effects. It should not be objected that this would make it determined only by active determinations, rather than by every determination, and so by only some—a position already refuted. Nor should it be said that this would be the form of only a part, not the whole. All other determinations are included in this form, so it is indeed the form of the whole. The determinations of all perfective acts and active effects are included among the determinations constituting this form, but from the side of agency, not reception.

More precisely, all determinations attaching to existence, active and receptive, are one in essence and reality and differ only in consideration. When the acts and effects are considered as proceeding from the Principle, relations between them and the Principle must arise. Considered as attaching to the Principle, these are called active determinations. Existence bearing all determinations under this consideration is the manifest form of the whole. Considered as attaching to the acts and receptivities, they yield the form of the receptive locus and the Perfect Human.

Thus the human being, insofar as he contains all higher and lower receptivities—spiritual, imaginal, natural, and bodily—in their entirety and comprehensive oneness through genuine combination and intermixture, is suitable to manifest that form under the corresponding consideration, likewise in its entirety and comprehensive oneness.

It may be objected that existence determined by receptive determinations does not truly differ from its reality and form. The difference between manifest and locus would disappear, so neither could be what it is. Furthermore, choosing actively determined reality as the whole's form rather than receptively determined reality would be arbitrary and contradict the claim that unrestricted reality comprehends every determination. Its form would be determined by only some.

We reply that, within the presence of differentiation, reality considered through necessary realizations and noble aspects establishing divinity and principiality differs from reality considered through possible aspects establishing creaturehood and being an effect. Assigning the names in this way is therefore not arbitrary.

Nor does this contradict the claimed comprehensiveness. Unrestrictedness and comprehensiveness belong to the presence of gathering, the reality of realities, where there is no differentiation. As unrestricted comprehensive reality, the reality of realities

does not differ from the reality of creation. Under some considerations it is hidden, under others manifest; under some it is loci of manifestation, under others places of concealment. All are one with respect to unrestricted essential reality, but not one with respect to the relations and correlations arising in the presence of differentiation. Some of these considerations and the corresponding names in revealed and technical usage were explained in the prolegomenon; recall that discussion.

QT-050 — Why an embodied soul can be a genuine natural unity while the cosmos is only an aggregate

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> We have shown in the fundamental sciences of reality that balanced bodies composed of organs can arise from portions of the elements. These organs bear numerous faculties from which diverse acts proceed; through their interaction and intermixture balanced conditions arise. Those faculties proceed from separate souls that stand to the balanced bodies as form stands to matter. The conjunction of body and separate soul accordingly constitutes a real unity and a natural unity of species. Natural acts issue from this genuinely composite being that could not proceed from a plurality of principles merely insofar as they remain many and are not united in a genuine unity. No comparable genuine natural composite can be constituted from the elements taken in their universality; nor can a genuine composite or natural species be constituted from the collective of these elements, the celestial spheres and stars, the principles that bring them into being, and the separate substances that stand to them in a relation analogous to substantial form. Such a collection can possess an aggregative unity, but the demonstration of these two propositions, with the requisite proofs and arguments, exceeds the scope of this short treatise.

SH-050 — Why the embodied human can be a natural unity while the cosmos is an aggregate

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers the arguments claiming that no particular within the macrocosm can manifest existence determined by every determination, whereas the macrocosm as a whole can. The author first explains why the former is suitable and the latter is not. The fundamental sciences of reality establish that balanced bodies can be composed from particular portions of the elements. Through the minuteness of their parts and the possibility of thorough mutual contact, opposed qualities interact and their opposed, possible determinations—which conceal the properties of necessity—are removed. The elements thereby become prepared for balanced unity. This oppositional kind of determination characterizes cosmic beings and reaches its extreme in the elements.

When these determinations are overcome through temperamental unity and the comprehensive determinations proper to divine realities and names, the body's parts become receptive, in proportion to their affinity with genuine unity, to the necessary properties previously concealed by cosmic determinations. They become organs bearing many faculties from which diverse actions proceed. The intermixture of these actions, faculties, and their subjects produces balanced states that manifest real forms and ground necessary properties. The faculties proceed from immaterial souls related to the balanced bodies as form to matter. That relationship arises through the subtle bond between temperamental unity and genuine unity. Body and immaterial soul together thus acquire genuine natural and specific unity.

Genuine unity possesses the encompassing determination that joins opposites, as temperaments do, especially the human temperament. Through complete intermixture and perfected balance, the human being becomes a real composite capable of natural acts that cannot issue from many principles merely as many: diverse simultaneous movements in opposed directions, assimilation of food to the nourished being, perception of varied sensible objects, and movements of thought and longing yielding divine knowledge and unveiled realities—all at once. Multiple principles cannot, merely as multiple, be the source of these actions.

Similarly, the elements taken in their totality cannot constitute genuine composites. They cannot as wholes undergo the interaction of contrary qualities and the removal of opposed determinations. Nor can these qualities, together with celestial spheres, stars, their productive principles, and immaterial substances related to those principles like specific forms, constitute a genuine composite comparable to the human being. The elements taken in their totality lack a temperamental unity that could link them to those principles and immaterial substances. Genuine unity cannot therefore belong to them under this consideration. They may possess an aggregative unity, but this does not suffice to manifest the reality in question.

One may object that this would follow only if the temperaments of minerals, plants, animals, and the human being were not included in the macrocosm. Through them it could become prepared to manifest that reality. We reply that, among these temperaments, the one enabling a composite to manifest genuine unity is the balanced human temperament. If the macrocosm is rendered suitable through the human being, this is conceded. But the macrocosm contributes little to that manifestation: the human being includes the particulars of its manifestations while displaying divine comprehensiveness and the oneness of the gathering of gathering, and so needs no further assistance from the macrocosm for this role. If it is claimed to be suitable without the human being, the claim fails.

In summary, divine names and necessary realities, because unity dominates their comprehensive form, leave no room for possible multiplicity. Conversely, cosmic realities and possible names, because possible multiplicity dominates them, leave no room for

necessary unity to appear. Genuine unity joining unity and multiplicity therefore cannot appear in either alone. Only what joins the two sides and encompasses both bows, such as the human being, can manifest it through the oneness of their total gathering. Reflect: this is a major principle containing profound meanings.

Most premises employed here to explain these two points are persuasive rather than demonstrated. The author therefore apologizes that establishing the two investigations, framing their arguments, and setting out their proofs exceeds this brief treatise. Each requires principles demonstrated through rules whose explanation needs a wider field.

QT-051 — Finite noble species, lesser species, and perfection shared within the human kind

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> It has also been established in those sciences that the noble kinds from which acts of perfection may proceed are finite. Inferior, deficient kinds need not be taken into account here: whatever perfectional acts proceed from an inferior kind also proceed from a superior kind, whereas the superior kind can produce acts that the inferior cannot. A single noble kind possessing real unity thus includes within itself all the inferior kinds relative to it, in the sense indicated here, even if these are unlimited in number. As for the primary perfection possible to the kind considered as a kind, all perfected individuals belonging to it share in that perfection. Particular perfections that differ according to individual capacities are not decisive for this purpose. A perceptive reader familiar with the foundations of the preceding discussions will understand how these questions are to be argued and established; extending the explanation and multiplying premises in this short treatise would serve no purpose.

SH-051 — Species-wide perfection, individual variation, and the completing seal

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers the objection to the comprehensiveness of the human specific reality: it supposedly fails to include every kind, containing nothing like inferior kinds such as worms, snakes, and the like. Acts in the created world are of two sorts. Some are noble, perfective, and intended in themselves, contributing to the attainment of the genuine goal which is the end of ends, such as nourishment and growth. Others are deficient and base, existing incidentally and as accompaniments, without contributing to that goal, such as a scorpion's sting or a snake's bite.

Kinds are correspondingly divided according to the actions they originate. Noble kinds belong within the ordered series extending between creation and command and ending in the genuine intermediary which is the goal just described. Inferior deficient kinds fall

outside that series, their existence following upon and branching from the spirits ordered within it.

The noble kinds capable of producing perfective acts are finite, since the series ends upon reaching that goal. Their inclusion within one reality is therefore not impossible. Inferior kinds need not be considered here, since every perfective action proceeding from an inferior kind also proceeds from a superior kind, whereas the superior performs actions the inferior cannot. Moreover, a noble kind possessing genuine unity can include the inferior kinds too, in the sense already indicated. Genuine unity appears through temperamental balance joining essential necessary unity to possible multiplicity of names.

Once that genuine unity, which comprehends all unities and multiplicities, appears, no reality can lie beyond its essential comprehensiveness, even if its individuals are unlimited in number. Unlimited individuals do not contradict comprehensive unity in this sense. Given the comprehensiveness of the specific reality, particular perfections varying with particular preparednesses are not decisive. The objection drawn from the two seals therefore does not refute it.

More precisely, just as generic unities of differing kinds require a comprehensive specific unity in which to terminate, that specific unity must possess varying degrees of perfection and intelligible comprehensiveness, until they terminate in a personal unity embracing all in form and meaning. This is the true external determination through which the other realities are realized and come to be, as an intelligent reader acquainted with the preceding principles will recognize.

Those principles imply that noble human existential perfections continually ascend as times are renewed. Each succeeding perfected person must encompass the predecessor’s perfections together with the particular perfections proper to himself, until that kind of perfection is completed in the seal—upon him be the finest blessings and the fullest greetings. For the acquisition of these perfections is from the niche of supreme completeness. Whoever is more closely related to it and possesses greater affinity receives more from it. Temporal affinity is among the most complete affinities, because many other affinities follow it; whoever is temporally closer therefore receives a greater share.

This is supported by what is reported of the ancient Persian sages devoted to divine wisdom: they agreed that, as the ranks of intellects descend, their illuminations multiply. The later a rank, the greater its share of the illumination of the Light of Lights, the rays of His countenance, and the illuminations of the intermediate dominating lights. The same applies in time. This meaning is among those contained in the following saying of the Prophet—may God bless him and his family and grant him peace: ‘Time has come round to the condition it had on the day God created the heavens and the earth,’ although the report has many elevated meanings according to the heights of the paths from which it is understood.

That individual is therefore the one who realizes the specific reality in its entirety and perfection. Lesser individuals do not realize it with the same completeness, because impediments arise on their provisional and settled paths and stages. Detailed investigation would require many premises unsuitable for this brief work.

QT-052 — Can the Real's manifestation depend upon determinations without compromising necessity?

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> There is nothing impossible in the Real's being described by certain attributes and determinations depending upon other attributes and determinations that accrue to Him from His own reality. If it is objected that, insofar as these are particular existents, they are possible things and the Real cannot depend upon something possible—even upon certain possible attributes—in order to be described by a perfectional attribute, we reply that there is no impossibility in His being described by certain possible attributes depending upon other possible attributes—for example, certain perfections of the divine names depending upon other possible attributes. The perfectional attribute in question is His manifestation in the complete, perfected, universal, and unrestricted locus of manifestation. This manifestation belongs among His necessary concomitant attributes and determinations through Himself, not through another.

SH-052 — Relative dependence in manifestation and intrinsic divine self-sufficiency

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers the objection denying manifestation altogether on the ground that, if any part of the world could serve as a locus, the Necessary would need another and would therefore not be necessary through Himself. There is no impossibility in the Real's qualification by certain attributes and determinations requiring other attributes and determinations that belong to Him from Himself. What is impossible is that the Necessary should need, for such qualification, attributes or determinations not deriving from Himself. Where the attributes required are from Himself, the requirement is not incompatible with necessity.

It may be objected that these required determinations, insofar as they are particular existents, are possible, as already established. The necessary Real cannot depend on them for a perfective attribute without the Necessary needing possible things. We reply that it is not impossible for the Real's qualification by certain possible attributes, such as perfections of the names, to depend on other possible attributes and determinations, such as His manifestation through the corresponding names, divine or cosmic, originated or eternal. What is impossible is dependence on possible attributes for the attributes through which

He is necessary, such as essential perfection. As you know, this latter consideration entails absolute self-sufficiency.

Need arises only with respect to the perfections of the names, called here the perfective attribute: manifestation in the complete, perfected, universal and unrestricted locus encompassing every reality of the levels and every particular manifestation, originated and eternal. This belongs among His necessary concomitant attributes considered through His universal reality and among determinations necessary through Him considered through His particular loci. What is complete through universal perfection therefore requires those determinations for manifestation, just as those determinations require Him for existence and necessity. Their existence is through the necessity bestowed by that complete manifest reality, not through another.

You may ask how this locus can be called unrestricted when there is no qualification in existence by which it is not qualified. We reply that genuine unrestrictedness possesses the oneness of the gathering of all qualifications, as explained in the prolegomenon. It is not unrestrictedness defined simply as the absence of every qualification. Recall that distinction.

QT-053 — The senses under the holy faculty: real comprehensiveness without suppressing the lower powers

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> It does not follow that sensory, estimative, and discursive perceptions cease to count if true perfection and certain apprehension are attained only upon reaching the level of unrestrictedness. For when the holy faculty draws its knowledge and cognitions from their proper sources in its state of detachment, and comes to command the other cognitive faculties so thoroughly that none acts independently without being employed and made to obey it, then the perceptions and operations of those faculties are themselves to be taken into account. None need obstruct the perfection sought by the spiritual practitioners; instead they assist its acquisition, consolidation, and advancement to its highest degrees. Understand this. Nor do we concede that the counterparts of rebellious spirits and demons are absent from the perfected human. Rather, the faculties corresponding to them, having been brought under control and disciplined through the recognised exercises of perfection, perform praiseworthy acts of an angelic character. They are prevented from acting merely according to their own natural impulses or in obedience to lower bodily faculties, such as estimation, independently of the holy faculty. The same applies to the counterparts of wild beasts, predators, animals, and harmful insects. As for the natures corresponding to the celestial spheres and stars, a likeness need not share every property of its original. Nor is it true that nothing in the human being moves continuously: the arteries and organs such as the lungs are in continual motion without interruption or exhaustion [as the author's inherited physiology represents them].

SH-053 — Ordered faculties rather than abolished faculties: the human correspondences of the worlds

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this begins the ordered replies to the objections concerning their practical sciences. The first alleges that their account of genuine knowledge as disclosed only through essential unrestrictedness—by loosening possible bonds, escaping material restrictions, and joining the higher immaterial intellects—contradicts human comprehensiveness.

The contradiction would follow only if the intended unrestrictedness were the conventional, conceptually considered kind opposed to restriction. It is not. The goal is genuine intrinsic unrestrictedness, to which restriction and its absence stand equally, since it comprehends both as the unrestricted comprehends its restricted particulars. Once this is established, and the goal of the existential movement is understood as the Real's appearance in the complete unrestricted locus embracing every particular manifestation, attaining genuine perfection at the level of unrestrictedness does not make sensory, estimative, and discursive apprehensions irrelevant. They must be included, so that unrestrictedness and comprehensiveness obtain in making manifest as well as in appearing.

When the holy faculty draws universal truths and certain cognitions from their sources in its detachment, it gains mastery over the bodily faculties apprehending particulars. They no longer act independently in any movement or operation, but are employed by it and compelled to follow it. Unrestrictedness in the stated sense then includes all kinds of their apprehension: universal and particular, forms and meanings, absent and present, as well as their operations combining these objects. None can obstruct genuine perfection. Each becomes an assisting cause and a preparation for acquiring and consolidating that perfection and ascending more readily to its highest degrees. The holy faculty employs them; achieving an effect with assistance is easier than achieving it without assistance—understand this.

Nor do we concede that counterparts of rebellious spirits and demons are absent from the Perfect Human. The corresponding faculties, once subdued and refined through the appropriate disciplines, produce praiseworthy acts of an angelic character. They are prevented from acting according to their independent natural impulses or following bodily powers such as estimation without the holy faculty employing them. The report that the Prophet’s satan submitted through him—may God bless the Prophet and his family—points to this meaning. The same applies to counterparts of wild animals, predators, beasts, and harmful insects.

As for the natures corresponding to the spheres and stars, a likeness need not possess every individuating property of its original. Resemblance requires only the attributes belonging to the unrestricted reality. Even if this is conceded, we deny that the human being contains nothing moving continually. Arteries and other vessels surround the parts of

the body as spheres surround the world's parts. Some move by contraction and expansion, others by other motions. The lungs also move continuously; as the source here identified for bodily movements, they resemble the motion of the greatest sphere through which night contracts and day expands.

The Shaykh, may his secret be sanctified, has explained the correspondences adequately. We quote his words for their subtle meanings:

‘The worlds are four: the higher world, the world of permanence; the world of transformation, the world of passing away; the world of inhabitation, the world of permanence and passing away; and the world of relations. They occur in two domains, the macrocosm and the human being.

‘In the higher world are the Muḥammadan Reality and its sphere, life; their human counterparts are the subtle reality and the holy spirit. The Throne corresponds to the body; the Footstool to the soul; the Frequented House to the heart; the angels to the human spirits. Saturn and its sphere correspond to the faculty of knowledge and the soul; Jupiter and its sphere to memory and the rear of the brain; the Red Planet and its sphere to the intellectual faculty and the crown of the head; the sun and its sphere to estimation and the animal spirit; Venus and its sphere to imagination and the rear of the brain's first ventricle; the Scribe and its sphere to common sense and the front of the first ventricle; and the moon and its sphere to the sensory faculty and the limbs. These are the divisions of the higher world and their human counterparts.

‘In the world of transformation are the sphere of ether, whose spirit is heat and dryness, corresponding to yellow bile, whose spirit is digestion; the sphere of air, whose spirit is heat and moisture, corresponding to blood and the attractive faculty; the sphere of water, whose spirit is cold and moisture, corresponding to phlegm and the expulsive faculty; and the sphere of earth, whose spirit is cold and dryness, corresponding to black bile and the retentive faculty. The earth has seven layers: black, dust-coloured, red, yellow, white, blue, and green. Their human counterparts are skin, fat, flesh, vessels, nerves, muscles, and bones.

‘In the world of inhabitation are spiritual beings, corresponding to human powers; the world of spirits, corresponding to what senses in the human being; plants, corresponding to what grows in him; and minerals, corresponding to what does not sense in him.

‘In the world of relations are accident, exemplified by black and white; quality, exemplified by healthy and ill; place, exemplified by my head upon my neck and my neck upon my shoulder; correlation, exemplified by this being my father and my being his son; position, exemplified by ‘my right [side]’ (يميني); acting, exemplified by eating; and being acted upon, exemplified by satiation. There are also different forms in bodily coverings, such as elephant, donkey, lion, and ṣarṣar. These correspond to human faculties receiving praiseworthy and blameworthy forms: this one is discerning, so he is an elephant; this one

dull, so a donkey; this one brave, so a lion; this one cowardly [the suggested reading], so a ṣarṣar. Understand: God speaks the truth and guides to the way.’

QT-054 — Knowledge beyond discursive thought need not be beyond intellect or expression

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> We do not concede that the intellect is incapable of apprehending everything apprehended in the mode said to lie above intellect. Certainly, some hidden matters cannot be reached by the intellect on its own, but are apprehended only through another faculty nobler than it. Yet other things apprehended by that higher faculty can also be apprehended by intellect. Indeed, whatever apprehends a universal meaning or universal reality falls under the definition and name of intellect. By 'intellect', however, when they speak of the sciences associated with it as formal sciences, they have in mind the discursive faculty that draws knowledge from its principles by finding middle terms and combining them with the two terms of the conclusion. Memory, estimation, and imagination need not obey the discursive intellect, yet they can submit to the nobler faculty and become its servants and instruments. Accordingly nothing prevents what that faculty apprehends from being expressed, in some measure, in words.

SH-054 — Beyond discursive thought does not mean beyond every form of intellect

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers the objection that the unveiled cognitions called perfection are impossible because intellect cannot apprehend them. We do not concede that intellect altogether fails to apprehend what is disclosed in the higher mode said to lie above it. Some hidden matters cannot be reached by intellect through itself, but can be reached with the help of a nobler power and illumination from a more complete light, kindled from the niche of the human glass containing the lamp. Once reached, however, intellect apprehends them as it does its other objects. It likewise needs another faculty to acquire particular objects—although that faculty is lower and less noble—and once they are acquired it apprehends them as it does its other objects. As for the remaining things, just as they are apprehended and reached through the higher faculty, they are also apprehended and reached through intellect.

Indeed, whatever apprehends a universal meaning or reality, whether through investigation and demonstration or through unveiling and immediate experience, falls under the definition and description of intellect. The distinction arises because intellect in ordinary usage, especially among this group, means the discursive faculty associated with formally constituted sciences: the faculty that derives knowledge from principles by finding middle

terms and combining them with the terms of the conclusion. This is only one of intellect's powers and levels.

Their statement that unveiling and genuine perfection occur above intellect in this customary sense therefore does not entail that such a mode is unapprehensible by intellect without qualification, inexpressible, and hence sheer nonbeing. Memory, estimation, and imagination—the instruments through which apprehended meanings are expressed in particular words—may fail to obey the discursive intellect because it is weak and lacks mastery over them, while submitting to the higher power: unrestricted intellect illuminated by essential unrestrictedness and strengthened by original comprehensive power. It can then employ them for what it intends. Hence the expressions of those endowed with this power sometimes attain an inimitable degree of eloquence, beyond what people who spend their lives investigating rhetoric and articulating its rules can approach.

QT-055 — Sustained contemplation can alter acquired dispositions and subordinate the bodily faculties

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> It is clear that sustained watchfulness, continued attention of the kind described, observance of the recognised disciplines and conditions of this art, and the refusal to employ the bodily faculties merely to procure worldly pleasures or repel bodily discomforts, can bring those faculties into obedience. The practitioner resists the tendencies flowing from the restrictions just mentioned, whether these arise from the faculties' own nature or from their habitual submission to appetite. The bodily faculties of estimation and imagination, in particular, can be made to follow the higher faculty and prevented from turning wholly toward the body and becoming bound to matter and its obscuring conditions. For there is nothing improbable in an operative cause being prevented, by other and more powerful causes, from exercising one kind of activity and constrained instead to exercise an activity opposed to it.

SH-055 — How watchfulness can change the operation of established dispositions

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers the alleged improbability of escaping bonds and restrictions so as to attain genuine unveiling. How, it was asked, could entrenched dispositions and natural acts fail to follow their subjects merely through representations, intellectual considerations called watchfulness, and opposing actions?

Continual watchfulness consists in observing unrestricted reality through the varieties of its determinations, without losing sight of the one that appears through the many loci. It draws the perfections in question and brings knowledge and cognition. To explain this, a

preliminary point is needed. The Real’s replenishments and self-disclosures—glorified and exalted is He—reach the world continuously at every breath. Strictly speaking, there is only one disclosure, which acquires determinations according to the recipients' levels and preparednesses. These determinations ground the apparent multiplicities. The effusion from the Real is one in its essence, but appears according to the governing properties of the recipients. Whatever attributes predominate in them, necessary or possible, colour its manifestation through those relational considerations, while its own real properties—first among them knowledge—are concealed.

The human heart, because of the breadth of its receptivity and its comprehensiveness joining the two seas of divine names and cosmic realities, is suitable as mirror and locus. It therefore receives particular and universal governing properties, continually changing according to what passes within it, whether particular or universal, divine or cosmic. If no particular object enters it, no determinate attribute dominates it, and it is purified of attachments—even an orientation to the Real through a particular belief or resort to Him through a particular name—the disclosure then appears according to essential comprehensive oneness with its real properties. First in rank and closest in relation among these is knowledge.

These premises show why continual watchfulness is a most fitting means and nearest route to knowledge, especially when joined to the manners and conditions recognized by the practitioners of this discipline: weaning the soul from habitual objects, disregarding conventions and habits, abandoning the demands of bodily animal powers—appetite and predatory anger—used to procure worldly pleasures and repel bodily discomforts, and bringing them into obedience to the holy faculty. It also involves resisting what the restrictions require, whether through their own natures or through their submission to appetite, estimation, and bodily imagination.

Indulging those faculties and restrictions conversely subjects the holy faculty to their direction and draws it toward the body, matter, and its obscuring conditions. The printed construction concerning the sacred faculty’s bodily orientation is compressed, but the ensuing causal point is explicit: operative causes may be prevented from exercising activities arising from material concomitants and possible restrictions, and constrained to contrary activities by stronger causes, such as undertaking what opposes the former demands. For, as the established maxim states, disorders are treated through their contraries.

QT-056 — Against confusing reason with delusion: disciplined ascetic practice, temperamental balance, and moral purification

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Whoever classes intellectual cognitions and certain sciences founded on conclusive demonstrations, attained by a person of balanced constitution who is not overwhelmed

by bodily vices, among corrupt imaginings and veils to genuine perfection—neither themselves being such veils nor incapable of serving as preparatory conditions for the perfection at issue—deserves rather to be numbered among the mad, the melancholic, and those who deny necessary knowledge. Repetition of certain words during vigilant contemplation serves to sustain the attention described above; forceful or loud utterance is not an essential condition recognised by practitioners of the discipline. Withdrawal from people and remaining in solitude is needed to clear the heart of distracting thoughts, relinquish obscuring attachments, and devote one's whole concern to God. But the same freedom from distraction is required for deriving certain discursive knowledge and demonstrative conclusions without the intrusion of imaginative and estimative doubts. Whoever makes the consumption of unsuitable foods a condition of this path is ignorant or disturbed. Foods suitable to one traveller may harm another: constitutions differ, and so do the dispositions that obstruct them. Management of food and remedies for psychological disorders must therefore vary with the condition, just as treatment of bodily illnesses does. Severe hunger and excessive sleeplessness are thoroughly condemned in the path of Sufi discipline no less than in the path of teaching and investigation. The requisite food is that which sustains strength without upsetting the humours, producing heedlessness, lethargy or turbulent desire, or so occupying a person with digestion and bodily elimination that attention to higher things is lost. Sleep and wakefulness must be regulated by the same principle. In short, whatever condition is genuinely required for one of the two paths is required for the other. Voluntary suffering, hardships, and relinquishment of comforts are not permissible except for someone seeking perfection who is habituated to luxury and bodily ease, whose temperament is dominated by sensual appetites and the traits of effeminate men and women. The same qualified principle applies to cultivating dispositions of sorrow, concern, and tears. As for acquiring dispositions that produce abasement, diminished zeal, meekness, and the like, this is not permissible except for practitioners whose temperaments are dominated by intense anger, conceit, pride, coercion, forcefulness, love of rank, and similar traits. Yet the explicit principle that follows is that destructive habits can only be cured through praiseworthy habits opposed to them. As the force of one contrary is broken by the force of its opposite, a condition nearer the mean arises. Where appetite predominates, an opposing disposition draws the temperament toward equilibrium; where violence and anger predominate, the appropriate contrary does likewise, even if complete balance is not attained. Restoring a disordered constitution toward equilibrium under the principles of medicine and practical wisdom is not making the soul and body ill, but healing and strengthening them. One must not imagine that a remedy suited to one disorder in one patient at one moment cures every disorder. Some psychological disorders arise through excess, others through deficiency; remedies vary according to persons, times, circumstances and habits. Reflect on this. Finally, 'opposing the lower soul', understood in the sense of the gnostics, is as necessary in teaching and rational inquiry as in Sufi practice. We have explained this elsewhere, so need not prolong the account here. Understand this.

SH-056 — Purification restores balance rather than deliberately producing disorder

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: this answers the last objection, already raised at the beginning of the treatise: that the actions and states employed in what they call the path of purification are causes of black bile's domination of the noble cognitive organs and their deviation from balanced temperament. The author wishes to remove this difficulty and establish that the situation is contrary to the objector's supposition—indeed, the reverse. He therefore explains the practices in detail. They are not intended to disturb the organs' original balance, but to restore it after deviations caused by accumulated appetites and conflicting natural, material habits and demands. His exposition is sufficiently full to need no prolonged explanation.

There is, however, an important preliminary point. A form, whether divine or cosmic, requires a circular configuration in this account. Its centre manifests the true reality that exists primarily through itself; the remaining points manifest the relations of the names and conceptually considered entities. Their existence is distinguished only through relation to their opposites. The centre, by contrast, has neither opposite, contrary, nor peer. It is the genuinely one through which the other points and their oppositions are determined. This is the intended meaning of the claim that balanced form manifests genuine unity.

The closer a point is to the centre, the more numerous the effects of unity and necessity and the more comprehensive their governing properties. The further it is, the greater the effects of multiplicity and possibility and the more limited its governing properties and relations, because it has an opposite possessing its own contrary effects. Existents consequently divide into three kinds. One occupies the mean between the governing properties of unity and multiplicity: the human specific reality. Another inclines toward unity and simplicity: immaterial intellects and souls. The third inclines toward multiplicity, as do animals, plants, and minerals.

The individuals of the human reality, owing to the breadth of its range and comprehensiveness, likewise fall into three divisions. One remains at the mean of balance in all states and actions: the true vicegerent of the Real and the Perfect Human. Others lie on the side of excess or on that of deficiency, outside balanced form. According to their deviation they require treatment and a movement from the extreme they occupy toward its opposite, so that original balance may be restored. This accords with the established account of treatment through contraries. The author has explained all this at length in the matn; it needs no further elucidation.

QT-057 — Why philosophers regard the contemplative path as possible but difficult

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> Know that the accomplished investigators among speculative thinkers do not deny that the Sufi path is possible or that it occasionally reaches its intended end. Nevertheless, they regard it as arduous and think that bringing together its necessary conditions is unlikely. They suppose that effacing attachments to the required degree is almost unattainable; even if achieved briefly, retaining that condition is still harder, because the slightest obsessive thought or passing notion disturbs and distracts the heart. During spiritual exertion, moreover, the constitution may be disturbed, judgement confused and the body made ill. Unless the practitioner has first trained and disciplined the mind through genuine sciences, corrupt imaginings may take hold of the heart and satisfy the soul for a very long time. Many a traveller has pursued this path only to remain caught in a single image for twenty years or more, when prior mastery of knowledge would have disclosed the confusion immediately. In this sense the path of rational investigation appears easier, closer to its objective, and more fitting.

SH-057 — The reflective investigators' qualified acceptance of the contemplative path

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: having answered the objections of those who parade their cleverness in reflective inquiry, the author wishes to state what the accomplished investigators among them actually hold, before presenting his own view. From the beginning of the book to this point, one might suppose that all reflective investigators deny the path of purification and are responsible for the formidable objection just considered. This is not so. Accomplished investigators, ancient and later, Peripatetic and non-Peripatetic alike, do not deny that the Sufi path is possible or occasionally attains its goal.

They nevertheless see numerous obstacles and a demanding combination of conditions and causes, and therefore regard it as arduous and think its conditions unlikely to coincide. Removing attachments, the first stage of the path, requires severing outward and inward relations so completely that no passing thought distracts from attention to a single matter. They regard this as almost impossible. Even if it occurs for a moment, sustaining it is more remote still, since the slightest suggestion or thought disturbs and occupies the rapidly changing heart. The language of revelation expresses this in the Prophet’s saying—may God bless him and his family—that the believer’s heart is between two fingers of the All-Merciful: among bodily members none changes position more readily than the fingers.

Even if the traveller avoids this obstacle, a temperament departing from original balance is subject to conflicting appetites. He must persevere in disciplines and undertake what opposes nature, as explained. It is therefore possible that the temperament will be

corrupted, intellect disturbed, and body made ill by undertaking the causes of those effects. Even if he escapes this, without prior training of the soul through true universal sciences and discriminating rules, false imaginings may attach to the heart and satisfy it for a long time. Many a traveller remains caught in one image for twenty years or more.

It is reported that al-Ḥusayn ibn Manṣūr, may his secret be sanctified, asked a practitioner about his state and station. The man replied that he had practised for thirty years in the station of reliance. Al-Ḥusayn said, ‘If you have spent your life cultivating the inward self, where is annihilation in divine unity?’ The Shaykh likewise states in the Meccan Openings that spiritual exertion yields knowledge for those endowed with concentrated aspiration; for others it yields only clarity of the moment and delicacy of state.

‘My friends, many cross the wilderness toward the sanctuary,
but few are those who arrive.’

Had the practitioner first mastered the discriminating scientific rules, the error in that imagining would have become apparent immediately, and he would not have made it his resting place. On this account, pursuing reflective investigation to acquire these cognitions and realities appears nearer, easier, and more reliable. The other path must be preceded by reflective investigation to become trustworthy and attain its goal, whereas reflective investigation is said to need no such prior dependence upon it.

QT-058 — Contemplation and disciplined inquiry require the same conditions of clarity and equilibrium

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> As for us, we say that, on proper examination, every condition that must be observed in the Sufi path must also be observed in the path of rational investigation. The removal of distracting attachments is necessary in both; that is clear without further demonstration. The same is true of the regulation of sleep and wakefulness. In short, everything required to maintain a balanced constitution must be observed in either path, while everything that disturbs that balance must be avoided. This also shows that there is nothing inherently incredible about bringing together the conditions of contemplative practice. Distracting thoughts that disperse concentration are obstacles to both paths. Such disturbances do arise in the course of one's activity under the order of providential wisdom; nevertheless, practitioners of the discipline do not regard it as impossible to quiet the imagination when it is driven by confused, agitated motions, restraining it and preventing its disturbances, as their books explain.

SH-058 — Both paths require purification, attention, and a balanced constitution

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: after setting out the opinion of reflective investigators, both accomplished and ostentatiously clever, about the validity of their path, the author states his own judgment with ‘As for us…’. Every condition recognized in the Sufi path must also be observed in reflective inquiry. Removing distracting attachments, among the first stages of the former, is necessary in the latter too. Without it inquiry cannot attain its object. Even apprehending first principles, the clearest objects for these thinkers, requires attention. Attention occurs only through turning away from other things and directing oneself fully to the object. This is precisely what removing attachments means. Acquiring theoretical sciences and hidden cognitions all the more requires it.

The same applies to sleep and wakefulness, and to the hunger and satiety that can give rise to them. Excess in any of these dulls and weakens the discursive faculty, preventing the transitional movement through which acquired conclusions are reached. Everything maintaining a balanced constitution is necessary in both inference and purification, just as everything disturbing it must be avoided in both.

The claim of some investigators—that purification depends on prior reflective inquiry to attain truths, while inquiry is independently sufficient—is therefore the reverse of the situation. Reflective inquiry is the conditioned path, while purification is what it needs to attain its object and is the path that may be independently sufficient. For those supported by sound innate disposition and directed along straight methods, bringing together its conditions is not implausible. No one has claimed this for people indiscriminately: ‘The presence of the Real is too exalted to be a watering-place for every arrival.’

Distracting thoughts impede both paths, so the difficulty bears equally upon both. The heart's nature, under the order of encompassing wisdom, is disposed to rapid change. But practitioners do not regard it as impossible to quiet imagination's confused movements and restrain its distracting transitions. Some occupy it with firm recitations, forceful utterance, and sound foundations. others with pleasurable, longing-inducing melodies, delicate love poetry, and chaste love, as people of spiritual taste observe.

These measures work through cutting external ties with the swords of detachment and singleness, and uprooting their inward sources through the storms of realization—not through the scissors of imitation.

You may object that the path's first stage is emptying the heart of what distracts it from itself, then preparing to receive existential disclosures and generous breaths. Such emptying seems incompatible with the busy movements of discursive thought. I reply that first acquiring stable psychic capacities for apprehension does not conflict with subsequently emptying the receptacle of particular cognitions. The difficulty would affect someone who holds that reflective inquiry is independently sufficient or absolutely indispensable. That is not the author's position here. He holds that purification is independently sufficient, while reflective inquiry at most does not obstruct it and may provide a kind of preparation.

This is clear from his correspondence with a leading master of unveiling and witnessing, to whom he writes: ‘Preparing the holy receptacle through movements of discursive thought and longing is not an impediment. It is beneficial and fruitful for bringing into manifestation the cognitions and wisdom latent within it, when the holy faculty masters the bodily powers and maintains its ascendancy over estimation and imagination.’

QT-059 — Sense and intellect are preparatory causes in both paths; the effusion of knowledge is from the First Principle [LACUNOSE]

ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> The assertion that the speculative philosophers derive their knowledge from the senses, whereas those who undertake spiritual exertion derive theirs from the effusive Principle, is mistaken. The senses provide the first preparatory conditions in both paths, while the principle that actually bestows cognitions and sciences is, through itself, the effusive Principle. As for the first claim: that the senses prepare one for rational investigation is obvious. But they are preparatory also for the other path: were they not, the rational soul would never have become attached to its body. True perfection, moreover, must become available to the soul when that bodily attachment is severed by death. If one objects that bodily association can impart dispositions that prevent attainment, we answer that, on that supposition, the perfection must have been attainable prior to association with the body; why, then, should the soul have become attached to it at all? If the opponent replies that, just as bodily association can impart obstructive habits, it may equally impart other habits that serve as preparatory causes and conditions, we answer: you have now returned to the truth and conceded what you previously denied. As for the second claim, its explanation has already been supplied in our works on philosophical science.

SH-059 — The senses prepare in both paths; the bestowal of knowledge belongs to the Principle

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: after establishing the validity of purification and answering the reflective investigators' objections, the author turns to an objection raised by practitioners of purification against reflective inquiry and answers it. The objection is that reflective knowledge comes from bodily instruments and material sensory powers, the sources of error and mistake, whereas the practitioners' knowledge comes directly from the effusive Principle, intrinsically the source of truth, without bodily instruments or material faculties. What is received from the Principle in this manner would be immune to error, unlike what is received through inquiry mediated by faculties and instruments.

The answer is that the faculties and senses are the first preparatory conditions in purification just as in reflective inquiry, while the effusive Principle bestows cognitions and realities through itself without being restricted to one path.

That the senses prepare in reflective inquiry is evident. They prepare in the other path too: otherwise the rational soul would never have become attached to its body, since the goal of the existential movement would already be available without the body, and none of its faculties or instruments would contribute to attaining that goal. Even if attachment were conceded, genuine perfection would then have to be attained when the attachment ends in death.

It may be objected that the attachment can impart something preventing attainment. We reply that perfection would then have to have been available before attachment, or else its attainment would be impossible altogether, since after attachment the impediments prevent it. The soul should therefore never have become attached: its perfected goal would already be available without attachment, and attachment would obstruct it. In substance, one of two things must follow: either attachment does not entail the acquisition of impediments, or the soul has no need of the body for attaining its goals and is intrinsically independent of it.

The objector may answer that this follows only if attachment yields impediments alone. Just as it can impart obstructive dispositions in some subjects, it may impart other dispositions functioning as causes and conditions in others. We reply that the objector has now returned to the truth and conceded what was denied. The first point to be established is precisely that bodily sensory faculties and material instruments can prepare the soul for perfected goals when employed appropriately for appropriate objects. When employed otherwise, they necessarily yield dispositions obstructing their proper use and consequently impede perfection.

As for the second point, the philosophical works establish that the Principle intrinsically bestows all cognitions and realities, being the treasury preserving them. Premises from which conclusions are drawn are only preparations for receiving that bestowal.

It should not be objected that the Principle would not then bestow through itself, since its bestowal depends on the recipient's preparedness. The recipient's need for preparatory causes and conditions in receiving does not contradict the agent's independence of them in bestowing. The path of purification itself requires analogous preparations: emptying the receptacle, purifying the inward being, directing it toward the Principle, and the other recognized conditions already described.

QT-060 — Two legitimate routes to unveiled knowledge, both requiring purification

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA

> We further say that all the sciences are already present within us, as reflection upon the earlier discussions will show, but they remain hidden behind veils preventing their manifestation. They can become manifest in one way through subtle, spiritual movements of discursive thought, after the holy faculty has been given mastery over estimation, imagination, and the other bodily faculties and after the character has been refined and the soul adorned with good qualities. They can become manifest in another way through stilling estimation and imagination, bridling them and restraining their confused movements once the bodily faculties have been disciplined through purification and clarification. Most accomplished investigators, whether rational scholars or practitioners of spiritual exertion, accept both paths as legitimate. As the quoted verse puts it: 'Take the inner slope of Harshā or its far side: either side affords a path.' Someone who believes that purification and refinement of character have no place in teaching and rational inquiry follows caprice and whim. Appetite and anger dominate the soul, destructive natural vices take possession of it, and angelic, loving virtues are denied to it. Such a person devotes himself to the books of imitators of philosophers and to contentious theologians, wasting his life memorising contradictory opinions and rival statements. Tossed into a sea of corrupt imaginings and false suppositions amid overwhelming waves of doubts, the light of his heart fades and his insight is blinded by the accumulation of obscuring conditions and false beliefs. Ignorance and hesitation intensify; perplexity takes hold; he no longer knows which way to turn, and the wrath of the Real overtakes him. Yet he supposes that the learning he has acquired is the whole of perfection and that there is no more desirable state or abiding felicity beyond it. Let him recognize, through God's grace, the corruption and harm of this belief, and seek refuge in Him from His devising and wrath.

SH-060 — Two routes to knowledge, both requiring ordered character and faculties

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: having established the validity of purification and reflective inquiry under the rules of those who reason by inference, the author explains them in accordance with the previously established principles of realization. The later discussions thereby join the earlier in a coherent order. Those principles establish that no divine reality or cosmic level lies outside what the human heart and subtle reality already contain in actuality, as a whole contains its parts and a universal its particulars. Yet accumulated dark material coverings and bodily veils and impediments have obscured their effects and concealed their lights. These coverings must therefore be removed so that what is latent can emerge into manifestation and direct vision, making cognitions and realities apparent and distinguishing their relations and subtle connections.

This can occur in two ways. One employs subtle discursive movements after the holy spiritual faculty has gained mastery over estimation, imagination, and the other bodily

powers, producing refinement of character and adorning the soul with praiseworthy dispositions. The other quiets estimation and imagination, restraining their confused movements after subduing bodily powers through purification. Accomplished reflective investigators and practitioners of spiritual exertion acknowledge both paths as true.

‘Take the inner slope of Harshā or its far side:
either side provides a road for them.’

The coverings and veils arise because particular bodily powers—like workers and artisans in the kingdom of human reality—have gained ascendancy over the balanced subtle heart, the true ruler, and its helpers, the spiritual intellectual faculties. There are two ways to govern the kingdom. One strengthens the ruler and supports his helpers, establishing their command over the bodily powers so that these cannot depart from the particular tasks assigned to them for the kingdom's order. All are subject to the ruler's command, allowing his effects and governing properties—knowledge and cognition—to appear.

The other removes those bodily powers from their governing positions, stills them, and restrains their distracting movements after subduing their auxiliaries and weakening them through purification. The ruler can then manifest his effects.

Purification—the restraint of bodily powers from overstepping their bounds in the human kingdom and from confused, disturbing movements—is therefore necessary in both paths. In the first, it follows from establishing mastery and is intended secondarily; without it, mastery would not be achieved. In the second, it is intended primarily, and mastery follows from it. Someone who believes that purification has no place in instruction and reflective inquiry follows appetite and caprice, and the outcome is the harm described in the matn. We seek refuge in God from the evils of our souls and deeds. Whomever God guides is guided; for whomever He lets go astray, no protecting guide will be found. The book's wording here is clear and needs no further explanation.

QT-061 — The final criterion: logic, contradictory unveilings, rational preparation, and the perfected teacher

> ORIGINAL MATN · ABŪ ḤĀMID TURKA
>
> A subtle point remains, one useful inquiry to which we must allude briefly. Know that those who pursue rational investigation and formal instruction possess a science by which sound reasoning can be distinguished from unsound reasoning, and the true aspect of a matter can be distinguished from the false. The travellers of the path who practise spiritual exertion do not possess an instrument of precisely this description. If they object that their knowledge is immediately experienced, and just as necessary knowledge given in direct awareness needs no instrumental science to distinguish it, so their knowledge obtained through spiritual taste and immediate finding requires none, our reply is that what one spiritual traveller experiences may contradict what another

> experiences. Indeed, practitioners sometimes reject one another's perceptions and cognitions. Once this is understood, we say that those who follow the path of spiritual exertion must first acquire the genuine discursive and theoretical sciences, after purifying their hearts by severing darkening attachments and refining and ordering their dispositions, so that those sciences—including the instrumental discipline that discriminates correct from incorrect thinking—will stand in relation to experiential cognitions much as logic stands in relation to theoretical sciences not already coherent and systematically ordered. Then, if the seeker becomes perplexed and reaches an impasse on a question not resolved by discursive reasoning, he may attain it by the other path and discern its true aspect through the stable intellectual dispositions acquired from his theoretical studies. This applies where he has no perfecting spiritual master to guide him at every station and stage. A full treatment of this question would require a lengthy discussion beyond this brief treatise. This is the end of what we intended to present in this epistle. Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds, and blessings and peace upon His Prophet Muḥammad the Chosen and his pure family.

SH-061-C — Why the final subtle point concerns a criterion of knowledge

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

I say: having explained the treatise's objectives, the path leading to them, and the answers to the doubts raised against them, the author wished to conclude with a particularly useful point and an inquiry often needed by travellers of the best path. Establishing its foundations and explaining its basis would require discussions too lengthy for this brief work, so he must be content with a delicate indication and a slight allusion, perceptible only to discerning readers acquainted with the principles of the disciplines. Hence he entitled it a subtle point. Its explanation is this. The thought often occurs that reflective investigators and those engaged in formal instruction, who acquire cognitions and truths through arguments and demonstrations, possess an instrumental science. They employ it to attain what they seek and to distinguish sound reasoning that yields truth from defective reasoning. It also enables them to know what is true and why it is true, and what is false and why it is false. Travellers engaged in spiritual exertion do not possess an instrument of that kind. Knowledge acquired in the former manner would evidently be more complete and perfected than knowledge obtained through assorted, unspecified procedures; their path would therefore seem more secure.

SH-061-D — Immediate experience does not settle disagreement among experiencers

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

It may be objected that the knowledge of those who practise spiritual exertion belongs to immediate experiential cognitions, which are necessary. Just as reflective investigators

need no discriminating instrumental discipline or rule to obtain and recognize their necessary cognitions, neither do practitioners need one for knowledge acquired through spiritual taste and immediate experience. We reply that this would follow only if their cognitions were unqualified experiential certainties shared by all travellers, which they are not. What one traveller finds may contradict what another finds. For this reason, practitioners sometimes reject one another's experiential apprehensions and the knowledge obtained through their immediate experiences and unveilings.

SH-061-E — Different capacities still require a discriminating measure

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

An objection may be made that the differences between travellers in their knowledge and experiences arise only from differences in strength of preparedness. A less capable practitioner apprehends a meaning, supposes it to be the final attainment, stops there without going beyond it, and binds himself to it in an unshakeable conviction. A stronger practitioner encompasses in his apprehension what the weaker regards as the goal, goes beyond it, and reaches what is higher and more complete. He therefore objects to the other's stopping and fixing his conviction there—not to the content of the conviction itself, but to its restriction and confinement to that content. We reply that, even granting this account, the weaker practitioner would not have fallen into that error or stopped there had he possessed an instrument of discrimination. Testing that attainment against the measure would have disclosed its deficiency. He would not have rested in complete assurance but would have sought something higher and more perfect.

SH-061-F — Intellectual formation as a trained capacity to discriminate truth

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

Once this is understood, we say that practitioners of spiritual exertion who travel the path of reality with earnest application must acquire discursive sciences and certain theoretical knowledge, after purifying their hearts of the taint of external attachments by severing what darkens them and adorning themselves with noble and praiseworthy character. These theoretical sciences, including the instrumental discipline of discrimination, will then stand in relation to experiential cognitions as logic stands in relation to theoretical sciences not already coherent and systematically ordered. The stable capacity acquired through these certain theoretical studies must distinguish certainties from other cognitions. It is like the trained capacities acquired through mastery of poetic metres or musical modes: they enable a person to distinguish what is correctly measured from what is not, even where a person merely reasoning about it remains perplexed. If the diligent traveller acquires that capacity and then encounters perplexity in his seeking and travelling, reaching an impasse on a question not attained through discursive thought, this excellent capacity enables him to bring it to light and explain its truth to a discerning seeker of guidance. Such a condition

is plainly more complete in both attaining perfection and perfecting others than one lacking this capacity.

SH-061-A — The guide and the measure proper to each station

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

All of this applies when the seeker has no master of the path to direct him and no perfecting guide to emulate, one who holds the keys to his actions and states. If, however, he does have such a guide, then every stage and station has sciences and a measure proper to it, according to the time and the seeker's capacity. The guide, discerning the successive degrees of that capacity, draws the traveller's attention to those sciences and their appropriate measures.

SH-061-B — The commentator's own conclusion

SHARḤ · ṢĀʾIN AL-DĪN IBN TURKA

But a full examination of this matter and an exposition of the rules governing it would require lengthy investigations unsuitable for brief works such as this. Let us therefore be content with what has been said in these commentaries, praising God, Lord of the worlds, and invoking blessings upon Muḥammad, his good and pure family, and all his Companions.